

The Delta of Worlds

Book 1

Essence of Stone

Prologue

I was nine years old when the first Gate appeared on Earth. I remember that day clearly. Every news channel was talking about it, every headline repeating the same thing: at last, humanity had made contact with an alien civilization. The greatest event in human history. The world was about to change. Unimaginable horizons were opening before us.

A couple of months later, the second Gate appeared. Then the third. Then more, one after another—until there were eight of them.

By now, everyone knows what the Gates look like and who the Creatures are. Still, it's probably worth describing them. I didn't only see the Gates on the news—I saw one of them in person. Shortly after the first Gate appeared, my parents, like millions of others, went on a guided tour to see it, and they took me along. These trips are still a popular form of entertainment to this day.

A Gate is a massive arch—or more precisely, a half-circle the size of a rainbow. They always rise above forested mountains, because they appear exclusively in mountainous, wooded regions, always near either a mountain river or a lake. Why the Gates emerged in places like that, no one knows.

Each end of a Gate seems to grow straight out of the ground or the mountainside. Some people even believe that a Gate isn't really a half-circle at all, but a full circle, with its lower half hidden underground. Maybe that's true. Or maybe it's just idle speculation.

The surface of a Gate is a pale gray haze, constantly in motion. Lighter patches drift slowly across it, flowing, changing shape, growing brighter and dimmer. There is something ominous about that movement—something deeply unsettling. Looking at a Gate is difficult. After just a minute, your head starts to spin, nausea creeps in, your mood darkens. The longer you stare, the worse it gets. People who live near the Gates have learned to simply look away. That helps: if you only catch the Gate out of the corner of your eye, without focusing on it, you feel fine.

From either side, a Gate looks the same. But from the edge, it simply isn't there. The Gates have zero thickness. When viewed from an angle, they narrow like any flat object, but unlike everything else, they narrow all the way down—to nothing. If you look at a Gate perfectly edge-on, with one eye, it vanishes completely. A colossal wall stretching into the sky simply disappears. It's very strange—and, to me at least, a little disturbing.

The Creatures—or, as they're sometimes called, the Beings—emerge from the Gates, wander across Earth, and then return—either into the same Gate or into a different one. No one can make sense of their routes. They seem to be just... walking. Or perhaps traveling.

The Creatures vary wildly in shape and, it feels, in their very nature. One might look like a jet-black, viscous mass, slowly flowing in on itself. Another resembles a crystalline sphere, bouncing across the ground in a way that defies explanation. Yet another might be nothing more than a drifting cluster of chaotic, glowing points of light.

Creatures have names—and a curious, almost charming habit of announcing their names when they approach someone, as if introducing themselves. They don't do this with sound. Somehow, they transmit a thought, and the person hears a name inside their head. Names like *Ink-Puddle*, *Bubble*, or *So-Many-Bees*. Often—though not always—the names artistically reflect the Creature's appearance. In that sense, they feel less like names and more like nicknames, or even descriptive labels.

There are rumors that some people have seen humans emerge from the Gates the same way the Creatures do—not by walking through them. Anyone can pass through a Gate the normal way: you simply step into it and instantly appear on the other side, as if walking through a sheet of light or a thin strip of fog. I've done it many times myself. You don't feel anything at all.

But Creatures never emerge from the opposite side of a Gate. They come from somewhere else—and leave to somewhere else through them.

So, every now and then, people claim they've seen humans appear from the Gates the same way Creatures do. There's no proof, though. Most likely, it's just rumors and imagination.

There's one more thing that happens around the Gates: Storms. But these aren't storms in the usual sense—not just bad weather. They're something else entirely. Suddenly, energy erupts from a Gate and explodes outward in all directions, twisting and spiraling—flares and clots of pale gray haze, just like what you see inside the Gates themselves. It all comes with hurricane-force winds and horizontal lightning flashing across the air.

Despite how terrifying they look, Storms have never killed anyone. Still, being inside a Storm—standing exposed in the path of that rushing flow—is nearly impossible. People experience an intensely unpleasant, almost unbearable pressure of unknown origin. It feels like pain and suffering, both physical and psychological at once. You can't resist it. The only option is to take cover—behind thick walls, cliffs, or any sufficiently massive obstacle that shields you from the rushing flow.

Fortunately, the farther you are from a Gate, the weaker a Storm becomes. A few kilometers out, it's still unpleasant, but tolerable. A few dozen kilometers farther, it turns into little more than mild bad weather: stronger winds, faint pale ripples in the air like scraps of mist, and for some people—especially those sensitive to weather—a slight pressure in the temples.

Storms are short-lived, usually lasting about an hour. They happen roughly once a week, each time at a different Gate. Sometimes there's a gap of two or three weeks. Occasionally, two Storms happen back-to-back, though that's rare. But more than two Storms in a single week? That has never happened.

So, as I said before, looking at the Gates is unpleasant—and increasingly so. They can't be photographed or filmed: recordings show nothing but blurry, shapeless smears. In fact, the Gates can't be registered by any instruments at all. That's one reason—but not the only one—why studying the Gates, the Storms, and especially the Creatures has failed.

The other, more fundamental reason is the same physical and psychological pressure people experience—not only inside a Storm, but even when trying to approach a Creature, whether to capture it, restrain it, or simply measure it. Intense physical discomfort sets in, along with fear, depression, and apathy. It all escalates quickly, until it becomes completely unbearable.

Because of all this, the global fascination that followed the appearance of the Gates—along with interest in Storms, Creatures, and everything connected to them—faded surprisingly fast. Researchers abandoned their projects one by one. They said they were losing motivation. That thinking about it felt heavy. Scientists seemed to forget why they had started in the first place. Studies were shut down. Institutes, laboratories, entire research centers created during the initial frenzy were closed. Eventually, it all came to nothing.

That's how it happened that the Gates, the Storms, and the Creatures became... ordinary.

They turned into part of nature—no different from mountains and rivers, fish and birds, ordinary storms and hurricanes. People still travel to see the Gates. They still smile when they "hear" a Creature's name. They still take shelter from Storms. But now it's no different from visiting a beautiful waterfall or an oddly shaped mountain, from hiding from a hurricane or a flood, from reacting to an animal in the forest or a bird on a branch.

Born as the greatest sensation in human history, the Gates—and everything connected to them—became part of everyday life.

Chapter 1. The Ninth Gate

Until that day, I had never woken up with a premonition. Nothing had happened—nothing that I could point to—yet I woke up. Exactly at 5:30. The clock was right there in front of my eyes.

And I didn't just wake up. I *knew* something was about to happen.

I had to get up. Going back to sleep felt impossible.

I sat up, swung my legs over the edge of the bed. Then stood. Just stood there for a moment, looking around. The feeling was bizarre: part of me wanted to run somewhere—anywhere—and part of me wanted to crawl back under the blanket and hide.

I went to the window.

Everything looked normal. Our gorge. The mountains on both sides—green, spring-green. A thin mist rising off the river. Familiar. Ordinary. Exactly the way it always was.

And yet... something was wrong.

In the gap between the mountains—where the sky was especially blue—and in the mist below, there was something *off*. And inside me, something went cold. Not because of anything specific. Just... fear. Fear isn't usually logical.

My mornings were usually simple: coffee, shower, clothes, a light breakfast, then work. But that day I just stood at the window, and one thought kept repeating itself:

You need to leave. Now. Get out of the house as fast as you can.

I didn't want coffee. I wanted—outside.

I dressed quickly, almost feverishly, and went out. When I opened the door, I inhaled air that felt cold and... blue, somehow, mixed with morning fog. And suddenly I felt—how good it was to be alive.

Just to be alive.

I closed the door, stuffed my keys into my pocket, and started walking. I didn't know where. Fear was leading me. Not fear *of* something—just fear as a state, as a pressure inside my chest. There was nowhere to hide from it. There was only one thing left to do.

Run.

So I ran.

I ran, gasping, not understanding why or where. The village street fell behind and turned into a tourist trail. It led downhill, almost to the river, then curved sharply and climbed up toward the road—the one that went to the center, to the cafés and little shops.

I ran downhill. And the fear started to ease.

Suddenly. Fast.

By the time I reached the bend in the trail, it was gone completely.

I stopped.

In front of me, the mountains opened into a V-shaped cut. Outside the V, everything was a saturated green. Inside it, the sky was a hard, brilliant blue. To the left, the river; above it, ragged strips of white mist. The sun was somewhere behind the mountain, but its light was already spilling over the peaks.

I stood there thinking about the sun. For some reason, only the sun.

And then it started.

The world distorted.

It was like an old television set. The horizon split vertically, and the left half began to *slide* into the right. It swallowed almost half the gap between the mountains—and part of the right slope, too.

There was a sound. Not a hum. Not a crash. Not a sigh. Something in between. Something enormous had been pulled tight. But there isn't a word for that sound.

There was no fear anymore. None at all.

I stood there, watching, breathing. My heart was beating—I could feel it—but everything else had gone still.

Time stretched. Every second lasted forever. And all at once it seemed to me that I understood what death was.

As if I had already died.

Then the two halves of the world began to slide back into place. Slowly. Calmly. And between them—about a hundred meters from me—a half-circle took shape.

A Gate.

I knew it immediately. The familiar gray haze was there at its center. At first the Gate was small. Then it widened, almost as if it were overtaking the edges of the horizon as they moved back into alignment. And while the horizon returned to normal, the Gate grew to its full, ordinary size.

Now it rose in front of me in all its magnitude.

A new Gate.

The ninth.

You'd think that would be the end of it.

It wasn't.

A second shift came—this time not in the world, but in me. I didn't *hear* it with my ears. I heard it with my whole body:

UWE-E-E-OOO!!!

It wasn't a sound. It was a sensation. Not outside—inside my skull, in my chest, in my stomach. A wave of violent dizziness rolled through me. Nausea surged.

My legs buckled. I fell.

And then came the third thing.

Something like a shriek.

A torrent of information—too much, too fast. As if my brain had been pumped full until it burst.

Then—silence. Darkness. I blacked out.

When consciousness returned, it returned at once. Not painfully. Lightly. Joyfully.

I was lying on my back in grass, staring up at a bright blue sky. The sun was shining. The air was warm. The grass smelled fresh. Everything was good.

Not because of anything. Without thoughts. Without reasons.

Just... good.

I stood up, looked forward—and saw the Gate.

What I saw nearly took my legs out from under me again. I recoiled, but stayed upright.

The Gate had changed.

The gray haze was gone. Inside the Gate there was sky, mountains, forest. Everything was blurred, shimmering with a kind of ripple, but there was no doubt: it was a mountain landscape.

And yet, the sense of a wall hadn't disappeared. The Gate still had a surface. It wasn't empty space. It was more like a vertical sheet of water—transparent, alive, with waves and ripples running across it. You could see through it, clearly enough to recognize what lay beyond, but never sharply, never fully in focus.

The outline of the horizon was similar to the V-shape the Gate was blocking now—but it was still slightly different.

Everything inside the Gate was almost like ours.

But not ours.

And looking at the Gate no longer felt unpleasant, the way it always had before. Still, I made myself look away.

My first impulse was to go in. Step through. Find out what was there. I almost took a step.

Almost.

But I stopped.

That's probably how people die—throwing themselves into the unknown. The Gate was here. New. Yes. But nothing else would change in the next minute. For some reason, I knew that. So there was no need to rush.

I turned and walked away.

Home.

I walked, staring at the rocky road. It angled left and up, around the mountain. I glanced back.

The Gate—new in every sense of the word—was still there.

I saw the first Creature emerge. It looked like a turtle shell, green, sliding in a zigzag motion. Then a second. A third.

And then one of them seemed to me like...

A human.

A young man in a reddish-brown jacket, dark pants, and high boots. Light hair to his shoulders. He stepped out after one of the Creatures, looked around—

and saw me.

I spun and ran.

Almost immediately I disappeared around the mountain, and I felt that moment physically—like the Gate and whatever was happening behind me had been cut off by rock. I slowed to a walk. A fast walk.

I headed home.

More than anything in the world, I wanted to be inside my house.

I remember the rest of the way poorly. I only remember seeing my bed, collapsing face-down onto it—and falling asleep.

When I woke up, sunlight was blazing outside the window.

The clock read 10:30.

Chapter 2. Art

It's probably time to say a little about myself.

My name is Mac.

I was born and raised on the Islands—somewhere between fog, soft grass, and tea with milk. The town was small and cozy, with identical houses and never-ending rain. My parents still live there, but we hardly keep in touch. In our family, this has been the tradition for generations: parents give their children an education, consider their duty fulfilled, leave them alone—and expect the same in return.

I graduated from university—some dull department, I can't even remember the name. After that, I decided to see a bit of the world before diving into office slavery. A few countries, a few continents, a few adventures—until the money ran out. That's when I got a job as a zipline instructor. I ferried tourists along a cable stretched over a canyon. Lived alone in a rented cottage at the edge of the village. Quiet. Simple. Somehow... right.

So, that was my life. And now I can go back to that day.

I woke up late—at 10:30, for the second time that morning. I lay there without opening my eyes, feeling sunlight seep through the curtains. Something in me had changed. And the change was for the better. A new kind of calm confidence had appeared—not about anything specific, just in general. Confidence in myself, in my actions, in the future. Along with it came a sense of quiet goodwill—a steady, benevolent attitude toward people and the world around me. And for some reason, I immediately knew this wasn't a passing mood. This was the state I would be in from now on.

I opened my eyes, turned my head—and instantly sat upright.

There was a guy sitting on a chair by the table.

That guy. The one I'd seen earlier that morning, stepping out of the Gate. He was looking at me and smiling.

A reddish-brown jacket, dark pants, heavy boots. A backpack stood nearby. He looked as if he'd simply dropped by for a visit.

Except no one had knocked.

"Hi," he said. "Hope I didn't scare you too much."

"Uh..." I tried to gather my thoughts. "You..."

"Yes. I'm the one you saw. My name's Art."

I slowly got up from the bed. He stood as well and held out his hand. I stepped forward and shook it.

He was a little older than me. Light, shoulder-length curly hair, refined, non-angular features. Calm, attentive eyes. Good-looking—too good-looking not to notice. I'd been called handsome myself, but I noted that his appearance was almost the opposite of mine, with my short black hair and rather plain face.

But it wasn't about looks.

There was something about him... stable. Strength. Confidence. Calm. And all of it without posing, without any hint of showmanship. Like sunlight: it's just there—and everything feels better because of it. And then, looking at him, I was struck by how closely the feeling coming from him matched the one I'd felt—and was still feeling—inside myself.

He sat back down, leaning comfortably against the chair.

"So, what's your name?"

"Mac," I said, stepping back and sitting on the bed.

"Well, there we are. Nice to meet you. I saw you there. Right beyond the Gate. Followed you. Saw you come into this house. Went in—you were asleep. So I took a walk around the area. Got back just a couple of minutes before you woke up."

"So you saw the Gate from the inside?" I asked—the question I'd wanted to ask the whole time, and been afraid to.

"Yes. I went in as soon as it appeared. Usually I wait for the right Variant, but this time I didn't. Felt like I had to go right away. Saw you. Decided that wasn't a coincidence."

We fell silent. Then, struggling to find the words, I asked:

"So... you came from another world?"

"Another Variant," he corrected gently. "There are eight of them. Or rather—there were eight. Now, as I understand it, there are nine."

I sat on the edge of the bed and leaned forward.

"Wait. What do you mean? Variants of what?"

He raised an eyebrow, looking at me with a faint smile.

"One thing at a time. You'll learn a lot. But first, let's eat. You've been sleeping all morning, and I've managed to work up quite an appetite."

I exhaled, relaxing a little.

"Alright, let's go have breakfast," I smiled. "There's a place here—Lemar's. Their fried eggs are almost legendary."

He smiled back. Then easily picked up his backpack and slung it over his shoulders.

"Perfect. I like legends."

We stepped outside. The Gate was still there. It cut violently into the now-familiar landscape. On the road, I saw far more people than usual, along with several Creatures. People—alone or in groups—were mostly heading toward the Gate. The Creatures, meanwhile, were moving in the opposite direction.

Of course, I thought. A brand-new global sensation. Tourists would be swarming the place now.

We headed toward the center of town. Art looked around with a light, almost childlike curiosity. That warm curiosity was contagious. I looked around too—and saw everything with new eyes. The air had warmed slightly, but still held its morning freshness. A gentle breeze brushed my face. The mountains, the trees, the sky above them all seemed subtly different—newly, distinctly beautiful. The world felt as if it were smiling at me, and I wanted to smile back.

Lemar's café looked the same as ever—a small building with an open terrace, a peeling sign, and a slightly crooked door. Lemar himself stood behind the counter: massive, round-faced, eternally sleepy-eyed, with his trademark sly smile.

"Mac!" He spotted me and broke into a wide grin. "Well, I'll be damned. You're late today. And with a friend?"

"Lemar, meet Art. He arrived yesterday on a passing bus."

Art shook his hand, smiling.

"Nice to meet you. I've already heard about your fried eggs."

"Whoever told you didn't lie," Lemar said importantly. "Sit down. I'll take care of you."

As expected, the place was more crowded than usual, but we found a free table by the window. Sitting down, Art casually took off his backpack and set it beside him.

Lemar brought lemonade first, in fogged glasses. Then fresh, still-warm buns on a wooden plate, and three small wooden boards with farmhouse butter: plain, garlic, and herb. After that came two enormous plates of fried eggs. They had everything: three eggs with crisped edges, bacon, sausages, beans, and a mound of vegetable salad.

We dug in. Art ate Lemar's eggs slowly, with obvious pleasure, paying equal tribute to the signature lemonade. I tried to keep up, glancing at him and feeling oddly proud—as if I'd cooked it all myself. Exchanging satisfied looks from time to time, we finished our plates. Lemar, who had seemed not to watch us at all, immediately appeared with a tray holding two large clay mugs of coffee. The aroma alone made my head spin. As always, he said nothing, maintaining a deliberately indifferent expression, as if our opinion of his cooking didn't interest him in the slightest.

"I've never had a breakfast like this," Art said, looking at Lemar with genuine delight. "Nothing even close."

A proud, self-satisfied smile flickered across Lemar's face, but he immediately returned to his indifferent look.

"Just fried eggs. The way they're supposed to be," he muttered, clearing the table and leaving only our mugs. "Drink your coffee. Wave if you want more."

"Alright," I said when Lemar returned to the counter. "Now tell me."

Art took a solid sip of coffee, glanced at the mug with clear approval—and began.

Chapter 3. The Delta

"This is called the Delta," Art was explaining. "The Delta of worlds—or, officially, Variants.

"You know how it works with a river: first there's a single channel, then it splits into two, then into more and more branches. The same thing happened with the world. A very long time ago, it split in two—that was the first Rift. Later, in one of those worlds, a second Rift occurred. Then, in another one, a third.

"When exactly this happened, and how many Rifts there have been in total—we don't know. Which means we also don't know how many Variants exist overall. We only know about the ones connected by Gates. There used to be eight of them. Now there are nine. Officially, they're called Variant One, Variant Two, and so on. But most people just call them worlds."

He paused, then continued:

"The worlds are different, of course—but they also have a lot in common. For example, the languages people speak in different worlds are almost identical. No one knows exactly why. There is one explanation I personally agree with. I'll tell you about it some other time."

I was listening, hardly breathing. At first, it was shocking.

Then astonishing.

Then simply fascinating.

"So you're from the first world?" I asked.

"Yes. From Variant One. It's considered the first because we were the first to learn how to walk through the Gates. Or rather—to understand who could do it."

"And who can?" I asked.

"We can. Striders."

"Who?"

"Striders. That's what we're called. We can walk through the Gates because our Essence level is higher than that of ordinary people. Roughly twice as high. And that's exactly the threshold every Gate has."

"Wait. Hold on. Essence?" I said. "What is that?"

Art's expression grew serious. I understood immediately: what he was about to say mattered.

"Officially, it's called Quintessence. But most people just say Essence. Or even shorter—quinta. Quintessence is both energy and substance at the same time. It's the essence of the world itself, of all living beings. The essence of existence. It's present in every person, in all living things. And it's also present in everything else—in the surrounding world."

"Wait," I interrupted. I felt like something crucial had just slipped past me. "So this... Essence—is it only in living beings? Only where there's life? Or is it everywhere?"

He smiled slightly and nodded, clearly pleased.

"Good question. Essence is everywhere. But every living being—unlike inanimate matter—has a contour. A boundary that holds its own Essence inside. It's like a small, personal world contained within the larger one. Living beings can take in Essence or give it away, raising or lowering their internal level, and that level is maintained within the contour—within the living body. At the moment of death, that contour disappears. In inanimate objects, or in certain places, Essence levels can also be higher or lower—but those fluctuations have no boundary. Essence gradually diffuses, merging back into the surrounding baseline level."

"And what is the baseline level?" I asked.

He nodded again, still looking at me with the same focused seriousness.

“One hundred quint. Essence level—or, as it’s sometimes called, Essence tension—is measured in quint. One quint is one hundredth of the level all Essence in the universe naturally tends toward. In a vacuum, for example, Essence is exactly at one hundred quint. The quantity of Essence is measured in amphoras. One amphora is ten liters of Essence at baseline level. In everyday speech, people often call one-tenth of an amphora simply a liter.”

He fell silent, giving me time to absorb all of it.

We sat quietly for a while. Then I said:

“I think I’ve stopped being surprised. I’ve probably reached the upper limit of what’s possible.”

He chuckled softly.

“And that’s the right approach.”

I tried to formulate my next question. There were so many of them that I couldn’t decide where to begin. And then I realized there was one question that mattered more than all the others.

“Art,” I said. “Tell me... am I also a Strider?”

Smiling, he leaned back in his chair, tilted his head slightly to the side, narrowed his eyes—and said:

“About time you figured it out. Yes, Mac. You’re a Strider too. You can walk through the Gates into other worlds.”

Even though, deep down, I’d been expecting that answer, it still shook me. Or rather, what shook me was the feeling that came with it. A realization that I was now living in a different world—a new one. A world far larger than before. Not nine times larger, but infinitely so. Immeasurably larger.

I listened to myself—and suddenly understood that I felt no fear. No discomfort. On the contrary, I felt dizzy with something impossibly pleasant. And I recognized it at once.

I felt free.

It took me a few minutes to fully come back to myself. All that time, Art sat there, leaning back, watching me attentively and sipping his coffee. When he saw that I was finally “okay,” he smiled and raised his mug in a lightly ironic salute.

“Welcome, Mac.”

I lifted my mug and finished the nearly cold coffee. Art turned toward Lemar, pointed at our empty cups, and gave him a disarmingly polite, almost apologetic smile. Lemar nodded in understanding. Art inclined his head in a small bow of thanks. We waited until Lemar brought us two fresh mugs of coffee, and once he’d gone, I asked:

“Why can I pass through the Gates? And why can you? Why are we striders, and others aren’t?”

“I was near a forming Nugget during a Storm,” Art said. “That’s how it happened. That’s the main—almost the only—way people become striders. Your case is a very rare exception. You were nearby when the new Gate appeared.”

I didn’t fully understand everything yet, but I nodded anyway.

“Tell me about the striders,” I said. “What do you actually do? Do you just wander from world to world like these tourists?”

I nodded toward the people at the neighboring tables.

Sipping his steaming coffee with obvious pleasure, Art explained.

During Storms, Essence accumulates in certain places—mostly in stone, rock, and other solid matter. Large concentrations of Essence are called Nuggets. The main occupation of striders is Essence picking—also known as quint-picking, or simply picking: finding Nuggets and extracting Essence from them. That’s why striders are also called pickers, though the two terms aren’t the same. *Strider* refers to an ability; *picker* is an occupation, a profession.

Pickers, Art continued, come in two kinds: Greens and Reds.

Greens—Art included—are government employees, agents of the Agency for the Regulation of Quintessence, or ARC. They turn in the Essence they collect to ARC storage facilities, from where it’s distributed and used where it’s needed most. Mostly in medicine—primarily to save lives in cases where nothing else can. When Essence reserves exceed medical needs, the surplus is allocated to scientific and even creative institutions, where it’s used by people with exceptional scientific or artistic talent. It helps them make breakthroughs, create masterpieces.

Red pickers, on the other hand, keep the Essence they collect for themselves. They sell it on the black market or consume it personally. They exploit one of Essence’s fundamental properties: when it’s released from a person’s internal contour into the surrounding world, that person experiences powerful, euphoric sensations. In that sense, Essence—quinta—is a perfect drug.

After listening and thinking it all through, I asked what seemed to me the obvious question:

“And me? Can I become a picker?”

He looked at me very closely.

“A Green or a Red?”

The question genuinely surprised me.

“A Green, of course. Like you.”

He let out a restrained breath—relief, it seemed to me.

“I think so. Yes. I’d like you to be with us.”

We sat in silence for a while, each lost in our own thoughts. Then he drained his coffee in one swallow, glanced at the empty mug with mild regret, and said:

“A new Gate means a massive Essence release. There should be plenty of good Nuggets around here. Want to take a walk and look for some?”

I grinned and finished my coffee as well.

“Is that even a question?”

Chapter 4. Essence

Leaving a generous tip for Lemar, we stepped out onto the central square. I immediately noticed how much everything had changed. At this hour it was usually spacious here—tourists already scattered along their routes, locals sitting in cafés. Today, it was a sea of people. Several tourist buses, an overflowing parking lot, TV cameras, microphones, reporters with bright press badges. Our new Gate was already in every news broadcast.

I also noticed several Creatures, as usual moving unhurriedly among the tourists and journalists, who paid them almost no attention. What caught my eye was that all the Creatures were heading in the same direction—away from the Gate. Apparently, I thought, they had all just come through the new Gate from other Variants.

“So, where to?” I asked.

“Let’s take a walk,” Art replied, slipping his other arm through the backpack strap and adjusting it on his shoulders. “Across the bridge.”

The bridge spanned the canyon. The view was mesmerizing: the river far below, shreds of mist drifting above it, sheer cliffs and pine-covered slopes on both sides. We walked in silence. The wind brushed our faces, and in that quiet it felt as if the rest of the world had dissolved.

“Essence,” Art began, “is everywhere. In the air, in the water, in the ground. But it can only stabilize in solid matter—primarily in stone.

“When Storms happen—and they’re essentially Essence ejections from the Gates—it settles and accumulates. Most of the time, it forms light, unstable clusters. But when conditions align, nuggets form. That happens when the Storm’s flow creates vortices, like small tornadoes. Such a vortex has to form close to rock or stone—somewhere Essence can anchor and stabilize, forming a nugget.

“As you move farther from the Gate, both the size and number of nuggets drop. That’s why we start picking right at the Gate and move through our sectors, gradually increasing the distance—until the nuggets become too scarce and too small to be worth the effort.”

He spoke calmly, slightly off to the side, almost as if talking to himself—but I knew this explanation was for me. For who I had become.

“Nuggets vary in shape, size, and level. We call it depth. Not depth in the ground, but internal depth—the Essence level inside the cluster. Some nuggets reach several hundred quintis in depth and contain hundreds of amphoras of Essence. A regular human has five to ten amphoras, seven on average, depending on body type. So a single nugget can hold as much Essence as dozens of people.”

“And the biggest ones?” I asked.

“They say some exceed a thousand amphoras. I’ve never seen one.”

On the far side of the bridge, a narrow trail began, running along the canyon. Tourists rarely went that way. We turned onto it. To the right—a slope and a drop. To the left—rock faces.

“Can you actually see them?” I asked. “The nuggets. The clusters?”

Art pulled a pair of glasses from the inner pocket of his jacket. Thin, almost invisible frames. Light, transparent lenses. When he put them on, they seemed to merge with his face. Then he took out a second pair.

“This is called a Mask. We usually carry two—one as a backup.”

He handed the second Mask to me. I put it on. It fit perfectly, as if it had been made for my face. I looked around—and saw exactly the same thing as before.

“Nothing unusual.”

“And now?”

The image shifted. A nearly transparent green layer appeared. Not a color, but light—shimmering, fluid. Like looking through emerald glass. What was especially striking was that the green of the grass and leaves stayed the same, while this was something else entirely. An inner glow. I looked at Art—and saw his contour glowing. Mine was even brighter.

“That’s Essence?” I asked.

“Yes.”

He explained. The Mask was a device that allowed you to see different layers of what we call augmented reality. Some of those layers displayed sensor data built into the Mask. One of them was an Essence-field sensor. But that sensor only worked when the Mask was worn by someone with a high Essence level—by a strider. On ordinary people, it didn’t activate, unless there was an external source involved. I didn’t fully grasp all of it, and Art promised to explain it in more detail later.

I took off the Mask and noticed tiny lenses embedded in the frame—like cameras, only miniature.

“It’s controlled mentally,” Art said. “That’s called n2e. Neurons to electrons. When you think about something or imagine it, the device recognizes that and translates it into an electronic signal for other devices.”

“And the other way around?” I asked. “Electrons to neurons?”

He smiled.

“e2n? Yes, that exists too. It’s used for learning, memory retention—even for *implanting* memories. But it isn’t safe. Only licensed specialists are allowed to use it.”

As I kept looking around through the Mask, I first noticed—and then consciously registered—one particular difference. There was a clear distinction in how nonliving objects—stones, cliffs, soil—appeared in the Essence layer, compared to living things: trees, grass, Art, and me.

Everything alive was sharply defined. Each living form seemed to exist within an invisible but unmistakable boundary. By contrast, the glow around rocks and cliffs was diffuse, their light bleeding outward, forming areas of greater or lesser density without any clear edge.

I raised my hand and studied how it looked in the Essence layer.

As if reading my thoughts, Art explained:

“Yes. That’s what life looks like. All living things. That’s exactly how life differs from non-life—by having its own internal Essence, held within a contour that separates it from the surrounding field.”

I nodded, thinking that people must have intuited something like this unconsciously—if not consciously—long before.

We kept walking.

Most of what I saw through the Mask was a soft, pale green glow. But some plants—certain branches, flowers, blades of grass—had a noticeably lighter background. Some were almost transparent.

“Transparent means death,” Art said, once more ahead of my thoughts. “When a living thing’s Essence level drops to zero, it dies. The contour disappears. After that, the body—now just a nonliving object—starts accumulating Essence again, up to the baseline. A hundred quints. But without a contour.”

“And visibility?” I asked. “It’s only close-range, right?”

“Yes. Twenty, maybe thirty meters at most. That’s why you won’t see it from orbit.”

By now, we were alone on the trail.

From time to time, patches of more concentrated glow appeared. Art pointed to one of the stones beside the path.

“Want to try picking a bit?”

The stone lay almost on the trail itself. Shaped vaguely like a horse’s head. Bright. Alive with light.

Art sat down on the grass beside it, legs crossed. I followed suit.

He unclipped his belt. It was the same color as his clothes—soft, flexible, almost organic. Several subtle thickened segments were visible along it. When Art ran his hand across one of them, the material flowed apart, revealing a rectangular device inside, something like a miniature phone. As soon as he removed it, the material sealed itself again.

“Formin,” he said. “All of it is formin. The belt, the clothes, the backpack. It’s a material infused with molecular mechs—tiny machines. They’re controlled via n2e and can change shape, color, and structure. Faster or slower, depending on the size and complexity. Connecting or separating edges is almost instant. But turning this jacket into, say, a pillow?” He smiled. “That would take close to a minute.”

He held up the device he’d taken from the belt.

“This is a quint-box. Or just *the box*. Inside it is an artificially grown emerald. It’s the best known accumulator of Essence. Diamond, ruby, and similar stones hold it almost as well. And the best conductor of Essence is platinum—that’s what the quint-pump and all conductive elements are made of. And yes,” he added, “as you’ve probably guessed by now, other precious metals—especially gold—are excellent conductors too.”

I nodded.

“So that’s why those stones and metals were always considered precious?”

“Yes. People sensed it intuitively.”

“And the casing?” I asked.

Art nodded approvingly.

“The casing is made of two layers of ultra-strong polymer, with a vacuum—or near-vacuum—between them. As I told you earlier, in a perfect vacuum the Essence level is always exactly one hundred quints, and that can’t be altered. So a vacuum layer is the best possible insulator, the best way to keep Essence contained. Of course, the plastic layers are connected by microscopic bridges, so the box still *leaks* Essence a little—but very little. Overall, it’s a highly reliable and efficient container. This one, for example, can hold up to ten thousand amphoras.”

I realized that was more Essence than a thousand people combined, and let out a low whistle.

Art continued:

“In practice, though, boxes are rarely filled to capacity. The transfer rate of Essence is directly proportional to the depth of the source and inversely proportional to the depth of the receiver—and in both cases, the relationship is exponential, not linear. So filling a box *all the way* is only realistically possible from extremely deep nuggets. Otherwise, you’d be sitting next to each cluster for hours—or even days. Naturally, no one does that.”

He fell silent for a moment, as if considering something, then continued.

“Now for another important device—perhaps the most important one of all. The quint-pump. It’s built into the box itself and doesn’t run on electricity, but on Essence drawn from the box. Like the Essence field sensor, the quint-pump only functions when the user’s Essence level is above a certain threshold—more precisely, above 187 quints. That’s why ordinary people can’t use these devices. Technically, they could—but only if their Essence level were constantly maintained at 187 quints, and doing that would consume nearly all the Essence the pump collects. At that point, the whole process becomes pointless.”

He paused briefly. I listened without interrupting.

“The quint-pump and the Essence field sensor,” Art went on, “were both created at the same time, by the same person. His name is Hikaru Yugura. Their appearance was a turning point—the foundation of all technology that allows us to use Essence at all. Both devices were invented exclusively in our world, Variant One. That’s why, under no circumstances, they can be allowed to fall into the wrong hands,” he said, then repeated more slowly, choosing his words with care. “Especially not into the hands of representatives from closed worlds.”

He looked at me to make sure I was following.

“In case that ever does happen,” he continued, “the box with the quint-pump—and, incidentally, the Mask and every other piece of our gear that hasn’t been developed in other Variants—are all equipped with a self-destruction protocol. In a critical situation, the molecular mechs will turn them into dust in a matter of seconds.”

He returned the box to his belt—or rather, simply pressed it against it. The formin immediately flowed around the box, the edges rising and sealing over it, swallowing it whole. Once again, it was just a thickened segment of the belt.

Art gestured to the other segments.

“Terminal. Resonator. Batteries. I’ll show you all of that later and explain how it works. For now—let’s get to work.”

We stood up.

In the corner of my Mask’s display, a green icon appeared: the box. The number next to it read 0. Near the stone, a floating annotation popped up, ending in two values: 124q, 36α. I understood these as the nugget’s depth in quints and its capacity in amphoras.

Art turned toward me, as if to draw my attention.

I looked at him—and flinched.

The right shoulder strap of Art’s backpack, the one closest to the stone, suddenly stirred and began to change shape. It split lengthwise into two parts. The lower end of one section detached and slowly lifted upward, writhing slightly as it rose.

It looked like a tentacle.

Or like a snake lifting its head from the ground, preparing to strike.

“That’s a tacle,” Art explained calmly. “Like the rest of the backpack, it’s made of formin. Inside it runs a platinum core. Right now, it’s connected to the quint-pump.”

The tacle extended toward the stone. Its tip seemed to *bite* into the surface.

The numbers on the box icon began to climb: 1α... 2α... 3α...

On the Mask’s display, the stone gradually grew paler. The numbers slowed.

Art disconnected the tackle when the box reached 24 amphoras, and the nugget's indicators settled at 106q, 8α.

"As you can see," he said, "when the depth is low, the process is slow—and the speed drops exponentially. On top of that, the percentage of losses increases. More and more Essence simply dissipates into the surrounding space. Picking nuggets below 105 quints isn't worth it—it takes too much time, especially once the box is partially filled. And extracting anything below 100 quints is impossible altogether."

As he spoke, the tackle smoothly coiled back and flowed into the backpack strap, disappearing as if it had never existed.

"Let's look for a few more," Art said.

We continued along the trail. Over the rest of the day, we found roughly another dozen nuggets. Almost all of them were smaller than the first one, so by the end Art's box held around two hundred amphoras—an amount of Essence roughly equivalent to that contained in twenty to thirty people.

Each time before extracting Essence from another nugget, Art would glance around, making sure no one was nearby and no one could see us. After that, he would usually position himself with his back to the nugget, keeping an eye on the surroundings. In those cases, the tackle formed not from the strap but from the backpack itself, which made the whole process almost completely invisible.

When we finished picking the last nugget, Art said:

"That'll do for a first day."

It was already around seven. Dusk was setting in. We started heading back. Even though I was exhausted—and my head was already overflowing with new information—I decided to ask a question that had been on my mind for a while. Or rather, to test a suspicion.

"I wanted to ask you something," I said. "You striders—you've been here for a long time already, haven't you? I mean, in our Variant."

He smiled tiredly.

"About ten years. I don't remember exactly. When the Gates appeared, we—like everyone else—immediately rushed to study them. But unlike the other Variants, we managed to learn how to see and collect Essence, and most importantly, to understand what it actually is and what it can be used for. After that, things moved very fast. The first strider was identified, then gradually the rest. Striders began walking through the Gates, bringing back information about other Variants. That's how we figured out the structure of the Delta of Worlds. Then the striders split into Reds and Greens. ARC was created and organized the work of us Greens. Altogether, it took about five years."

He paused, as if thinking about something.

"Your Variant is classified as closed. That means we striders hide ourselves and our activities from the locals. There are open Variants as well—places where everyone knows about us. But here, we've been keeping a low profile, and I think we've managed to do that successfully. Still, to operate properly, we need a lot from your world—from basic information about how things work, all the way to money and documents. So we gradually recruited and trained the right people—agents—who now provide us with everything we need. Some of them are locals who agreed to confidentiality. Others were brought through the Gates after having their Essence boosted."

"Boosted?" I interrupted immediately. "Is that even possible?"

"Of course. Why wouldn't it be?" he said calmly. "You can raise the Essence level in a person—or in any material object, for that matter. The same quint pump used for collecting Essence is used, just in reverse. The elevated level immediately starts dropping, with Essence leaking outward, until it settles at the level determined by the person's contour. To pass through a Gate, the Essence level has to be higher than the

Gate's own level—what we call the threshold. That's why we striders can cross at any time, but a regular person has to be boosted, preferably right before the crossing, so their level doesn't drop below the threshold before they enter."

"And the threshold level is... how much?"

"It varies. Some Variants have higher thresholds, some lower. On average—around two hundred quints. Give or take twenty. Oh, and by the way, the crossing itself consumes Essence too—about twenty to thirty quints. You don't get that back instantly. So even we striders can't just run back and forth endlessly."

He smiled.

By that point, the stream of information had completely exhausted my ability to absorb anything new—or even to think clearly at all. So for the rest of the walk home, we barely talked. We bought a sandwich and a juice each at a small shop, and finally reached my place. I gave him the bed and took the couch.

I fell asleep instantly.

Chapter 5. The Snap

I woke to a faint sound. My eyes were still closed, but I could hear a muted voice. Someone was speaking calmly, as if having a quiet conversation with someone in the next room.

I slowly opened my eyes. Art was standing by the window, leaning on the sill, talking while gazing into the space in front of him. Just behind his ear I noticed a thin, barely visible stripe that seemed to merge with his skin.

"Yes, at ten. In twenty minutes. Perfect, see you then."

He turned toward me, and a light, slightly mischievous smile instantly appeared on his face.

"Morning. Didn't wake you, did I?"

"Not anymore," I smiled back. "What was that?"

"This is a Clip." He stepped closer, lightly touched his ear, removed the device, and showed it to me—a thin, flexible half-ring. "It contains the main personal n2e interface and is also linked to the Terminal. Through it you can hear audio, receive notifications, and control devices—mentally, via the neural channel. Very convenient."

He handed me the Clip.

"Yours. I've got a spare."

I took it in my hand. The material was a matte beige, pleasant to the touch—almost warm—and very flexible, nearly pliable. I turned it over, examining it, then hooked the clip behind my ear. It immediately tightened just a little, almost imperceptibly, fitting snugly around the contour of my ear—and then I almost stopped feeling it at all.

"And the Terminal is...?" I began.

Art took a thin plate from his belt, about the size of a credit card, with a matte surface.

"This. This is the Terminal. It's how we access the Net. The Net exists in our Variant—there's no connection to it here—but the Terminal stores a snapshot of everything essential. It also allows you to use your cellular or satellite networks—which I just did."

He paused briefly, clearly searching for a clear way to put it.

"You could say our Net is like your Internet. Only much, much bigger. Incomparably bigger. Everything is there: information, communication, navigation, Layers."

"Layers?" I repeated, hearing the word for the first time.

"Layers are visual, audio, and mental overlays on reality. Like your augmented and virtual reality, only far more integrated. Through Layers we see maps, prompts, markers, messages. And of course, the Net Aide—NA."

"NA?" I echoed.

"Yes. An artificial intelligence that helps with everyday tasks, navigation, communication. Everyone has their own, personalized one. The Terminal sends visual data to the Mask, audio and mental to the Clip—but you can also use the Terminal directly."

He spoke calmly, unhurriedly, almost like a lecturer. But there was something warm in his voice—the tone of someone talking about things he genuinely loved.

"You said the meeting is in twenty minutes?" I asked, still turning the Clip over between my fingers.

“Yes. A snap.” Art sat down on the chair opposite me and leaned slightly forward. “It’s a short meeting we hold before every picking. We Greens gather as fast as possible to divide up the territory. The zones with the highest probability of nuggets—we need to reach them before the Reds do. So on a snap, we try not to waste time. Like this.” He snapped his fingers. Then, glancing at me, he smiled wryly.

“Today’s snap will be here, at your place. I took the liberty of inviting everyone on your behalf. Hope you don’t mind?”

“Of course not.” I stood up. “We should make tea and coffee. Want some?”

“Oh yes, thank you. Coffee, if possible.”

I started bustling around the stove. Put the kettle on, set up the cezve for coffee, took out all the cups I had and lined them up on the table, set out sugar and milk. The window was slightly open; a light morning breeze played with the curtains. I listened to the sounds outside: birdsong, the distant hum of cars and buses, voices of passersby along the road. Everything felt astonishingly ordinary—and at the same time, completely new.

They arrived one by one or in pairs. No one knocked—just came in through the door. Smiled, greeted us, exchanged a few light, friendly remarks. I had the strange feeling that I’d known them for a long time, that they were old friends—and maybe that wasn’t just my impression. Perhaps it was the same quality Art had. Elevated Essence levels. Calm confidence, friendliness, goodwill—it radiated from every one of them.

The first to arrive were two people—a man and a woman, both dark-skinned, with bright, dark eyes. There was a light, shared accent in their speech that I couldn’t quite place. The woman was strikingly beautiful: long thick hair, refined features, a smile that carried both warmth and a kind of quiet superiority. They were dressed simply and practically, trail-ready. On their backs—like Art—small, comfortable backpacks. I later noticed that these backpacks, along with the sporty, expedition-style clothing, were common to all the striders.

The man’s name was Rishan, the woman’s Amaya. The way they carried themselves made it obvious—without a word—that they were together. I offered them tea and coffee. Rishan smiled and gave my shoulder a friendly, courteous pat.

“Thanks, friend. Coffee for us.”

“Don’t worry, we’ll pour it ourselves,” Amaya added, smiling at me as well.

Almost immediately after Rishan and Amaya, a dark-skinned woman in her early forties stepped inside. She had short, curly hair, an intelligent, approachable face, and an athletic build. Her movements were unhurried, her gaze attentive and calm. When she spoke, people listened. Her name was Ellen.

As we were introduced, Ellen gave me a friendly look that also felt—at least to me—slightly evaluative. She, too, chose coffee.

“Wow, you even have a cezve,” she said approvingly. “Then I’ll make mine strong.”

And with quiet confidence, Ellen headed straight for the stove.

“Teams are named after their leader,” Art explained to me softly. “Ours is Team Ellen.”

I nodded, feeling a quiet relief at not having to pretend. I genuinely wanted to be part of this.

The next to arrive was Laar—tall, with a Scandinavian look, long greying hair tied back in a ponytail, and an upright, steady posture. There was something solid in his calm gestures and in his focused, slightly contemplative gaze.

“You know what we have in common?” Laar asked, shaking my hand firmly and smiling only with his eyes. His palm was broad and strong—the kind of hand that’s used to physical work.

I shook my head.

"I'm not from their world either," he said, nodding toward the other striders. "Not from Variant One."

"Which one, then?" I asked, instantly more alert, looking at him with renewed curiosity.

"Third," he replied. "Will you pour me some tea?"

"Of course," I said quickly, hurrying toward the kettle.

"Strong," Laar added, following me. "No milk. And plenty of sugar."

I nodded, tipping the last of the tea leaves from the tin into the teapot and pouring in boiling water.

"So what's it like there, in the Third?" I asked, glancing at him and doing a poor job of hiding my intense curiosity.

"That's a long story," he said. "And you'll find out soon enough anyway. You'll have an induction course. All new striders do. Right at the start there's a 'download.' They'll write all the necessary information straight into your brain via e2n. Including data on all the Variants."

The news barely surprised me. I think I'd been expecting something like that.

"Still," I said, unable to resist, "just in general—two words?"

He leaned back against the refrigerator and crossed his arms.

"It's... good there," he said slowly. His gaze seemed to drift somewhere far away. "In our world, instead of your cars and airplanes, we have steam-drives and airships. Everything runs on steam."

He fell silent.

As I poured tea into his cup, I stole a quick glance at him. He looked lost in thought. And suddenly I realized—he missed home. His world. Deeply.

I wondered if I would feel the same one day.

I handed him the cup. Laar surfaced from his memories and nodded in thanks, taking it.

"How did you end up with the striders?" I asked. "I mean—no, that's not quite right. How did you become a strider? That's the better question, right?"

"Both work," he smiled. "First I became one—without knowing it. And then Ellen found me."

He took a sip of tea and nodded approvingly.

"I'm a mechanic, actually. Spent my whole life working at a dock—an airship repair station. It's built in the mountains, to get some shelter from the winds.

"When the Storm hit, I was up on the slipway, replacing mounts on a longeron. The mountainside was right there. That's where a nugget started forming, as I learned later. And I was too lazy to leave the Storm. I'd have had to climb down ladders, exit the dock, go somewhere... I figured I'd just sit it out. Endure it. Thought it would pass quickly.

"It was awful, of course—absolutely brutal. And it didn't pass quickly at all. The Storm lasted nearly an hour. I thought I wouldn't make it. But I did. And well..."

Laar spread his hands with a smile, as if apologizing.

"And would you want it all undone?" I asked. "Go back to your old life?"

He smiled slyly.

“Nooo,” he drawled, still smiling. “It’s interesting here. You’ll see.”

At that moment, two more people arrived—a short Latina woman with an open, lively smile, and a quiet, slightly shy young man with short, tightly curled hair and deep black skin. Her name was Marisol, his Tariq. It was immediately clear that Marisol was his mentor.

After greeting me and receiving a cup of coffee with milk from me, Marisol and Tariq stepped aside, casually chatting with Art. When Marisol spoke to Tariq, he listened with respectful attention, as if catching every word.

The last to arrive was a petite, energetic young woman of Asian appearance. Her name was Sana. She immediately asked for tea, and I—lost in thought—automatically made her black tea with milk, out of habit. She tasted it and seemed slightly surprised. I caught myself at once and offered to make her a fresh cup.

Sana tilted her head to the side, smiled broadly and warmly, and politely refused. She assured me that she liked this tea too. All the while, she was studying me with open curiosity and interest—almost analytically, it seemed.

I realized everyone had arrived and the meeting was about to begin. The striders spread out around the room, settling onto the couch and chairs, putting on their masks and clips. I followed their example. Ellen remained standing. She looked around at the striders and spoke:

“Let’s begin. First, an update. I know you all want to hear what we have on the new world. The short answer is: almost nothing. Other than the fact that yes—it exists. We now have nine Variants.

“And one more thing. The Gate threshold for the new Variant is significantly higher than for all the others. Around two hundred seventy quints. Which means that yes—for all of us, and for the vast majority of striders in general, crossing into the new Variant without boosting is impossible.

“That said—not for all of us.”

She suddenly looked at me.

“Mac can cross.”

Everyone turned toward me with open interest. I felt a little uneasy under their gazes, but at the same time I remembered that my contour had looked brighter than Art’s earlier. Which meant my Essence level was apparently higher—likely above two hundred seventy quints. Unlike most other striders.

Ellen went on:

“That’s essentially everything that was known at the moment I crossed the Gate here. A special group has been formed. Their leader is Eric. His contour level also exceeds two hundred seventy; the others were boosted. They crossed into the new Variant. We haven’t received any information from them yet. At the same time, teams—including ours—have been dispatched to all the other Variants. Our task is Essence picking around the new Gates in each world.”

A three-dimensional map appeared inside the mask. I recognized our local terrain, with the Gate at the center.

“This is the area around the new Gate. As usual, we’ll work by sectors—standard procedure, just like any other picking run.”

The map divided into six sectors, highlighted in different colors. I noticed that the sector boundaries followed rivers, ridgelines, and roads. Clearly, Ellen had prepared the layout in advance, thinking through the details. Near the center of the map, labels appeared above each sector, showing one or two names.

Ellen continued calmly, matter-of-factly:

“Marisol and Tarik get the largest sector. There are good trails there—you’ll be able to cover more ground. Art and Mac get a smaller one; it’s harder to traverse. But I think the chances of finding deep nuggets there are higher.

“As you can see, pairs get broader zones. Solo operators—compact ones.”

Art and I were assigned the sector between the coastal road and the mountain river.

As I looked at the map, a warm, unexpected feeling rose in me.

I was part of the team. I had been accepted. Simply, without ceremony.

When Ellen finished the assignments and looked around, waiting for questions, Marisol raised her hand.

“Any news on the Reds?”

“Analytics say the Reds have become more active,” Ellen replied. “The appearance of new Gates is a massive release. For them, it’s an obvious lure. We expect heightened activity and increased aggression. Stay alert.”

I looked around at the striders and saw their expressions harden.

“Any other questions?” Ellen asked.

I had many—but I held back.

“Then, striders—get to work,” Ellen said.

And snapped her fingers.

Chapter 6. Into the Mountains

After the other striders left, Art and I were alone in the room again. The space seemed to grow quieter and more open.

Art studied the holographic map still hovering in his mask display.

"Listen," he said. "I've done a preliminary look at our sector. It's a large area, lots of rock formations—which means the nugget density should be decent. Given that not everything is accessible on foot, it looks like at least three days of work. Three for sure. Possibly even four."

He paused, still looking at the map, as if running calculations in his head.

"I want to go over the routes in more detail now—mark tracks, rest points. But I can already tell: it'll be better if we stay overnight in the mountains today. And probably at least one more night after that. We'll save a lot of time by not having to go back home and return to the trail every day."

He looked at me with a faint smile.

"You'll be able to bring everything you need for an overnight stay?"

I nodded immediately, feeling a pleasant excitement at the thought of the hike.

"Of course. I've got a backpack with full gear. I used to head out into the canyons for a day or two all the time. Haven't done that much lately, but I've still got everything—tent, sleeping bag, cooking pot."

Art gave a thumbs-up.

"Perfect. The pot is up to you, but you won't need the tent or the sleeping bag." He nodded toward his own backpack.

I looked at it skeptically.

"Will that really be... enough?"

Art nodded without hesitation.

"Yes. Formin can create large membrane structures. Air inside the membranes, so even a relatively small amount of formin can become something fairly big. It just takes more time. You won't be sleeping on bare ground."

I suddenly remembered my job at the zipline.

"Oh, right. I need to quit my job," I said. "Completely forgot about that."

Art looked at me thoughtfully.

"With this many tourists around, your leaving might cause some trouble."

"No," I said with a grin. "I wasn't really an instructor anyway. That requires a license. I mostly brought in customers—talked to people, convinced them to try it. And now they'll manage without me just fine. With this kind of crowd, people are lining up on their own."

Art nodded approvingly.

Another question popped into my head.

"What about food? Any preferences?" I asked.

"Nope. I'm not picky. I eat whatever's available."

“Great. I’ll grab some freeze-dried food from the outdoor shop, just in case. But I’ll also bring the pot and real ingredients.” I smiled. “I’ll cook you my famous shepherd’s stew.”

He looked at me with genuine admiration.

“So this is going to be a real hike. Real camping. Cooking over a fire. Perfect.”

I quickly assembled a mental checklist.

“Alright. I’ll take care of everything and be back in an hour or so.”

“Sounds good,” Art said. “I’ll finish refining the routes and take a look at your Clip settings.”

I stepped outside feeling light, cheerful—not because I was quitting my job, but because a hike lay ahead. New places. And, more importantly, company that genuinely interested me.

Quitting didn’t take long.

My coworker Peter was, as usual, bustling around the zipline platform, fastening gear on the next customer. As expected, a solid line of people had formed in front of the entrance. When I approached, Peter glanced at me, seemed to understand everything at once, and said—more as a statement than a question:

“You’re leaving.”

I nodded, feeling a twinge of guilt. Peter, apparently reading my thoughts, waved it off.

“Don’t worry. We’ll manage. Good luck to you. And thanks for the work.”

He shook my hand and immediately turned back to the next customer. I smiled—it had been easier than I expected.

I stopped by the outdoor store, picked up freeze-dried meals, mosquito repellent, a few sturdy trash bags, and a spare rain poncho—just to be safe. Then I went to a small grocery shop and bought everything needed for shepherd’s stew: a chunk of the freshest beef, carefully wrapped, bacon, onions, garlic, carrots, potatoes, spices. I added bread, some fruit, and also crackers, nuts, and chocolate—for long stretches on the trail.

When I got back home, Art was already finishing the route markings.

“All set,” he said. “I’ve mapped the routes. In this sector beyond the Gate, we’ll need to cover three tracks. Tonight we stay in the mountains. Tomorrow’s and the day after tomorrow’s routes end near the road—we can head home and then take a taxi to the start of the next segment.”

“Perfect,” I said, and started laying out the supplies, dividing them into two piles.

Together we distributed water, food, and gear. I noticed how Art’s backpack seemed to subtly expand, adjusting to the volume being packed inside. The fabric—formin—felt almost alive: elastic, resilient, responsive. It was clear he barely noticed it anymore. For him, it was simply normal.

“I’ve done a bit of work on your mask and clip,” Art said as we were finishing packing. “For now, I’ve only enabled the basic functions: comms, maps, terminal. The controls are simple—you’ll be comfortable with them. I’ll explain things as we go.”

“Alright,” I nodded, tightening the straps on my backpack.

We grabbed a quick bite from whatever was left in my fridge. Then we double-checked everything, put on our packs, locked the front door, and set off.

We walked along the shoulder of the road, skirting the Gate on the right. A map hovered in my mask, the route clearly marked: first a few kilometers downhill toward the sea, to the point where a narrow trail branched off into the canyons. That’s where our real route would begin.

The weather was perfect—soft morning sun, a fresh breeze. The mountains ahead looked almost translucent, their slopes dissolving into a light haze. Pines lined the road, their branches twisted and muscular. Below, in the bends of the canyon, the river flashed now and then, winding between the rocks.

We walked at an easy pace, talking.

“When we’re picking in pairs, it usually works like this,” Art explained. “We don’t walk side by side. We move in parallel, some distance apart. That way we cover more ground. If each of us follows our own track, the chances of finding nuggets go up.”

“And how do we communicate then?” I asked. “Shout?”

“Why shout?” Art smiled. “That’s what message mode is for. Some people also call it dispatch mode—or *depeche mode*.”

He explained: in theory, the mask and clip allow for direct, real-time thought sharing—but that mode is almost never used.

“Why?” I asked. “Wouldn’t that be more convenient?”

“It would be horrible,” Art said calmly. “Almost everyone runs an internal monologue constantly. Talking to themselves, thinking things through, remembering, fantasizing. Now imagine someone hearing all of that. Every random, spontaneous thought. Every unfiltered image. It would be the most brutal violation of personal boundaries imaginable.”

He paused, then added:

“That’s why n2e protocols are hard-coded: no mind-reading. Ever. Only deliberately formed messages. That rule is sacred.”

“Got it. So how do messages work?”

“There are two options. Voice messages—which you hear in the clip as my voice. Or text messages, which you see in the mask. To create one, you clearly think ‘Voice’ or ‘Text,’ then immediately think the message itself. When you’re done, you say ‘Send.’ Or you just pause—at least five seconds. That’s enough for the Net Aide to recognize the message is complete and send it.

“The pause duration is adjustable, but people rarely set it below five seconds—to avoid accidental sends. If you change your mind, just think ‘Cancel’ during the pause.”

“And how does n2e know what’s a command and what’s part of the message?” I asked. “What if I start a message with the word ‘text’ as part of the sentence?”

Art smiled.

“That’s where the Net Aide comes in. It almost never makes mistakes. It reads intent. Not just words—but how you think them. With what focus, what purpose. It understands context, tone, the structure of the thought itself. At first it feels strange, but you get used to it. It really does understand you.”

We walked in silence for a while as I processed that.

“Want to practice?” Art asked. “Switch to message mode. Think: ‘Message mode, Art.’”

I focused and clearly thought:

Message mode, Art.

A small green icon appeared in the corner of my display—mode active.

“Now try sending me a text,” Art said aloud.

I thought:

Text: Can you hear me?

A moment later, text floated into view:

"Loud and clear. Now try voice."

I thought:

Voice: Is everything working?

A second later, Art's calm voice sounded in my Clip, as if he were speaking right beside me:

"Yes, everything's working. Convenient, right?"

I nodded.

Text: Very. Almost like being there—but without interference. Send.

Art's voice replied:

"Yes. And most importantly—it's extremely reliable. Even if the connection is bad, messages still get through."

We kept walking, continuing the exercise. I found myself liking it more and more. It was simple, fast, and genuinely comfortable.

Art, text: *"What would you like to talk about?"*

Me, text: *"The Reds. Send."*

Art's voice: *"They probably deserve the attention."*

Me, text: *"Is being a Red a crime?"*

Art, voice: *"Not really. In our world, people are free. No one is obligated to hand over Essence to the Agency. No one has the right to force you to collect nuggets for the Forum."*

Me, voice: *"For who?"*

Art, text: *"For the Forum. That's what we call what you'd think of as 'the state' or 'the authorities.' You'll learn all of that during the upload."*

Me, text: *"Alright. Let's get back to the Reds."*

Art, voice: *"Being Red in itself isn't a crime. But there are at least three kinds of violations Reds tend toward... by definition. First, drug trafficking."*

Me, voice: *"Drugs?"*

Art, voice: *"Yes. As I told you before, when Essence leaves a person's inner contour and spills into the surrounding world, the person experiences intense euphoria. Because of that, Essence is officially classified as a narcotic. Reds mostly use it exactly this way—either for themselves or for sale. By the way, in that context it's more often called *quinta*. So: quinta is a drug. Unlike most others, it doesn't destroy the body. There's no chemical dependency. But the psychological dependence is very real. If you've slid even a couple of times, quitting without consequences is almost impossible."*

I didn't interrupt—he caught my unspoken question anyway. His voice stayed calm, without judgment.

Art, voice: *"To slide, Reds use boosting—through form-bracelets. They have platinum micro-needles built in, connected to a box. The bracelets are made of formin and can be part of clothing. When a person activates the bracelet, the needles enter the veins, and the quint-pump starts injecting. The level of quinta in the blood rises. The contour overfills—and quinta spills outward, triggering the high. That's sliding."*

Me, voice: "So sliding is... when it hits?"

Art, voice: "Exactly. There's active sliding—energy surge, agitation, dilated pupils, tremors. And passive sliding—soft euphoria, relaxation, pleasure. Sliders learn to control the state, dial it up or down."

Me, voice: "But it's harmful, right?"

Art, voice: "Formally—no. Quinta doesn't kill. But the nervous system wears out. The person literally burns from the inside. Ages faster. Possibly lives less—though there isn't enough data yet, not enough time has passed. What *is* proven is psychological addiction—and it's very strong. Almost no one can stop."

Me, voice: "And the sliders themselves—do they know that?"

Art, voice: "That's the interesting part. They don't believe sliding is dangerous. They say things like, 'Only the weak die,' or 'If you slide properly, you'll be fine.' It's an entire culture of denial. They argue with doctors, with scientists. Some of the veterans already understand how it ends—but they can't quit."

Me, voice: "And all Reds slide?"

Art, voice: "No. Not all—but many. I'd say the overwhelming majority."

Me, voice: "And the Greens? Are there sliders among you?"

Art, voice: "No. It's strictly forbidden for us. When you join the Agency, you sign the Code. There are two clauses about this—no recreational use of Quintessence, and no personal enrichment."

Me, voice: "Got it. Then where's the crime with the Reds?"

Art, voice: "Selling. If a Red sells quinta, that's illegal. That business is mostly run by the Tribe—a closed and dangerous criminal network. Tribe includes both Reds and ordinary people. The Agency fights them, but strictly within the law. We Greens aren't allowed to use force unless a crime has already been committed. We can defend ourselves, but not attack. The Reds know this, which is why they're not particularly afraid of us."

Me, voice: "Okay, that makes sense. What else?"

Art, voice: "Second—violating closed-world protocol. We Greens are obligated to follow it—it's also in the Code. Reds have no such obligations—neither formal nor moral. So in theory, they could contact the authorities of closed worlds, or wealthy individuals, and tell them about the Delta, about striders, and of course about quinta. But I'll say this right away: it hasn't happened yet. I think every Red understands that once you start down that path, the trouble will be ten times greater than the profit. And they don't really need it—quinta is already plentiful for them."

Me, voice: "And how do you know there haven't been leaks?"

Art, voice: "That's handled by AIO—the Agency for Intervariant Operations. Everyone who supports us works for them. Locals and those brought through the Gates. Great people—you'll see. And top-tier professionals."

Me, voice: "I'm guessing there are other agencies in this field?"

For some reason, Art stopped using message mode and spoke out loud:

"Yes. There's one more—ICDA, the Intervariant Cooperation and Development Agency. Mona works there, actually. My..." He hesitated, visibly flustered. "My close friend."

I didn't press him and steered the conversation back to business.

"And what does ICDA do?"

“Studies other Variants. And carefully, under supervision, develops closed worlds—their societies. We help them move toward a level where integration becomes possible—turning them into open Variants.”

I paused, thinking.

“I mean... I can guess,” I said carefully. “But still. What’s stopping our Variant, for example, from becoming open?”

He smiled sadly.

“You really should talk to Mona about that. She’ll explain it properly—and, I think, with pleasure. But yes, you’re probably guessing right. The main barrier is war. State-sanctioned killing.”

I looked at him with a flicker of hope.

“Wait. So... you don’t have wars at all?”

He stared at me, genuinely shocked.

“Of course not. Not for a very long time now. Killing someone means depriving them of the rest of their life—thousands and thousands of minutes, hours, days, years. Just because, say, they think differently. For us, that’s...” He hesitated, searching for words. “That’s monstrous. Barbaric. Obscurantist madness. I simply can’t understand how people can allow it. How they can support armies—entire systems made up of huge numbers of people and machines whose sole purpose is to prepare for, and then carry out, mass killing. Just think about it. Try looking at it from the outside.”

As he spoke, my first instinct was to argue—to say that not everyone here was like that, that there were volunteers, doctors, peacekeepers...

And then I tried, honestly, to look at our world through his eyes.

And I felt unbearably ashamed.

Not of myself—but of my world, of our humanity.

We walked in silence for a while. I didn’t want to keep talking about it, but eventually I asked anyway:

“So you’re saying there’s no violence at all in your world?”

This time, he looked uncomfortable too. With a bitter half-smile, he replied:

“Unfortunately, not yet. But the most we allow ourselves is this.”

He took something out of his belt and handed it to me. A small, dark-gray object, shaped a bit like a joystick or a grip with a raised top. On the front of the protrusion, I saw a tiny black lens; on the handle itself, right where the index finger would rest, there was a small trigger-button. The grip had a pleasant, slightly textured surface and fit naturally into my hand.

I looked at Art questioningly. He began to explain.

“This device is called a resonator—or just a res. Sometimes people also call it a lens. Essentially, it’s a type of e2n interface. When you press the trigger, or give the firing command mentally, the resonator generates a neurocode—a program the human brain can read directly. The res then fires that code as an electromagnetic impulse—a short, invisible beam. When the impulse hits a person—or more precisely, any part of their nervous system—it integrates into their neural signals and reaches the brain. And the brain immediately executes the program.”

“And what exactly is that program?” I couldn’t help asking.

“In theory, it can be almost anything. In practice, two are used most often: paralysis and amnesia. More commonly called ‘freeze’ and ‘forget.’

“Freeze completely disables sensory input and voluntary motor control. Vital processes—breathing, circulation, digestion—continue at a subconscious level. Consciousness remains as well, but it’s completely isolated. The person sees nothing, hears nothing, feels nothing, can’t speak or move. Subjectively, they’re plunged into their inner world and continue to exist only there, with no connection to the outside.”

I tried to imagine myself in that state and shuddered. Art went on:

“Portable resonators like this one can freeze someone for short intervals—from one second up to an hour. The default setting is one minute. That’s usually enough.”

He paused, as if marking the next point as especially important, then continued:

“Generating a single impulse takes about five seconds. When you switch the res into firing mode, the first charge forms in five seconds. After the shot, the next one starts generating—another five seconds—and so on. You can pre-charge up to five impulses, but that only makes sense right before a threat. You can’t walk around indefinitely ‘with a full magazine.’

“The moment you switch the res into sleep mode, all generated charges automatically discharge. That’s not a bug—it’s a safety rule. Carrying a lens in firing mode, or with pre-generated impulses, is forbidden and dangerous. Any accidental press—even a fall or a sharp impact—can trigger a shot, which, by the way, is very likely to hit yourself. So once the threat is gone, you’re required to put the resonator to sleep. Which means all charges are dumped, and the energy is lost.”

I thought it through, then asked:

“If recharge time is so critical, does that mean hitting with the first shot is actually pretty hard?”

“Yes and no. The Net Aide helps you aim. It identifies a person as soon as you look at them or point the lens at them—especially if they also have an active resonator, even if it’s not aimed at you. In threat mode, the clip’s scanner detects an active resonator, and your res automatically locks onto it. So the impulse almost always reaches a stationary target. But... it doesn’t work every time. There are several limiting factors.”

He paused, then went on.

“First, the neurocode has to embed itself into an *active* signal of the nervous system. That depends on where exactly the impulse hits—what point on the body. Individual physiology matters too, as well as clothing, protective fields, and electromagnetic interference.”

I nodded, trying to fit all of that into a coherent picture.

“The second limiting factor is distance. The farther the target is, the lower the chance the impulse will take effect. The effective firing range is about ten meters—at that distance, the success rate is roughly seventy percent.

“From ten to thirty meters, you’re already relying on luck. Beyond thirty, it’s more like a lottery, and the odds aren’t great.”

Art paused briefly, as if deciding whether to go deeper, then continued anyway.

“And there’s a third factor—target movement. There’s only a fraction of a second between aiming and the impulse making contact, but that fraction matters. If the target is moving, the resonator’s Net Aide doesn’t aim at the person as they are—it aims at a calculated point, a prediction of where they’ll be a moment later.”

He gave a faint, wry smile.

“But people don’t always end up where they’re ‘expected’ to be. If someone moves erratically—breaking inertia, disrupting habitual patterns—the prediction can fail, and the impulse misses.”

He looked at me and added:

“That’s why dodging exists—the art of moving in such a way that you *don’t* get hit. But we’ll get to that later.”

We walked in silence for a while. Then I asked:

“So... is freezing always safe?”

His expression darkened.

“Unfortunately, no. If someone has respiratory or cardiac issues, or if they’re in a dangerous situation—underwater, at height, behind the wheel—freeze can kill them.”

“Can you bring someone out early, before the timer runs out? Is there an ‘unfreeze’ program in the resonator?”

“Not in portable units. That requires more complex equipment, and only licensed specialists can operate it. In practice, that means transporting the person to one of the medical centers in our Variant. Theoretically, there are field methods to partially break a freeze—but they’re illegal, risky, and can permanently damage the brain.”

He sighed.

“That’s why, as you can imagine, carrying and using a resonator is permitted only for those who’ve completed training and hold a license. I have one.”

“But there are people who use them without a license?” I asked after a moment.

Art grimaced.

“There are. Illegal resonators circulate—and there are more of them than you’d think.”

“I’m guessing I know who likes using them... Reds?”

He smiled bleakly and confirmed my guess with a slight nod.

“Exactly. Although many Reds also have licensed resonators.”

“And do Reds attack you often?”

“Not very often. But it does happen—and with uncomfortable regularity. That’s the third and main category of... let’s call them unlawful actions typical of Red striders. Selling quinta, potential violations of closed-world protocols, and armed robbery—meaning the theft of quint boxes. Those are the three situations in which a Red—or anyone else—becomes a criminal. Until then, Reds are just ordinary, law-abiding citizens.”

There was a trace of irony in his last words.

“And what’s the punishment for those crimes?” I asked.

“The same freeze. Just for much longer periods. It’s carried out using powerful stationary resonators, and only in specialized correctional facilities, under constant supervision. The duration of penal paralysis is determined by the court, depending on the severity of the crime—from one month up to three years. Longer than that isn’t allowed: the human psyche can’t handle it. Irreversible changes begin, and the person simply loses their mind.”

He fell silent for a moment, then added:

“For particularly serious crimes, the punishment can be combined: several freeze terms separated by conventional imprisonment. That way the person has time to physically recover—while fully aware that another block of total isolation still lies ahead.”

I shuddered at his words. The resonator I was still holding suddenly felt heavy, awkward, and faintly repulsive. I handed it back to Art, and he slipped it into his belt.

“To be honest,” Art went on thoughtfully, “we don’t always put maximum effort into apprehending Reds who’ve committed violations and delivering them to law enforcement. In closed worlds, that’s often practically impossible—without creating a clear risk of breaching the closed-world protocol.

“So more often than not, our role is limited to documenting what happened: cameras, scanners, full incident recording. After that, if the offender’s identity can be established, they’re assigned wanted status—or, as we put it, they become an *illegal*.”

He paused briefly.

“In practical terms, that means access to open worlds is closed to them. From that point on, they can only feel relatively free in closed Variants. And in that, by the way,” Art added with a faint smirk, “probably lies the main reason Reds have absolutely no interest in violating the closed regime or turning closed worlds into open ones.”

Art let the pause stretch waiting for questions—and then, as if with some relief, shifted to another topic.

“Now, about the forget mode. We mostly use it when there’s a risk of breaching the closed regime. For example, if someone accidentally sees you—or another strider—using a tacle. In that case, the resonator fires an impulse encoded to erase short-term memory for a specific period—by default, one minute.”

He made a gesture, as if wiping an invisible recording.

“And what does the person feel afterward?” I asked.

“Either they don’t remember the last minute at all, or they decide it was some kind of hallucination. And if you happen to be nearby and give them a plausible explanation of what *actually* happened, they tend to believe you and adopt that version. It’s a kind of psychological defense mechanism—the mind trying to restore a familiar picture of reality and avoid stress. So in practice, it almost always works. People rarely feel the urge to tell everyone that a guy suddenly grew a tentacle out of his shoulder.”

He punctuated the last sentence with a ridiculous imitation of a writhing tentacle and a mock expression of horror. We both laughed.

“And just to answer your next question in advance,” Art went on more seriously, “yes—the erased memory segment *can* be restored. But again, that requires stationary equipment and a qualified specialist.”

I tried to process all of this once more—and realized I couldn’t shake the feeling that such situations might not always be so easily ‘contained.’ I voiced my concern. Art answered without a trace of a smile.

“If you see that you’re not coping, that the risk of a leak is still there—or if the situation is getting out of control altogether—you call in an AIO task group. That’s their job. And they do it very well.”

Art pulled a bottle of water from his pack, took a few swallows, and handed it to me. I followed suit—and only then, momentarily distracted from the conversation, realized how far we’d already walked.

Turning my head to the left, I saw that we had rounded the Gate and were now looking at it from the reverse side. It looked no different than before—the same smooth surface, the same hazy, shifting outlines within.

I shifted my gaze to Art... and involuntarily lingered on the bulge at his belt, where the resonator rested.

“Tell me,” I asked, “how often have you actually had to use it yourself?”

“In forgetting mode—fairly often,” he nodded. “I’ve lost count, honestly. Usually when someone shows up unexpectedly while you’re working. As for freeze... seven times total. And always only after someone fired a resonator at me first. I’ve been frozen myself four times.”

“And what does it feel like?” I asked, already realizing how foolish the question sounded.

His face changed for a split second—he went slightly pale, his gaze hardening.

“The feeling...” he said, looking somewhere near his feet, “is unpleasant. To put it mildly. I hope you never have to experience it yourself. Although...” He hesitated. “You will. One way or another. The training course for resonator use includes a mandatory one-minute freeze. The instructors say it helps you treat the device with the respect it deserves.”

He gave a grim smile—but it faded almost immediately.

“Alright. I think you now know everything you need to about this unpleasant part of our work. And just in time—it’s time to get started.”

I lifted my gaze and saw a narrow trail branching off from the road toward the mountains.

We turned off the road.

Chapter 7. Agrav

The Essence layer appeared in my mask.

Once again I saw the familiar green glow—soft, shimmering, spreading in thin veils across rock, grass, and stone.

“It’s strange how quickly I managed to get used to it,” I said, unable to take my eyes off the iridescent field. “And how quickly I forgot. And now I’m amazed all over again at how beautiful it is.”

Art smiled faintly. He didn’t answer, but from his look I could tell he felt the same.

We turned onto a narrow side trail that slipped away downhill along the slope. The ground was dry; low shrubs grew on both sides, with the occasional twisted tree clinging to the soil.

A few minutes later we switched back to message mode and split up. Art moved left, lower down the slope; I went right, a little higher. We walked parallel to the path, each scanning our own section of the hillside. I studied the rocks closely, the patches of green light, searching for anything larger than the small, shallow clusters that turned up now and then.

“I’m only seeing small ones,” I reported to Art. “Nothing deep.”

“That’s normal,” he replied. “Near trails and open areas there’s a good chance the Reds have already been through. Deeper in, and on hard-to-reach slopes, the odds are better.”

I looked at the map again and noted how enormous our sector was—and how much of it was practically inaccessible.

“With an area this size,” I said, “there’s no way we’ll even cover a tenth of it.”

Art confirmed this calmly, as if long accustomed to the thought.

“In picking, time matters most. The most efficient window is the few days right after an Essence release—that is, under normal circumstances, after a Storm. Within a few days, the vast majority of nuggets disappear. They simply disperse—the Essence spreads out and returns to the background. Only the deepest nuggets remain. They can last longer, sometimes weeks, but even they dissolve eventually.”

He paused, then added:

“What’s interesting is that Storms don’t happen simultaneously at different Gates or in different Variants. It’s as if the whole system were being run from a single center. For us pickers, though, that’s good news. There’s almost always work.”

We kept moving along the trail, gradually leaving the road behind. The path slipped off the mountainside and down into the bottom of a narrow ravine squeezed between two steep walls. Rock faces rose on both sides, mottled with patches of Essence.

I was walking along the right wall, Art along the left. I kept scanning the stone, but mostly found small stuff—just a few amphoras at most.

And then, rounding another bend, I lifted my eyes—and that feeling hit me. The kind a fisherman must feel when a massive fish takes the hook. Or a mushroom hunter, stumbling on the perfect porcini.

Ahead of me, about ten meters up the slope, hung a nugget—huge, the size of a large wardrobe.

I checked the readout immediately:

180q, 178α.

I waved to Art.

“Over here! I’ve got something big!”

He came over, took a look, and nodded with approval.

“Not bad for a start. Congratulations.”

As we got closer, it became clear that the nugget wasn’t resting on the ground at all—it was embedded in a sheer rock face, about three meters up.

I scratched the back of my head.

“Should’ve brought climbing gear. Didn’t think of that.”

Art narrowed his eyes slightly, and a sly smile appeared on his face.

“That won’t be necessary,” he said calmly.

I looked at him, puzzled.

The next second I stepped back. My eyes widened. My mouth fell open.

Standing in front of me, without making a single visible movement, Art slowly lifted off the ground.

He rose smoothly a couple of meters and hovered there, perfectly still.

“What... how did you—” I couldn’t get the words out.

Art drifted back down just as smoothly, as if this were the most ordinary thing in the world.

“There’s one more thing I didn’t get a chance to tell you about earlier,” he said. “Agrav. Fully: A-grav. A substance that, unlike everything else, isn’t pulled toward the ground—but pushed away from it.”

He paused for a second, then added:

“The ‘A’ isn’t just a letter. It’s more of a symbol. Like an arrow pointing upward. And everything else,” he went on, “we refer to as V-gravs. Ordinary matter. The kind that behaves... normally.

“Agrav is rare. In its free state, it rises into the upper layers of the atmosphere and exists there as a very diffuse dust. The higher its temperature, the stronger its upward thrust. As the temperature drops, its lift decreases. That’s why, in the cold upper atmosphere, it reaches equilibrium and stabilizes at a certain altitude.”

I listened, hardly believing what I was hearing. He went on:

“In our Variant, agrav was discovered. We learned how to collect it from the atmosphere. There is also artificial agrav, but producing it is extremely expensive and complex. In practice, we mostly use the natural kind.”

He paused, as if considering something.

“Agrav is the foundation of our aerial transport. We have floaters—vehicles with agrav elements or inserts built into their structure. They rise into the air, hover, move freely. My backpack and clothing have agrav inserts as well. When I give the ‘float’ command, the structure of the outfit reconfigures—supporting straps form underneath, the inserts lock into place, the agrav heats up, and I lift off.”

I was still standing there, stunned by the revelation.

“That’s... incredible,” I said at last. “Why didn’t you tell me earlier?”

“Some things are better shown than explained. And as you can imagine, that isn’t always possible. This just happened to be the right moment.”

He gave a short grin, stepped closer, and gave me a friendly tap on the shoulder.

“Have some water. Catch your breath. I’ll get to work.”

I obediently sat down on the grass, took out my bottle, and drank a few gulps, watching as Art scanned the surroundings to make sure no one was nearby.

He approached the rock, apparently issued a command, and smoothly rose to the level of the nugget. He hovered a few centimeters from the cliff face, extended the tacle, and began extracting the Essence.

He worked calmly, unhurriedly, occasionally glancing around.

When the nugget was fully collected, Art descended back to the ground. We moved on.

All that time, I kept thinking about what it must feel like—to simply rise into the air. What it would be like to be able to fly. I also found myself imagining what flying machines might look like. And then I thought: why imagine, when I could just ask?

By then we had spread out along the slopes again, so I switched to message mode.

“I know I’ll probably see it all myself soon,” I said. “But I can’t help it. Tell me—what kind of flying machines do you have? Or not machines... what did you call them? Floaters?”

I saw him smile with understanding.

“Yes. Floaters is the general term for any transport that uses agrav and can take off. We also have ordinary cars, buses, trucks. Very similar to yours. But we gave up fossil-fuel engines a long time ago—everything runs on electricity or hydrogen now. And wherever we can do without agrav, we try to.”

“First of all because it’s a limited—and therefore fairly expensive—material. Extracting it from the atmosphere is technologically demanding.

“But the main reason isn’t even that. It’s ecology. Agrav binds and holds ozone in the atmosphere. And you probably know how important the ozone layer is. So when agrav is extracted, it has to be replaced with a gaseous analogue that performs the same function.”

“Wait, wait,” I interrupted. “Some time ago there was a big topic in our news: ozone depletion. And the cause was supposed to be aerosols, chemicals... Are you saying the real reason could be that someone in our world was collecting agrav?”

Art fell silent. Either he was thinking about it for the first time—or choosing his words carefully. Most likely the latter.

“Personally, I also believe that the ozone depletion in your Variant is connected to someone actually extracting your agrav. Or having done so in the past. But I doubt that someone is from your world. Much more likely—from ours.”

“That’s impossible,” I said firmly. “Ozone depletion started before the Gates appeared.”

“I know. But there are some indications—unofficial, unconfirmed—that before the current Gates, there were others. Smaller ones. Temporary. They appeared, existed for a while, then vanished. As if the creators of the Gates were running trials. Testing the technology before opening large, stable passages.”

I tried to digest the new wave of astonishing information. Art went on:

“So during that testing period, someone may already have been crossing through temporary Gates. Accidentally or deliberately—we don’t know. But the fact itself seems real. And it explains certain events in your world that are hard to account for otherwise.”

“Such as?” I asked.

“Well... you’ve heard of ‘flying saucers,’ haven’t you?”

"Of course. But what do they have to do with this?"

"Quite a lot, actually. Judging by the descriptions and the photographs available, 'flying saucers' are our hovers. Hover-class floaters."

I actually stopped walking.

Art was a few steps ahead. He turned around and looked at me seriously, without smiling. Then he waved a hand—*come on*—and continued as we walked:

"So now you know what hovers look like. A hemispherical body in the center, made of a material with agrav inclusions, and a circular lower contour with engines arranged along it.

"Hovers are used where speed isn't the priority, but maximum maneuverability is. Most often they're flying yachts—very expensive, so they usually belong to extremely wealthy people. There are also research hovers: monitoring weather fronts, volcanoes, migratory flocks... and sightseeing models for tourists.

"In large cities, the police use hovers as well—but only in dense urban areas, where you need full panoramic visibility. They still have plenty of gliders and drifters too—where speed matters more."

"Glider and drifters?" I perked up.

"Uh-huh. Gliders are essentially the equivalent of your airplanes or helicopters. All kinds—from single-seat cabs to intercontinental liners. And drifters are more like motorcycles or scooters... just flying ones."

"They're small, mostly single-seat. There are even portable drifters—you wear them on your shoulders like a backpack. By the way, my pack has a drifter built into it too, though it's very low-power. I'll show you sometime. And then there are high-performance drifters, tuned for maximum speed and maneuverability—like sport bikes."

"Oh, and yes," he added, "we still have ground motorcycles and scooters as well. Some people just love them."

He paused meaningfully, then added with a smile:

"I could, of course, show you all of this right now on the screen. But I think seeing it in person for the first time will be much more interesting."

I couldn't agree more.

"So I'm guessing there are flying trucks too?" I ventured.

"Correct," Art nodded. "You've definitely got an engineer's mind. I hope you won't change your mind about becoming a strider and decide to go into vehicle design instead."

The Net Aide gave his last remark a faintly ironic tone.

"So. Cargo floaters come in two main classes: skimmers and lifters. Skimmers are, roughly speaking, flying trucks—platforms or frames for standard containers. Their main job is moving cargo through the air, usually over short distances where ground transport isn't practical.

"Lifters, on the other hand, work mostly vertically. Think of them as mobile tower cranes. They're used where you can't install a crane, or where doing so would be too slow or too expensive."

I found myself thinking that cabins wouldn't even be necessary for machines like that. They could just be operated like drones.

Art seemed to read my thought.

“Both types are usually remote-controlled,” he continued. “And more often than not, they operate fully autonomously. The Net Aide coordinates everything that flies—from drifters to cargo platforms. It manages routes, assists in manual mode, and prevents collisions.”

He fell silent, then pointed toward a boulder piled up against the cliff.

“Oh—and this beauty here is mine.”

The nugget was the size of a decent skimmer and was resting right at the base of the rock face. Art collected it standing on the ground, without using agrav lift. When he finished, he turned to me. His expression had grown serious.

“From this point on, we switch to threat mode. I think you understand why, but just for context: a full box is worth about as much on the black market as a good flying yacht.”

I let out a low whistle.

“We don’t take off the mask or the clip again until the box is handed over to the Agency vault,” he went on. “And now I’m activating the scanners.”

In the lower-right corner of my mask, the words appeared:

THREAT MODE

“A threat is defined as the presence of hostile resonators within scanner range,” Art explained.

He took out his resonator and placed it on his open palm. The device was immediately overlaid with a fine glowing mesh, visible to me through the mask. The mesh was green. In the upper-right corner, an icon appeared—a circle with the number *1* inside it, also green.

“This resonator is currently on your clip’s whitelist. That means no threats. Note this: you can see the outline of any resonator, even if it’s behind somebody’s body or under clothes.”

Art hid the device behind his back, but the mesh didn’t disappear—it continued to glow right through his silhouette.

“There are three alert levels. First—yellow. Watch.”

He apparently removed his resonator from the whitelist. Instantly, both the mesh and the icon turned yellow, and a long, drawn-out tone sounded in my clip:

Beeeeeeep.

“This means there’s a hostile resonator in the area—even if it’s passive. At yellow level, your task is to locate it. Stay alert, but don’t panic.”

I nodded.

“Next—orange,” Art continued. “That’s when at least one resonator switches to firing mode.”

In the silence, a slow, pulsing sound emerged—

Beeeeep. Beeeeep. Beeeeep...

The circle and mesh flared amber.

“If you see an orange resonator, immediately look for the nearest opaque cover and get behind it. The key word is *opaque*. Resonator impulses pass freely through transparent glass, water, and the like.”

“So clothing protects you from the... impulse?” I asked hopefully.

“Unfortunately, no. Or rather—not really. The impulse has penetrating power, with a depth of about five centimeters. I’m not a specialist here—I can’t explain it properly. Something about carrier wavelengths, modulation frequencies, that sort of thing.”

I nodded thoughtfully.

“Still,” Art went on, “clothing does create a kind of insulating layer and reduces the likelihood that the impulse will ‘find’ a suitable receptor. The thicker the layer, the lower the chance it takes effect. So clothing—and especially headgear, protective helmets—aren’t protection per se, but they *do* count as mitigating factors when there’s a threat.”

I listened without interrupting. After a short pause, Art continued.

“Red—”

The signal suddenly accelerated into a sharp, rapid alarm—

beep-beep-beep-beep-beep!

—and the glow turned harsh, crimson red.

“That’s when the lens is pointed at you and the resonator has locked you as a target. I won’t demonstrate—I think the idea is clear. Your response: drop to the ground immediately, preferably with your feet toward the threat. Your most vulnerable area is your head. Once you’re down, crawl or roll behind cover. The odds that the impulse won’t take effect are actually not that bad.”

Hearing that, I felt a surge of relief. I wasn’t a helpless target after all. Survival was possible—and a lot depended on me.

“Short version,” Art summarized. “Yellow—locate and observe. Orange—hide. Red—don’t think, drop and roll to cover.”

He returned the resonator to the whitelist. The sounds faded, the mesh calmed back to green—and then vanished entirely.

“One more thing, just so you know. You’ll only see and hear a shot if you’re wearing both the mask and the clip. The beam is blue for freezing, white for forgetting, with corresponding firing sounds—both unpleasant. Those are just markers generated by the Net Aide. In the real world, a resonator shot is silent, and the impulse itself is invisible. That’s about all you need to remember on this rather unpleasant topic.”

He gave an awkward smile, almost apologetic.

“Got it,” I nodded. “No questions.”

We split up again and moved on.

Nuggets were appearing more frequently now. Some were quite large—several hundred amphoras, with levels of two hundred quints or more. More often they were modest finds, but each one still sparked the same hunter’s—or mushroom picker’s—thrill. At first Art and I tried to keep count, even joked about competing, but before long we were so absorbed that we lost track.

The sun began to sink toward the horizon, and long blue shadows stretched across the slopes. Art said his box was over four thousand amphoras full—more than enough for a single day.

We exchanged a look and, without saying a word, started searching for a place to spend the night.

Chapter 8. Camping

The clearing we chose for the night turned out to be unexpectedly cozy and picturesque. It nestled between two rocky outcrops of the neighboring mountain: behind us rose a steep, forested slope; to the left, beyond a ledge, the river shimmered in the dusk; and to the right, a dozen meters away, ran a trail, from which we were hidden by a rocky spur. Another pleasant surprise—and a stroke of real luck—was that, when we went down to the river, we found a spring nearby, emerging from a crack in the rock and flowing straight into the river. The spring was wonderfully cold, and its taste struck me as possessing the subtlest bouquet, like an expensive wine. We drank our fill and topped up our bottles, which by then were nearly empty.

The grass in the clearing was soft. Young trees grew here and there, and boulders lay scattered among smaller stones. One of them—flat and conveniently shaped—I immediately designated as the “main table,” while the others I used to build a fire pit.

Art emptied his backpack and began doing something odd with it: unfastening, refastening, and at times seeming almost to tear the fabric apart.

I took a small axe from my gear and went to gather firewood. When I returned—an armful of branches in one hand and a dry sapling dragged behind me in the other—I was met with an unexpected sight: two small but quite comfortable chairs with mesh seats and backs stood by the “table.” Art was already settled into one of them, leaning back with his legs stretched out.

“They’ll turn into sleeping bags later,” he remarked casually, and once again I marveled at the “magical” properties of formin.

I fashioned stakes with a crossbar from the sapling, hung the pot over the fire pit, lit the fire, and set about making shepherd’s stew—a dish without which no picnic of mine ever felt complete.

First I fried the bacon, then the meat, followed by onions and carrots. Art watched the process with genuine interest, asking questions from time to time. When the vegetables and meat were coated in a golden crust, I added my “signature” spice mix, let it bloom, and finally tossed in the potatoes, a bit of water, and salt. All that remained was to stir and wait.

Soon an appetizing aroma spread through the clearing—the stew was clearly a success. By then, dusk had begun to slide into night, and the first stars lit up over the mountains.

And that was when they appeared.

I had just tasted the stew and noted to myself that this batch had turned out especially well when a long, drawn-out *beeeep* sounded in my clip. I flinched. Beside the green icon with the number “1,” a new yellow one appeared, glowing with the number “3.”

I shot a glance at Art. He was already on his feet, staring into the darkness toward the trail. I followed his gaze and saw three glowing yellow dots on my mask’s display—resonators in passive mode.

They were coming closer.

A moment later, three figures stepped out of the darkness. Two men and a woman.

Without making a show of it, Art brought up the Essence layer.

The difference was immediately obvious. The emerald glow around them was noticeably darker than the background. I blinked, focusing—and then noticed dark green patches at their belts: boxes, and judging by their intensity, far from empty. A second later my eyes caught on the masks covering their faces and the thin clips at their temples.

The picture came together.

Striders.

"We followed the smell," said the one standing closest to us, grinning. "Like wolves. Mind if we join you?"

He was massive—like an armored door come to life. Tall, heavily built, with shoulders that looked as if they'd been hewn with an axe. He wore a thick shirt, a leather vest, and loose trousers with countless pockets, tucked into high lace-up boots. A backpack hung from his shoulders, and at his belt rested a resonator wrapped in a faintly glowing yellow mesh.

His long, coal-black hair was tied back in a ponytail, but a heavy lock hung over one eye, giving the unsettling impression that he was looking at me through a gunsight. A mocking smile twisted his mouth beneath a neatly trimmed goatee. He carried himself with confidence and challenge, like someone who knew exactly the impression he made. I caught myself noticing that, despite his intimidating presence and the tension of the moment, there was an undeniable charisma about him.

The other two stood slightly behind him, in the shadows, and I couldn't make them out right away.

"Of course. Come in, make yourselves comfortable," Art said. I caught a faint strain in his voice. "My name's Art."

"I'm Mac," I added, raising a hand.

"And I'm Fang," the big man grinned. "Take a guess why."

He smiled wide, and I noticed what immediately stood out: his upper canines were longer than normal—and in the Essence layer, they glowed a dense, dark green.

"Mini-boxes," Fang explained, catching our look. "Emergency reserve. In case things get tight and there's no quinta handy."

If I'd had any doubts left, they vanished completely.

These were Reds.

Fang dropped his backpack to the ground and sat down on it, stretching his legs with a weary sigh. I noticed how the pack immediately began to reshape itself, transforming into something like a low chair or a lounge.

The second Red behaved differently. He walked up to the fire, unhurriedly took off his backpack, and carefully set it aside. Then he squatted down and held his palms out to the warmth. Lean, of average height, with straight light-colored hair of medium length, pale skin, and gray eyes. A narrow face, a calm, slightly absent gaze. His appearance was utterly neutral—so much so that the eye slid past him without catching.

"I'm Ion," he said quietly, in a calm, slightly muffled voice. "Do you know what an ion is? A charged particle."

"Is Ion your name," I asked, mostly just to keep the conversation going, "or a nickname?"

He shot me a quick, attentive glance.

"Ion is what I am. You know that people are nothing but elementary particles? Most of them are neutral—they neither attract nor repel. And I'm a charged one. An ion."

I thought that his appearance gave exactly the opposite impression. And that, apparently, was a sore point for him.

"Oh, Ion, don't start again," Fang grumbled irritably, settling more comfortably into what was now a fully formed lounge.

Ion smirked, staring thoughtfully into the fire. He clearly had no intention of elaborating.

So I shifted my attention to the third of them.

It was her. Zara.

Up to that point she had stayed aside, remaining in the shadows. Now she stepped forward—and into the firelight. Unlike Fang or Ion, she needed neither flamboyant gestures nor cryptic phrases. It was enough for her simply to appear.

Huge, mesmerizing light-brown eyes, deep and captivating, framed by long, slightly curved lashes. Perfectly smooth skin, faintly sun-kissed, that seemed to glow from within. A precise line of luxurious eyebrows. Sensual, softly full lips. A flawlessly shaped nose, cheekbones, and chin. Her hair—jet black and glossy—was styled in a short cut that framed her face beautifully and emphasized its expressive features.

Zara's figure was slim, but not model-thin—rather softly full, with graceful curves, toned and supple at the same time. Her movements were smooth, fluid, effortlessly elegant.

I couldn't even recall what she was wearing. The clothes dissolved into insignificance. All attention was drawn to her. Not just to her striking beauty, but to the energy radiating from within—a sense of vitality, of presence. It felt as if the space around her grew denser, more alive.

"Hi," she said. "I'm Zara. That's my name."

She gave the last words a particular intonation, casting me a faintly amused glance. Only then did I realize that I had been standing there the whole time with a spoon in my hand. I hastily and awkwardly hid it behind my back and felt myself flush.

Without a word, Zara walked over and sat down in *my* chair, setting her backpack beside it.

The awkward pause was broken by Art. With his usual ease and a lightly ironic smile, he invited everyone "to the table." His tone immediately defused the tension. I followed his lead—confirmed that there was plenty of stew for everyone, pulled disposable bowls and spoons from my pack, and began ladling out the hot dish. Steam rose in thick curls, the aroma wrapped around us, and seemed to dissolve whatever tension remained. The Reds visibly relaxed and began settling in, each finding a spot that suited them.

Fang rummaged through his backpack and, with a satisfied look, pulled out and placed on the "table" a rather large, flat metal flask.

"Whiskey," he explained. "Organic. Twelve years old. Who's with me?"

He swept the group with a questioning glance. Ion and Zara showed no reaction. Art smiled politely and shook his head. To avoid awkwardness, I smiled at Fang and shrugged.

"That's the spirit, kid!" Fang exclaimed happily. "Hand me your cup."

I passed him my mug. He unscrewed the flask's cap, inhaled its scent blissfully, then poured me a generous measure and filled the cap for himself. I added spring water from my bottle. We clinked.

"Here's to this, Mac—may we never run out of quinta!"

With that, Fang tossed the contents of the cap into his mouth, grunted with pleasure, and looked at me expectantly. I took a sip as well. The whiskey really was excellent—rich, smoky, with a smooth, mellow finish.

I stepped aside and sat down on one of the rocks. Even though Zara had vacated my chair, I didn't hurry to reclaim it—quietly hoping she might choose it again.

Zara took a large metal thermos and a stack of light plastic cups out of her backpack.

"Tea. The real kind. Herbal. Picked on slopes where only clouds rise higher."

Ion added nothing to the communal table. He picked up his backpack and moved aside, farther from the fire than anyone else. There, he leaned the pack against a tree and sat down on the ground, resting his back against it and crossing his legs. He placed his hands on his knees, palms up, closed his eyes, and seemed to withdraw completely into himself.

I portioned out the stew for everyone. Ion's bowl I set down on the grass beside him. Sensing the movement, he opened his eyes, looked at me without any expression, and—without moving or saying a word—closed them again.

When I handed a bowl to Zara, she took it and looked up at me. There was still that faint note of amusement in her gaze, but also a polite gratitude. And perhaps—though I may have been deceiving myself—I caught a flicker of something like favor, something that flashed and vanished at once.

"Thank you, Mac," she said, smiling only with her eyes.

I felt a wave of embarrassment wash over me again and immediately turned away, irritated with myself for it.

I gave Fang the largest portion, taking his build into account. He accepted the bowl and, looking at me questioningly, nodded toward the flask. I thanked him and said there was still some left in my mug. So he poured himself another capful of whiskey, tossed it back with relish, and attacked the stew with infectious appetite.

I noticed that Ion had, after all, taken his bowl and was now eating slowly, seemingly paying no attention to the rest of us.

I finished my whiskey and joined in.

We ate, exchanging glances and brief remarks. Gradually the conversation loosened and began to flow more freely. Art asked where they had come from, and Fang, chewing as he spoke, launched into an explanation:

"We've been harvesting around the new Gates here for two days now. Today we started out along your trail—but almost right away it was clear someone had already passed through. Nothing but crumbs left. So we veered right, into the spurs. And that's where it really kicked off! Loads of goodies, and proper pies, too—five times at least. One of them, honestly, was half a cliff!"

"Three hundred seventy-eight amphorae," Zara said without looking up. "I found that one."

I caught something childlike in her voice—a girlish note of pride, even though she tried to hide it. It struck me as incredibly touching, and charming.

When I looked at Fang, I saw that he was gazing at Zara with undisguised adoration. A sharp stab of jealousy ran through me.

Fang went on. Art listened attentively, nodding, though his eyes had narrowed slightly, with a hint of caution.

"So how do we split things tomorrow?" Fang asked, licking his spoon. "Whose trail goes where?"

It was as if Art had been waiting for that very question. He didn't hesitate for a second.

"Half a kilometer down the trail there's an old bridge over the river. That's where the road splits—one branch continues along this bank, the other crosses the canyon to the far side. Take whichever you like. It's all the same to us."

Fang slapped his knee and flashed a satisfied grin.

"Now that's what I call business. Then we'll take the left—through the canyon. Looks like no one's mowed there yet. Plenty of pies for everyone."

"Agreed," Art said with a brief nod.

We finished eating. I gathered the bowls and spoons into a trash bag. Zara walked over to the table, picked up the thermos, and unscrewed the lid. The aroma of mountain herbs rose into the air—spicy, slightly

sweet. She poured tea into two cups, took one for herself, and, without looking at anyone, returned to her seat. The second cup remained on the table.

I don't know whom she had left that cup for—but I felt an overwhelming urge to take it. Without paying attention to anyone and without thinking about politeness, I simply walked up, picked up the cup, and carried it back to my seat.

As I did, I had the distinct impression of feeling a heavy, unfriendly gaze upon me—perhaps more than one. When I sat down and looked first at Fang, then at Ion, neither of them seemed to be the source. Fang was pouring himself yet another capful of whiskey, and Ion sat in the same posture as before, eyes closed.

"Been with the striders long?" Fang asked, tossing back his whiskey and drawing in a loud breath.

"Not really," Art said with a disarming smile. "About five years. Less, actually."

I shrugged. "I'm brand new. Just a few days in."

"So what, you're not even an Agent yet?" Fang perked up. "Listen—forget them, man. Come with us."

I asked cautiously, "And what would that give me?"

Fang's grin spread wide.

"What do you *mean*—what? Freedom, brother. We're free striders. All worlds are open to us. All the quinta is ours. You won't get that kind of high with the Agency."

"And the Tribe?" I blurted out. "Are you with the Tribe at all?"

Fang burst out laughing. I noticed that even quiet Ion let out a short snort without opening his eyes. Zara didn't react at all—clearly, I'd asked a stupid question.

"And who'd tell you that?" Fang laughed. "This guy—" he jerked his head toward Art, "—would rat us out in a heartbeat. In the Tribe, only Alpha knows everyone."

"Alpha?" I echoed.

Fang was happy to explain.

"It's simple. Rank and file are Omegas. Cell leaders are Gammas. There are a couple of Betas at the top. And above them all—Alpha. No one's ever seen him. But everyone knows he exists."

"Alright," I said, trying to smooth things over and steer away from the topic. "I'll think about it."

"Do that—while you still can," Fang chuckled. "And meanwhile, we'll have a little fun."

He shifted his folding chair slightly away from the fire and settled in. Stretched his legs out, rested his hands on them, and closed his eyes. I noticed the sleeves of his shirt suddenly tighten, forming dense bands—like bracelets—just above his elbows.

Fang jerked, as if struck by a jolt or a needle. His breathing grew heavy, his eyes flew open. His whole body tensed, as if he were climbing a steep slope. It lasted maybe half a minute.

Then he slowly went slack. Relaxed. And something flared in his eyes—a strange inner fire. His face lit up with a blissful, triumphant smile. His mouth fell open, releasing a long, satisfied moan:

"Aaaaah..."

I looked to Art, seeking confirmation of what I already suspected. Art gave a short nod.

Then I looked at Ion. He was sitting in the same posture as before—legs crossed, hands on his knees, palms up, eyes closed. But now his sleeves, too, had tightened into bracelets. A soft, almost childlike smile had appeared on his face.

Bracing myself for what I might see next, I turned to Zara. And felt a wave of relief.

She was unchanged. Holding her cup of tea with both hands, lifted close to her face, apparently savoring the aroma. Her gaze was calm, slightly distant. There were no bands on her sleeves. She looked as she had before.

As if to illustrate and confirm my thoughts, Art switched on the Essence Layer again. Zara's contour and the background around her glowed with the familiar, steady emerald. But around Fang and Ion, a different effect shimmered—a "crown" of short, needle-like rays of pale green light radiating outward from their contours. It reminded me of the solar corona during an eclipse.

I shuddered. Watching it was unpleasant—borderline disturbing.

To distract myself, I took the pot off the crossbar, grabbed the bottle of dish soap, and headed down to the river to wash it.

The night was nearly moonless: a thin, barely visible crescent hung above the mountains. But the sky was ablaze with stars, their light seeming especially bright in the clear, transparent silence.

I went down to the river and carefully washed the pot.

As I was walking back, a strange, unprovoked sense of fear suddenly washed over me.

The trail ahead was drowned in darkness. The campfire was hidden behind a rocky outcrop, and that blackness beyond it seemed to radiate anxiety, threat, something wrong. I had spent dozens of nights in the mountains, both with company and alone, and I had never felt anything like this before.

There was no rational reason for alarm. The icon with the number "3" in my mask was still glowing yellow; no threats were being detected nearby. And yet the feeling wouldn't go away. On the contrary—the closer I got to the camp, the stronger it became.

When I rounded the outcrop, I saw the firelight and the striders sitting calmly around it. There was still no sign of danger. I even felt a little embarrassed by my fear and decided not to mention it to Art—just to push it out of my head.

The Reds were already resting.

Zara was curled up on her side, her head on her backpack, wrapped in a blanket. Ion lay nearby, also on his side, using his pack as a pillow. Fang was sprawled flat on his back on the ground next to his lounger, arms and legs flung wide, breathing heavily and deeply. All three of them looked sound asleep.

Art was standing a little apart. When he saw me, he motioned me over. As I came closer, I noticed that the chairs were gone. In their place, on the grass, were two strange objects—something between a sleeping bag and a low, single-person tent. They looked like miniature sarcophagi.

Art's calm voice sounded in my clip.

"These are our sleeping pods for the night. Look—the top opens, you climb inside, then close it. The fabric cells adapt on their own: air flows freely, heat stays in."

"Don't you worry that the Reds might try something?" I asked, finally voicing the thought that had been gnawing at me, switching to voice message as well.

Art gave a slight smile.

"In this situation? Highly unlikely. The Net Aide has identified them, saved their profiles, and uploaded their scans to the cloud. Your mask and clip have nine cameras—in threat mode they record continuous video and transmit it, along with all sensor data, to remote storage. So yes, they could attack—theoretically. But they wouldn't be able to escape responsibility. And they know that perfectly well. They're not stupid enough to risk their freedom like that."

His explanation calmed me somewhat, though the vague, formless sense of danger still lingered somewhere inside. I forced myself to dismiss it and, following his instructions, climbed into the sleeping pod.

The top closed softly, almost fusing shut. I felt myself lying on a comfortable mattress, my head resting on a pillow. The air was fresh; breathing was easy. Inside, it was neither hot nor cold. Despite the fact that it was late spring and nights in the mountains were still quite chilly, I felt warm and unexpectedly comfortable.

I tried to relax and fall asleep—but sleep stubbornly refused to come.

I tossed and turned for what must have been over an hour before I understood: it was the same anxiety keeping me awake. That sticky sense of unknown danger. And the longer time passed, the stronger it grew.

At some point the tension became unbearable. I couldn't take it anymore. I flipped the top open, got up, and looked around.

Everything was quiet. The fire was dying down; beyond its fading glow, complete darkness reigned.

I climbed out of the pod without really knowing what I intended to do and headed toward the edge of the outcrop. Reaching the right-hand rock face, I turned toward the trail we had come down earlier.

And that's when I saw it.

About ten meters away, near the slope, something was frozen in place.

Against the night—already black—it looked far, far darker, like a blot of perfect, absolute darkness. It reflected no glimmer, no shade, no nuance—only a bottomless, mesmerizing void. Something inside me collapsed.

A wave of terror crashed over me—physical, almost tangible. It started at the base of my skull, ran down my spine, and flooded my legs, which suddenly went weak. I staggered, barely managing to stay on my feet.

And at that exact moment, a calm, distinct voice sounded in my head:

“Black Jellyfish.”

The blot of darkness shifted and slowly began to creep toward the trail. In the night, a silhouette emerged—indeed resembling a jellyfish, only about the size of a small stool.

A Creature.

A completely ordinary Creature—one of the many I had seen hundreds, if not thousands of times before. And now, as was their custom, this Creature had “introduced” itself.

The wave of terror vanished instantly.

My legs obeyed me again, and I drew a deep, relieved breath.

“You okay?” Art's calm voice came through the clip.

I turned. He was standing about ten steps away, watching me closely. The resonator was in his hand.

“Yes. I'm fine,” I exhaled. “Just a Creature. A Black Jellyfish. Just... very scary-looking.”

“Yes, I saw it,” Art nodded. “Impressive, I'll give you that.”

We waited until the Creature had crawled away and then headed back to the camp. I automatically glanced at the Reds.

Fang and Ion were lying exactly where they had been, as if asleep.

But Zara was gone.

Panic flared in my chest—only to be extinguished instantly by Art's short, firm phrase:

"It's all right. Zara, you can come out. There's no danger."

A silhouette detached itself from one of the trees.

It was Zara.

She approached us unhurriedly. She was holding a resonator as well.

"What happened?" she asked. Her voice was calm, but there was tension beneath it, carefully restrained.

Art gave a brief explanation of what had occurred. Zara nodded silently, turned, walked back to her pack without a word, lay down under the blanket, and seemed to fall asleep almost instantly.

I was struck by her steadiness. I was still trembling slightly, feeling weak, lightheaded. I sat down on a rock and tried to calm myself.

Art came over and stopped beside me.

"You know," he said thoughtfully, "I think I've seen that Creature before. Yesterday morning, when we were leaving Lemar's place. It was on the square, some distance away. It just didn't look quite so black back then."

I tried to remember. Yes—one of the Creatures drifting among the tourists and reporters might have looked similar to the Black Jellyfish. But I wasn't sure.

"Interesting," Art said quietly. "I've never heard of a Creature following someone. Though..."

He broke off.

"Never mind. Not now. Let's get some sleep. Drink some water and try to rest. Good night."

He returned to his "sarcophagus" and closed it over himself.

I followed his advice. Sitting on the rock, I took out my bottle of spring water and drank slowly, in small sips. It helped. The last remnants of anxiety gradually dissolved, and I felt calm again. I screwed the cap back on, stowed the bottle in my pack, lay down in the pod—and, to my own surprise, fell asleep almost immediately.

...

When I woke and opened the top, it was already late morning.

I got up and saw that Fang and Ion were still asleep, stretched out on the grass in the same spots. The pot was hanging over the fire, water boiling inside. Art was sitting on a rock with a mug in his hands, and Zara was perched on her fully assembled backpack. Thin wisps of steam rose from their mugs.

Noticing me, Art lifted his mug in greeting.

"Morning, Mac. Want some coffee?"

"Morning," I nodded, coming closer. "I'd love some."

Art took another mug from the "table" and began pouring coffee from the pot. I glanced at Zara.

She met my gaze... and smiled.

It was a smile I hadn't expected, hadn't dared hope for—light, soft, kind. Beautiful. In that instant, I felt completely, unreasonably happy.

"Hi," she said, then immediately looked away. It sounded as if we'd known each other for a very long time—and at the same time, as if we were at least good friends already.

"Hi..." I muttered, still staring at her, slightly dazed. Only when Art handed me the mug did I come back to myself, take it, and sip the hot, fragrant coffee.

"Time to pack up," Art said, pulling me back to reality. "Work's waiting."

"Right," I said quickly, turning to gather my things.

When the packs were ready, I emptied the pot, and set it down in the grass to cool.

"Well," Art said, "time to say goodbye."

"Yes," Zara nodded thoughtfully. "I'll wake them," she gestured toward Fang and Ion, "and we'll head out too."

She extended her hand to Art.

"Take care, Art."

He shook her hand and smiled. Then she turned to me.

"Bye, Mac."

She looked up and held out her hand.

I shook it, gently—and in that same second, the realization hit me: we were parting now. And we might never meet again.

My heart dropped. A sharp wave of panic and despair washed over me.

As if reading my thoughts, Zara held my hand for a moment longer, then said:

"I gave Art my Net ID. You don't have a terminal yet. If you want, you can get it from him later. Maybe someday we'll talk again... or message."

She smiled once more.

I felt an overwhelming relief, as if I'd been pulled back from the edge. She turned and walked away.

Art gave me a gentle tug at the elbow. I obediently turned and followed him.

"Don't forget the pot," he said, a hint of amusement in his voice.

I went back, grabbed it, and before catching up with Art, glanced once more at Zara's retreating figure. Then I turned sharply and hurried after him.

Chapter 9. The First Ones

We got back to work. As before, we split up on either side of the trail—the foothills stretched gently away in both directions, covered in short grass, easy enough to walk across. Almost immediately I spotted the first decent nugget, told Art about it, and he moved in to collect.

A little later, as we went on, I noticed an old wooden bridge crossing the river. The thought hit me at once: this was where my path and Zara’s diverged, and today there would be no chance of “accidentally” running into her again. My thoughts kept circling back to her. I replayed her look, her words—especially the last ones: “*Maybe sometime we’ll talk... or message.*”

What had she meant by that? And what was I supposed to do now?

Of course, I wanted to call her or write to her right away. But I knew she wasn’t expecting that. And more than anything, I was afraid of seeming intrusive—of irritating her.

Art tried a few times to start a conversation, but I answered absently, in short phrases. Then one of his questions finally caught my attention and pulled me out of the whirl of memories.

“Hey, Mac,” I heard him say through the clip. “Do you remember when we were sitting at Lemar’s, talking about similarities and differences between Variants? About how, for example, the languages people speak are almost identical? I said back then that there was an explanation I personally agreed with.”

“Yeah,” I nodded. “I remember.”

“Hold on—another one,” Art interrupted himself, having spotted a new nugget.

We fell silent. As always during collection, Art worked with his back to the rock, scanning the surroundings. When he finished and the tackle retracted back into his pack, he went on:

“So. In our Variant, there’s what’s known as the Hypothesis of the First Ones.”

“The what?” I asked.

“The Hypothesis of the First Ones,” Art repeated—this time sending it as a text message. The words appeared capitalized. Then he switched back to voice.

“It exists in academic circles. And notice—*hypothesis*, not theory, not concept. There’s no hard scientific proof. But it’s hugely popular in the Net. There are dozens of forums and communities discussing it. Online, by the way, people more often don’t say *the First Ones*—they call them *the Primes*.”

He sent *Primes* as text as well—capitalized again—and continued with voice:

“According to the hypothesis, the Primes are the ones who created the Gates. And with them, all the technology of transitions between Variants. Possibly the Variants themselves. In other words, it was the Primes who caused the Fractures—the events from which these worlds emerged.”

He paused, clearly giving me time to digest that. I caught myself walking with my eyes fixed on the ground and forced myself to look up again, scanning for nuggets. Almost at once I spotted a small one and called Art over. As he collected it, he continued:

“What matters most here isn’t even the details—not how omnipotent the Primes might be, although the Net argues about that endlessly—but the very assumption that they exist at all.”

“How could they not?” I said thoughtfully. “Someone had to create the Gates. I mean—the Gates and everything connected to them.”

“Well, theoretically,” Art said, raising a finger slightly, “it’s not entirely impossible that the Gates, the Fractures, the Storms, Essence—all of it—are simply natural phenomena. Like rainbows. Or seasons. Or hurricanes. Or... say, gravity.”

I thought about it. I pictured the Gates. Essence. Storms. Even the Rifts of worlds—yes, all of that *could* be seen as objective natural processes, forces of reality.

But the Gates—no. That didn't work. The Gates felt artificial. Deliberate.

I told Art exactly that. Even from a distance, I saw him smile and nod.

"I think so too," he agreed. "And it's not just the Gates—it's the structure of the worlds themselves. Look: the Rifts happened thousands of years ago, at least. More likely tens, maybe hundreds of thousands. In that time, languages should have changed—diverged beyond recognition. But they haven't. They're almost identical. The probability of that being a coincidence is practically zero."

I thought it over—and completely agreed. I told him so.

"Let's keep going," Art continued, clearly satisfied. "Science and technology. Or rather—key discoveries and inventions. They're almost identical across different worlds. The simplest example is the Net. We call it the Net, you call it the Internet, but the essence is the same. Some Variants don't have it yet, but that's most likely just a matter of time. And that brings us to the next important point.

Key scientific and technological breakthroughs in different worlds are nearly identical—but they happen at different times. It's as if someone is watching each world from the outside and, when a world 'ripens,' when it meets certain criteria, that someone simply *whispers* the next breakthrough into the minds of the people living there."

He paused briefly, then went on:

"This is especially noticeable with destructive technologies. And that's the third point. They only appear once humanity has become sufficiently civilized and wise not to destroy itself with them."

It didn't even occur to me to argue. Everything he said sounded perfectly logical, internally consistent.

"Yes, wars exist. Mass killings exist. In most Variants, all of this still happens," he continued. "But in none of them has humanity completely wiped itself out. No world has erased intelligent life from the planet. And yet—it easily could have. Just imagine how much higher the risk would have been if, say, in your Variant, technologies of global destruction—like the atomic bomb—had appeared significantly earlier than they actually did."

I imagined it.

And felt a cold wave of terror.

"The people of the Fourth Variant came the closest to the edge," Art went on. "A global catastrophe did happen there. Humanity was thrown back centuries. But they survived. Civilization—damaged, fragmented, reduced—still endured."

He hesitated for a moment, as if unsure whether to continue. Then, apparently, he decided to:

"By the way... Zara was born and raised there. She told me this morning."

I froze. Stared at him. My heart began to pound, my breathing faltered.

Art stopped as well and looked at me—calmly, even with a hint of sympathy.

"Don't worry," he said. "She's lived in our Variant for a long time now. And as far as I understand, she rarely visits her home world—if at all. But we striders have to go there regularly. Storms happen there too, same as everywhere else."

Gradually, I came back to myself. We started walking again. For a while, neither of us spoke.

Then Art moved a little closer and nodded ahead.

"You should try not to forget about the job," he said. "You just walked past a nugget like that."

I looked up—and realized that once again I'd been trudging along, staring blindly at the ground, seeing nothing around me. I felt embarrassed.

"Sorry," I muttered.

"It's fine," Art said encouragingly, as he latched the tacle onto the nugget. When its glow faded almost completely into the background, he retracted the tacle.

"So. Back to the topic," he went on. "The hypothesis of the First Ones claims that both the Gates and all advanced technologies were created by the Primes. They're usually imagined as an ancient—almost or even fully omnipotent—civilization. And after that, opinions diverge. Some believe the Primes are still invisibly present among us. Others think they have their own Variant. World Zero."

I looked at Art and noticed that he was watching my reaction closely, as if it genuinely mattered to him. I thought for a moment—and almost immediately understood why.

"You believe this Zero World exists, don't you?" I said slowly. "And you hope to reach it."

Art nodded, smiling faintly. His eyes lit up with genuine fascination, with the focused intensity of a researcher—and, I thought, with a trace of obsession. And that obsession suddenly spread to me as well. I imagined what it would be like to solve this riddle, to find a way to reach those who could create entire worlds.

"Are you with me?" he asked quietly. He tried to sound calm, but I could hear the tension in his voice.

I nodded firmly, meeting his gaze. And all at once I felt it—a goal. A real one. Something vast and meaningful, worth devoting a life to. The feeling was exhilarating.

Art seemed to read it on my face. He broke into a wide smile and let out a relieved breath.

"Great, Mac. Together, we'll definitely have better odds."

"I sure hope so," I said wryly.

We both laughed.

Art turned and walked on. Even from behind, he looked satisfied.

I followed, forcing myself to focus again—scanning the rocks, doing the work.

The First Ones... I thought. *I wonder—if they were present in our world, what would they look like?* And then it hit me.

"Art," I said aloud, without using the clip. He turned around.

"Don't you think it's possible that the First Ones are the Creatures? Or—put another way—that the Creatures *are* the First Ones?"

Art didn't seem surprised in the least. He simply smiled, nodded, and kept walking. Naturally, I felt a bit disappointed by his reaction.

Then his voice sounded in my clip.

"Of course, Mac. You're right in the sense that the thought practically suggests itself. And yes—both I and many others have thought about it."

I felt a flush of embarrassment at my own naïveté. Of course. How could I have imagined that such an obvious idea hadn't occurred to anyone before me?

“The Creatures are mysterious, enigmatic, and clearly very powerful,” Art went on. “They can do things that are inaccessible to us—sometimes even incomprehensible. They communicate mentally without clips, can keep humans at a distance, and are somehow able to suppress or even disrupt any attempts to study them. All of that lies far beyond the capabilities of ordinary living beings. And yet...”

He paused for a moment, choosing his words.

“And yet it’s still not the same scale. Not the same level of ability or scope that the First Ones would have. And besides...” He hesitated again. “It would be too simple. You see?”

He turned to me and smiled—a faint, almost sad smile.

“The Primes aren’t that simple or banal—to just step out in front of us from newly opened Gates in our worlds.”

I caught myself nodding in agreement.

“And still,” Art continued, “personally, I think there *is* something to it. Somehow. In some way we don’t yet understand. Both the Creatures themselves and the manner of their appearance—specifically like this, through the Gates—are connected to the First Ones. I’m certain of it, for reasons I can’t quite put into words.”

Again, I found myself agreeing with him silently. Art fell quiet, seemingly lost in thought over what he had just said.

We kept moving and continued picking—or, in strider slang, *harvesting goodies and pies*—until evening, stopping only briefly for a dry snack. I had plenty to think about, but by now I was keeping my focus under control, not letting my thoughts distract me from the work.

As dusk began to settle, I saw that we had reached the point where the trail merged back into the road, becoming its shoulder. The river formed a small bend here, and between the river and the road stood a wooden building with a wide veranda, furnished with heavy wooden tables and benches.

I knew the place. It was the *Bear’s Den* restaurant, famous for its excellent mushroom soup and fragrant grilled meats. I realized this was the endpoint of our route for the day—and I was genuinely glad of it.

Chapter 10. Assault

I caught the smell of meat sizzling on the grill before we even reached the veranda. A moment later, a delicate mushroom aroma joined it. Quite a few people were already seated at the heavy wooden tables—tourists and locals alike—and it took us a while to find a free spot. Eventually, though, we noticed a small table tucked away in the far corner.

Some of the patrons were laughing loudly, others were arguing animatedly, while a few simply sat in silence, gazing at the sunset sky with a massive beer mug clasped in one hand. The atmosphere was disarmingly simple and warm, as if everyone here had decided, at least for a short while, to forget about work, worries, and obligations.

When we sat down, I glanced at Art and noticed his mask and clip. The mask had subtly changed shape, a dark frame now visible around it. The clip had turned fully skin-toned, flatter, and seemed almost smaller. The mask now looked indistinguishable from ordinary glasses, and the clip was nearly impossible to notice. When I took off my own mask and clip to inspect them, I saw that the same transformation had happened to mine.

“That’s to avoid drawing attention,” Art explained. “In its standard form, the mask still looks a bit unusual in most Variants. The clip even more so. And anything unusual becomes a distinguishing feature. We try to avoid those.”

He hesitated, then added, almost reluctantly, “Please put them back on. Threat mode—remember.”

I hurriedly put the mask and clip back on and gave him an apologetic smile.

“Do people wear glasses in all Variants?” I asked.

“Unfortunately, no,” Art sighed. “In places where glasses aren’t a thing, we have to wear the mask as contact lenses. Which is noticeably uncomfortable. But that’s the job.”

“And what—no one ever notices the lenses or the clip, even like this?”

“It happens,” Art admitted with a helpless, ironic shrug. “That’s what the resonator and forgetting mode are for.”

I nodded.

A waitress approached our table—a cheerful, pleasant-looking young woman. She was clearly local, but her English was nearly fluent. We ordered two large bowls of mushroom soup, homemade bread, a shared grill platter, and two mugs of tea.

“We also have fresh draft beer—we brew it ourselves,” she offered, but without a word we both politely declined.

When she left, I asked, “You’re at least indifferent to alcohol, right? That’s the impression I get.”

“At least,” Art smiled. “And I can even tell you why. First, I like to stay fully in control of myself at all times. I don’t enjoy anything interfering with that. And second...” He paused deliberately. “Once you become a strider, you learn to take care of your Essence. Not to waste it.”

“And alcohol...” I began, then immediately understood.

Art nodded, confirming my realization, and decided to elaborate anyway.

“All drugs work the same way. They let quinta leak out of a person’s contour, causing euphoria. But unlike sliding, chemical substances—including alcohol—don’t involve an initial boost, no prior pumping of quinta. So your Essence level drops below baseline. It takes time to recover. That’s where that unpleasant post-drinking state comes from.”

I remembered our mountain picnic, Fang's flask, and imagined the "corona" flaring around my own contour. And that Zara might have seen it... though no, she had taken off her mask and clip then. Still, I felt a flush of embarrassment.

As if reading my thoughts, Art tried to reassure me.

"Don't worry. We're not that strict about alcohol. That's just me. Laar, for example, enjoys a beer or two, and Ellen is a great connoisseur of fine wines. Speaking of Ellen—here. Read this."

An envelope icon appeared in the corner of my mask. As soon as I focused on it, a text window unfolded.

From: Ellen

To: Team Ellen

Subject: Additional boxes

Hi, striders,

You've done great work over the past couple of days—congratulations. As the analysts predicted, the release associated with the emergence of the new Gates turned out to be exceptionally rich. All of our boxes are already more than half full, so to avoid wasting time on pumping tomorrow, AIO will deliver additional boxes in the morning.

Your contacts will reach out to each of you individually to arrange the details. They'll also accompany you for the remainder of this picking operation—as you can imagine, with this much quinta on hand, extra security won't hurt.

Stay in touch,

Ellen

I looked at Art.

"I've already contacted Kirsten—she's our liaison from AIO," he said. "She'll come by your place at eight tomorrow morning. We'll be working together all day."

I nodded.

The waitress returned with a tray, set the plates and mugs on the table, and, flashing a coquettish smile at Art, walked away. We started eating.

Both the mushroom soup and the grill were outstanding. When we finished our meals, the girl came back once more. Art asked her to bring the check and call a taxi.

"We always have a few cars on standby," she rattled off, gathering the plates and, for some reason, looking only at Art. "To the left of the entrance, in the parking lot—you'll see them."

After we paid—Art covered the bill, and judging by the waitress's reaction, tipped generously—we stepped outside and indeed saw three well-worn cars parked nearby, each with a local taxi logo on the roof.

I gave our address to one of the drivers—a stern-looking guy with thick black eyebrows and neatly groomed mustaches. He nodded and smiled professionally, just with his lips; his eyes remained serious.

We got in. Art took the front seat beside the driver, and I settled into the back, leaning comfortably against the seatback and watching the road through the window. The car pulled out of the parking lot and turned right onto the mountain road climbing along the slope. To my relief, the driver didn't speed—the road was winding, with sharp turns coming one after another.

It happened when we were rounding yet another bend.

Everything that followed unfolded incredibly fast, yet for me time seemed to slow, stretch, allowing me to notice and remember an astonishing number of details. The car slowed slightly, entered the turn, skirting the rock face—and at that exact moment, the clip shrieked:

“Beeeeep-beeeeeep-beeeeeep!”

An orange icon with the number 1 flared on my mask.

Why orange right away?—a panicked thought flashed. There should have been yellow first...

Art ducked sharply, folding down and to the side as much as the space between the seat and the dashboard allowed. At the same time, his hand shot forward, and the resonator stuck to the dashboard as if magnetized. The lens at its top darted back and forth, searching for a target.

Five seconds, I remembered. It takes five seconds for the impulse to form.

I jerked my head to the right. At the very edge of the sheer rock wall, a tiny orange speck glowed.

A resonator.

The next instant, a thin, needle-like blue beam shot out of it, and the clip emitted a nasty:

“Vzzzzzt!”

The sound carried something of high-voltage wires humming, metal scraping against glass, and toothache all at once.

The beam struck our driver in the temple—and vanished. The man went limp, his hands sliding uselessly off the steering wheel.

I turned my head right again. The resonator’s speck was still there. Still orange.

Now it needs another five seconds to recharge... right? I thought desperately. The next shot—at Art. And me... what can I do?

I felt like a spectator, watching a scene unfold onstage from a theater seat. And for some reason, it didn’t even occur to me that I was one of the actors.

And then the speck outside suddenly flared red. It was as if something began to pulse directly inside my skull:

“Beep-beep-beep-beep-beep!”

Without thinking, purely on instinct, I lunged sideways, twisting my head and dropping toward the seat. Or rather—just beginning to drop.

The air was sliced again by the vile:

“Vzzzzzt!”

This time I didn’t see the blue beam—I had already turned my head away.

And then everything vanished.

Chapter 11. The Freeze

It happened instantly.

A moment ago, I was in the car. I could see the slackened driver and Art ducking low, the seats they were sitting on, the road stretching ahead beyond the windshield, the icons glowing on the mask display. I could hear the engine running and the tires humming against the asphalt, hear the piercing, continuous alarm in the clip—cut off, at the very last instant, by the sound of a shot.

And now all of it was gone.

I could see nothing and feel nothing—not even my own breathing, not even the beating of my heart. I tried to perceive at least darkness, or to hear the silence around me—but there was neither. There wasn't even an "around." No space. No background. Nothing at all.

In the first moments, panic surged through me. The state was too unfamiliar, too alien, and that alone made it terrifying. But it didn't last long. Almost immediately, I realized what had happened.

I was frozen.

Not dead—frozen.

My condition matched Art's description exactly.

That realization brought a measure of relief. I remembered him saying that portable resonators are usually set to short freezes—most often, about one minute. I decided to wait it out. I even began counting silently to myself.

"One (one-two-three). Two (one-two-three). Three (one-two-three) ..."

I counted to sixty. Then, just to be safe, to a hundred.

The freeze didn't lift.

I waited longer. Then longer still.

At least five minutes had passed—possibly more.

And then a troubling thought surfaced: what was happening to my body in the real world right now?

Had Art avoided being frozen? Had he managed to stop the car? Or had it flown off the road—crashed into a tree, maybe caught fire? Was I bleeding out somewhere? Burning alive?

At that thought—and at the realization that I could do absolutely nothing about it, that I was completely helpless—terror took hold of me.

Only I didn't feel the usual signs of fear. No chill spreading through my body. No goosebumps. No hair standing on end.

My terror felt like vacuum.

And somehow that made it worse.

For a while, I could feel nothing but that terror. I could think of nothing except the certainty that right now—this very second, or the next—I was going to die.

But death didn't come.

Time passed, and nothing changed.

Gradually, I began to calm down. Of course, I thought, maybe I am dying—slowly, from blood loss or internal injuries. But the thought felt distant now, almost abstract. The sharp edge of panic was gone.

How much time had passed?

I tried to estimate it—and couldn't.

Ten minutes, perhaps. Or many hours.

I had lost all sense of time.

Which meant it no longer mattered how long I would “actually” remain in this state. Because any span of time—even a few minutes in the outside world—could stretch here, inside me, into long hours, days, or years.

With that thought came boredom.

No—not boredom exactly.

A kind of lethal despair.

A sticky, viscous sensation that pulled at me like a swamp. Thoughts began to move in circles, repeating themselves, each loop slower than the last. There was nothing to hold on to.

And worse—no desire to hold on to anything.

Everything felt indifferent. There was no strength left to think or to feel. Only emptiness, and a heavy, syrupy apathy.

Somewhere at the fading edge of consciousness, a fragment of a thought drifted by:

Extremes converge.

What? What was that about?

Ah. Right.

Probably about how so much had happened to me in the last few days—so many vivid, astonishing, exhilarating things—that it had drawn its opposite toward it. This. The total absence of everything. The gloom. The void.

Wait. No.

I caught myself.

But all those things—they *did* happen. And they're still with me now. In my memories.

It's not for nothing, I realized, that erasing even this last thing a person has—their memories—requires a separate resonator charge.

And then it hit me.

A flash of insight.

A saving idea.

Why don't I try to remember everything that's happened to me—and write it all down? Not now, later, just dictate it in message mode.

It *is* interesting. It *is* extraordinary. This doesn't happen to just anyone. And that means someone, somewhere, might actually want to read it.

I felt a sudden surge of strength, as if conjured out of nowhere. Thoughts began to appear, linking to one another, gradually settling into a steady, almost businesslike flow.

And for the first time since the freeze began, I felt like I had something to do.

Where do I even start?

Of course—I start with how I woke up with that premonition. That morning. The morning the new Gates opened.

Before that, I should probably explain, briefly, what the Gates are. What they look like. And then I'll tell the story of meeting Art...

I hesitated.

I was going to write about Art. About other people. Without asking their permission. That felt, at the very least, impolite.

The solution came instantly, as if it had been waiting for me. I would change names. And of course I wouldn't mention anyone's last name—except, perhaps, public figures everyone already knows.

And Zara's name? Would I change that too?

I wavered. Anything that touched Zara felt like touching *her*—without her consent. And yet I couldn't leave her out. Not anymore. She'd become too important to me.

Another precaution wouldn't hurt, either. I wouldn't use geographic names—no cities, no countries. And I wouldn't describe exact locations, especially not where the nuggets had been. Because what if nuggets tended to appear more often in the same places? What if there was a pattern to their emergence—something you could learn, and then predict where they'd show up next?

I should ask Art whether such a pattern exists.

And then I remembered where I was.

Frozen.

And it occurred to me that I had no idea when I'd get a chance to talk to Art again. The thought made me sigh—quietly, without meaning to.

Stop.

What...?

I just sighed, didn't I?

Or did I only imagine it?

And then, completely automatically, I opened my eyes.

That's it. The freeze was over.

I took another breath—this time with an almost painful sense of relief.

I looked around and realized I was at home, lying on my own couch. By the table, slumped into a chair turned toward me, sat Art. He was watching me closely.

The scene immediately reminded me of the day we'd met. That had been—what—two days ago? And yet it felt like long weeks had passed, if not months.

When he saw my eyes open, Art smiled warmly.

"You're back," he said. "We call it 'thawing out.' How do you feel?"

"I think I'm okay," I managed, returning his smile as best I could. "Though I wouldn't say I enjoyed the experience."

"Pretty impressive reaction," came a woman's voice from somewhere to the side. "And considering it was your first freeze—and it lasted a full three hours—that's actually excellent."

I pushed myself up on the couch and turned toward the voice.

By the window, leaning against the wall with her arms folded, stood a tall, slim woman—young, but unmistakably adult. Her hair was pale, almost white, pulled back into a ponytail; her skin was fair; her gaze sharp and lively. She had the look of a professional track athlete—fast, disciplined, all coiled energy. Like Art, she studied me with open curiosity, a faint smile playing on her lips.

"Hi, Mac." She lifted a hand in greeting. "I'm Kirsten. I work with AIO. I'll be accompanying you two for the rest of this picking run."

She flicked a friendly, ironic look at Art.

"You guys clearly need it."

Then she looked back at me.

"Nice to meet you, Kirsten," I said honestly. "Art told me you'd be joining us. And that you'd bring an extra box."

She nodded, still smiling.

"Kirsten flew in on the evening flight and was actually planning to meet us in the morning," Art explained. "But given... everything, I pulled her out of a perfectly comfortable hotel bed and asked her to come right away."

"Good thing I rented a car at the airport," Kirsten added. "Otherwise I'd have missed you thawing out. I got here a few minutes ago—haven't even had time to grill Art properly."

"All right, so what *did* happen?" I said, turning back to Art. "Tell me what came next. After they froze me."

Art started in. He spoke concisely, matter-of-factly—but he didn't omit a single important detail.

According to him, the moment the car rounded the bend and he heard the clip alarm and spotted the active resonator outside, he understood at once that the lens was positioned in a narrow cleft between two rocks. The shooter, apparently, was hiding behind the cliff itself—trying to keep our scanner from tagging him.

And as soon as Art grasped that, he realized something else just as fast: our only chance was to keep moving forward, to push past the line where the cliff would block the resonator completely.

On that stretch, the road curved left. The shooter's calculation was obvious: once the driver lost control, the car would keep going straight and slide off the road into the ditch.

Art's task, then, was to do two things at once: stay as concealed as possible from the active lens—using the side of the car and the back of his seat as cover—while reaching the accelerator pedal with one hand and pressing it, and at the same time turning the steering wheel smoothly to the left with the other, keeping the car on the road.

Both, fortunately, he managed.

By the time the car cleared the line of fire, Art's resonator—secured to the dashboard—had already finished forming its impulse. Art released the accelerator but stayed low behind the seatback. The car immediately began to slow and came to a stop a few seconds later.

For a while, Art waited for the shooter to appear from behind the mountainside. But no one emerged, and the hostile resonator vanished—the scanner no longer detected it.

Moving as quickly and quietly as possible, Art got out of the car and went around its front, using the vehicle itself as cover. Then he dragged the driver out of the front seat and moved him to the back, placing him next to me. After that, Art got behind the wheel and headed straight for my place.

On the way, he contacted Kirsten immediately. He kept it brief, avoided details, told her there had been an incident, and asked her to come right away. As he drove, he kept glancing at me and the driver in the rearview mirror, half-expecting one of us to come to at any moment.

Neither of us did.

By the time Art reached my house, both the driver and I were still frozen. He unlocked the door using the key from my pocket, carried me inside, and laid me out on the couch. The driver he placed on the bed.

The driver thawed first—exactly two hours after the attack.

Art had to act immediately. He used his resonator in forgetting mode and then began calmly convincing the confused man that he had suddenly lost consciousness at the wheel, and that Art had miraculously avoided a crash by grabbing the steering wheel in time.

Once the car had stopped, Art—presenting himself as a medical professional—had supposedly checked the driver for signs of a heart attack or stroke. Seeing none, and noting that the man simply looked like someone who'd fallen asleep at the wheel, Art decided to bring him to the nearest settlement—here—and figure out whether a doctor was needed.

As Art went on, luck intervened.

Before he even finished his explanation, the driver interrupted him and launched into his own story: he hadn't slept in nearly two days. He'd driven a client several hundred kilometers to the airport, then had to cover a shift for a sick colleague. So it was very fortunate that Art hadn't called a doctor—and especially fortunate he hadn't called the police.

As he spoke, the driver was already moving briskly toward his car, barely glancing at me lying on the couch. Art walked him out, returned his keys, and the man drove off immediately, thanking Art profusely for his understanding and help. Apparently, he'd been worried the whole time that Art might still call the police.

Art returned to the house and waited—first for Kirsten to arrive, and then for me to wake up. Or rather, to thaw.

Both Art and Kirsten seemed to regard everything he'd done, and the way he'd handled the situation, as entirely routine. To me, though, it was all genuinely impressive. I was just about to say so when Art tried to stop me—and Kirsten cut in first.

"You can direct those compliments at me instead," she said. "Unlike him, I don't suffer from excessive modesty."

I looked at her questioningly, then at Art. He was smiling with his eyes lowered, looking both embarrassed and quietly proud.

"When I went through Agency training," he explained, "she was my instructor."

I looked at Kirsten again, seeing her differently now. She turned to me and made a small, ironic curtsy. It almost distracted me from a thought that had just surfaced—but I caught it.

"Wait," I asked. "Aren't you taught everything through the e2n interface?"

Kirsten answered readily.

"Downloads transfer knowledge—information, essentially. But skills and abilities—the capacity to *apply* that information—depend on the individual: physical attributes, reflexes, natural aptitude, and so on. That's why

strider training combines a series of downloads with honing: hands-on practice, drills, and real skill development.”

I nodded, understanding.

“All right,” Kirsten said, “let’s get back to today. We can speculate all night about who staged the attack, but I suggest we leave that to the analysts—that’s their job. As for us, let’s try to get some sleep. It’s already past three a.m. I see only two sleeping spots here. Art, set up a sleeper for me, and I’ll release the flies in the meantime.”

Art nodded in understanding and reached for his backpack. Apparently, nothing in her words struck him as odd. I, on the other hand, was staring at Kirsten with a silent question written all over my face.

“‘Flies’—that’s what we call them—are mini-drones with cameras and scanners,” she explained, taking a small container out of her pack. “Unlike real flies, they don’t bother people. Quite the opposite—they keep their distance. But they’re excellent at securing a perimeter and will raise an alarm at the slightest threat. Here—look.”

She showed me the open container. Inside, nestled in custom slots, were four tiny black mechanisms—about the size and shape of actual flies.

The next second, they lifted off almost silently and hovered in the air, forming a neat square. After hanging there for a couple of seconds, they shifted into a line, moved together toward the slightly open window, and slipped outside.

“That’s it,” Kirsten said, stretching. “Now we can sleep peacefully.”

“Are you sure you want the sleeper?” Art asked. At his feet, his backpack on the floor was already taking on the familiar sarcophagus-like shape. “We can offer you a luxurious bed. Right, Mac?”

“Of course,” I said quickly. “I can sleep in the sleeper. I actually liked it.”

“Thank you for the concern, gentlemen,” Kirsten replied with dry irony. “But I’m more used to sleepers. It’s not just you striders who spend nights in mountains and forests. We do too—quite often.”

The Essence layer in my mask was inactive, so I couldn’t see Kirsten’s background glow. It was only now, from her words, that I realized she wasn’t a strider—and therefore must have been an agent transferred into our Variant through the Gates, her Essence boosted to the required level.

We settled in. Art and Kirsten, as far as I could tell, fell asleep almost instantly. I, however, couldn’t fall asleep at all. The freeze had probably acted as a kind of substitute for sleep for my body.

I spent the entire night in a thick, viscous half-doze, periodically sinking into a nightmare—always the same one. I dreamed that I was no longer myself, but the Black Jellyfish—a Creature made of absolute, all-consuming darkness. As if on the outside I remained in the ordinary world, while inside I was trapped in a permanent, unending freeze, composed of impenetrable gloom and bottomless emptiness.

Chapter 12. “The Wedding Cake”

I woke up late, feeling drained, with the dull sensation of a blunt needle lodged somewhere in my head. I opened my eyes and saw the now-familiar THREAT MODE icon floating in front of me.

Right. I’d fallen asleep wearing the mask. And the clip as well.

I realized that this was the second night in a row I hadn’t taken them off—and yet I hadn’t felt the slightest discomfort. Not even when I rolled onto my side and the clip and the arm of the mask ended up between my head and the pillow. The mask hadn’t fogged up, hadn’t gotten dirty, remained perfectly clear—as if it weren’t there at all. Overall, the devices were barely noticeable, almost nonexistent.

I got up from the couch and discovered that both Art and Kirsten were already up—and, judging by the looks of it, had been for a while. Art was sitting on a chair in his favorite pose—legs stretched out, arms crossed over his chest—staring at the wall. By now I knew that in moments like this he wasn’t daydreaming; he was working, using the mask and n2e.

Kirsten was standing by the open window, seemingly studying the surroundings. Or perhaps she wasn’t looking out the window at all, but at her mask’s display. Most likely, she was doing both—overlaying the landscape with information from the Layers. My guess was immediately confirmed when Kirsten took the now-familiar container out of her pocket, opened it, and one after another, four “flies” zipped back inside. She closed the container and slipped it back into her pocket.

She’s very attractive, I suddenly thought, looking at Kirsten.

She was standing half-turned toward me, and the light from the window outlined her refined, elegant face and her slim, athletic figure. It was surprising that the thought hadn’t even occurred to me yesterday. And today, I was registering her attractiveness as if from the outside—through the neutral gaze of someone with no personal stake in it.

I myself felt completely indifferent to this very attractive woman.

And of course, I knew why.

Starting the evening before last, the attractiveness of all women in the world had, for me, condensed into a single person. It was as if no other women existed anymore.

As if sensing my gaze, Kirsten turned toward me.

“Awake, Mac?” she said briskly. “Just in time. We’re leaving in half an hour.”

Art also “surfaced” from virtual space, smiled, and gave me a friendly nod.

“I didn’t oversleep too badly, did I?” I mumbled apologetically. “Didn’t think to set an alarm.”

“It’s fine,” Art said reassuringly. “We’re on schedule. Go get yourself together and let’s go. We’re starting today’s route at the *Bear’s Den*—we’ll have breakfast there.”

I hurried to the bathroom. Hesitated for a moment about whether to take off the mask and clip to shower—and decided that since no one could see me, I could.

We did make it within half an hour. Or rather, I did. Brushing my teeth, shaving, and a cool shower almost brought me back to normal, though faint echoes of my dream still lingered in my head.

We stepped outside. I took a deep breath of fresh mountain air, and that seemed to revive me completely. Kirsten pulled out the keys to her rental car—a nondescript gray SUV, perfectly matching the description of “utterly unremarkable transportation.” We loaded our backpacks into the trunk, took our seats, and headed toward yesterday’s restaurant.

The road descended along the river. Kirsten drove confidently and calmly. Art sat beside her in the front seat, and I settled in the back, letting my eyes rest on the vivid green slopes and the sunlight filtering through the leaves. For a while, silence filled the car, broken only by the steady hum of the engine and the soft hiss of tires on the road.

"Kirsten," Art said suddenly, "what's the situation with the new Variant? Do we have a clearer picture yet?"

I thought he might have asked her about it earlier that morning while I was asleep, but apparently he'd tactfully postponed the conversation so I could hear it too.

"We do," Kirsten replied after a brief pause. "Eric's team is back. Everyone's fine. No incidents."

"So?" Art asked impatiently, turning toward her.

Kirsten didn't answer right away.

"There's... a world," she said at last. "A world without humans."

I felt the air inside the car thicken. Art tensed slightly but said nothing, waiting.

"No, no—it's not what you're thinking," Kirsten hurried to reassure him—and me. "People didn't disappear there. They didn't die out. They simply... never existed there in the first place."

"Then who's there?" Art asked, his voice tight.

"Creatures," Kirsten said. "Mostly Creatures. There are far more of them there than in all the other Variants combined. The analysts believe this Variant is a 'home' world for the Creatures—their place of origin. The world they came from. Or at least one of them."

A long silence settled over the car. Naturally, the news had made a strong impression on both Art and me. We needed time to process it—to let it sink in.

From our school history classes, we all grew up with the idea that humans are the one unique species that became intelligent and reached the highest level of development. And now it turned out that this wasn't an axiom at all. That under a different chain of events, intelligence could emerge not in humans, but in entirely different living beings. How intelligent they were, what level of development they had reached—we could only speculate for now. Taking all this into account, it seemed that we humans had a great deal to rethink.

"Yes... that certainly gives one a lot to think about," Art finally said.

I realized that our thoughts had been moving along similar lines, and that he had likely arrived at the same conclusions I had. And I also noticed that Art looked... pleased. I immediately understood why. This new information significantly increased the likelihood that the world of the First Ones truly existed.

"You'll have time to think about it," Kirsten said. "And not just think—but see it with your own eyes."

As she said this, she couldn't quite hide the sadness in her voice. I thought about what it must be like for her—to constantly be among striders and yet not have the ability, like they—like we—do, to walk through the Gates. I was about to say something reassuring, but then I looked at her—calm, confident, focused—and realized she didn't need my sympathy at all.

As if to confirm that impression, Kirsten said in a distinctly commanding tone:

"We're almost there. Breakfast-lunch, and then back to work. Today we need to cover the rest of the route."

I realized I hadn't noticed the moment when she had become the unspoken leader of our small group. But it had clearly happened.

Breakfast-lunch took us no more than half an hour, yet I still managed to properly appreciate both the house-made puff pastries with a wide range of fillings—from meat and mushrooms to custard and wild berries—and the aromatic coffee served in traditional clay mugs.

After leaving the restaurant, we took our backpacks from the trunk and, leaving the car in the parking lot, headed down the road. Soon a narrow trail branched off, and we followed it. Kirsten moved ahead, pulling the mini-drone container from her pocket as she walked. I watched four black dots emerge from it and smoothly fan out upward and sideways, forming a trapezoid.

Art and I, as usual, split up on either side of the trail and got to work.

After we'd collected several nuggets, Kirsten decided to entertain me a bit. Making me promise that it wouldn't interfere with the job, she piped the drone camera feeds into my mask. That gave me the chance to take in the surrounding scenic canyons, covered in ancient pines, not only from the ground but from a bird's-eye view as well.

From time to time, when something struck her as suspicious, Kirsten sent one of the drones diving almost to the ground, threading rapidly between the trees, before letting it soar upward again. A couple of times the drones returned to her container "to refuel," as she put it. The refueling process took only a few seconds.

With this combination of picking—already an engaging activity in itself—and breathtaking vistas paired with the drones' daring maneuvers, time flew by unnoticed. Evening was already approaching when we climbed another ridge and froze before a mesmerizing panorama: ahead of us, glowing in the soft gold of sunset, stretched a turquoise sea. Contrasting with it were the picturesque orange-tiled roofs of a cozy resort town spread along the shore of the bay.

I didn't even notice the moment when Kirsten switched off the drone feeds in my mask.

I recognized the town immediately. It was the closest coastal town to where I lived. A couple of times, my colleagues and I had come here on weekends—to stroll along the promenade, swim in the sea, and sit in one of the cozy local restaurants.

"I think we can call it a day," Art said with satisfaction. "I've got two thousand eight hundred and fifty amphoras in my second box. That's just today. And total... nine thousand nine hundred and eight. Damn. Fell just short of ten thousand."

Kirsten applauded ironically.

"Yes, we've worked hard and earned ourselves a proper dinner at some respectable local place," she declared, continuing down the trail. We followed her.

The trail almost immediately brought us to the outskirts of the town. After wandering through narrow streets for about half an hour, we emerged onto a promenade running along a wide beach of clean, almost white sand. Beyond the sand, the pale turquoise sea shimmered in the rays of the setting sun.

"Care for a dip?" Kirsten teased us.

"I've had more than enough sea over the past couple of weeks," Art replied with a smile.

We stared at him in confusion.

"I was actually on vacation," Art explained. "Right nearby, in fact. Well—near a place just like this one. In our Variant. That's why I was the first of our lot to make it to the new Gates when they opened. Lucky, I guess. Though it turns out my vacation ended a bit earlier than planned."

I pictured myself lounging on the beach and realized that, right now, it was the very last thing I wanted. I was in no mood for beaches.

"And what about you?" I asked Kirsten, partly to avoid having to justify myself.

"Unfortunately, I can't leave you unattended."

Her tone was light, almost playful, but I understood that this was exactly how things stood. She was on duty. Her job was to accompany us, provide whatever we needed, and keep us safe—without interruption, even for a minute. And I had to admit, she was doing that job flawlessly.

“Alright,” Kirsten said briskly, “if the beach doesn’t tempt you, let’s move straight on to dinner.”

Orienting myself quickly, I suggested a restaurant I knew well—*The Fisherman’s Pier*—located just a couple of minutes away, right on the promenade. The idea was met with enthusiasm. We set off along the waterfront, enjoying the scent of the sea and flowering trees.

As soon as we entered the restaurant, I drew my companions’ attention to a long counter filled with trays of crushed ice, on which the day’s catch was beautifully displayed: several large fish, a couple dozen smaller ones, and plenty of mussels, shrimp, tiny octopuses, and other marine creatures. With the help of a waiter—a sun-tanned guy with hair bleached by the sun—we chose what would make up our dinner and took seats on the veranda, which offered a magnificent view of the bay and the setting sun.

From the fish and shrimp we’d selected, they prepared a thick, orange-colored soup. The rest of the seafood was served in a creamy white-wine sauce with aromatic herbs. The food was excellent. After thoroughly enjoying the ocean’s bounty, we settled back with cups of coffee, facing the sea, savoring the luxurious sunset and the cool marine breeze.

“So how are we getting home?” I asked, taking a sip of the fragrant coffee.

“We’ll take a taxi to the Bear’s Den, then switch to our car,” Kirsten replied matter-of-factly.

“And you’re not worried about someone setting up another ambush on the way?” I asked. I tried to make it sound like a joke, but didn’t quite succeed.

“I wish they would,” Kirsten said, narrowing her eyes with a predatory glint.

The look on her face gave me a measure of reassurance, and I turned my attention back to the view of the bay stretching out before us. I was sitting half-turned toward the sea, and directly in front of me lay the right edge of the bay. There, the promenade ended at a small marina where several yachts and boats rocked gently at anchor. Just beyond it rose the slope of a low mountain descending straight to the water.

I knew that a particularly scenic trail ran along that slope. It wound through the wooded hillside, dipped into a couple of short tunnels, and emerged onto a rocky beach enclosed on three sides by steep cliffs. Every time I visited this town, I made a point of walking that trail to the secluded beach and sitting alone on the rocks, gazing out at the azure sea.

Now, too, I felt that it would be good to walk that trail again—and to show this beautiful place to my companions. The more I thought about it, the stronger the urge became to go there, to that cliff-ringed beach. For some reason, it felt important—urgently so—turning into something close to an obsession, as if someone were calling me there, quietly but irresistibly.

And strangely enough, that call seemed connected to my dream from the night before, where I had been the Black Jellyfish—though I had no idea why.

At last, I couldn’t hold it in any longer and shared all this with Art and Kirsten. My proposal didn’t seem to spark much enthusiasm in either of them.

“I don’t think that, after what happened yesterday, taking a walk along a secluded cliff trail—with two not-exactly-empty boxes, and tunnels, no less—is a particularly good idea,” Art said.

And then it seemed to me that this comment of his shifted Kirsten’s stance. She hadn’t been eager about the walk either—but Art’s caution appeared to ignite her hunting instinct.

“I’m in,” Kirsten said decisively. “I see no reason not to take a walk and check out this supposedly picturesque beach. It *is* picturesque, isn’t it, Mac?”

I nodded vigorously.

Art, finding himself outvoted, gave a resigned shrug.

We stepped out onto the promenade. The resort season hadn't properly begun yet, so there were few people around. The sun had already dipped into the sea, painting the sky in a spectrum of hues—from sandy orange to violet-turquoise. The walk really was pleasant.

When we reached the end of the promenade, climbed the steps, and emerged onto the trail running along the slope, Kirsten, as usual, moved a little ahead. Art and I followed side by side. At that moment, Kirsten refueled the mini-drones once again, and I realized that all this time they had still been circling around us, allowing her to maintain full perimeter control. As we approached the entrance to the first tunnel, I noticed one of the "flies" dart inside first, scouting the way ahead.

"Since we're already walking in the hills," Art said, "why not combine pleasure with business? Maybe we can round our haul up to a nice even number."

He activated the Essence layer in our masks. For some reason, I felt a flicker of relief when he did. And yet, despite that, I still felt myself being *pulled* toward the beach.

We moved along the trail fairly quickly, alternating between open stretches and several short tunnels along the way. There were a few small clumps on the slopes, but no real nuggets, so we didn't linger. The sun had fully set, the sky was gradually darkening, but above the sea a soft turquoise glow still lingered.

Kirsten stepped onto the beach first, looking around with interest. Art and I followed her out of the tunnel into the narrow canyon framing the beach. I lifted my eyes—and stopped short, as if I had run into an invisible wall.

One of the cliffs on the opposite side of the canyon was glowing with a deep, saturated emerald light. Its entire surface was covered by a colossal nugget—unlike anything I had ever seen before.

I couldn't look away. The nugget radiated an almost physical sense of power, as if the rock itself were breathing Essence.

Gradually, I came back to myself and glanced at Art. He stood beside me, staring at the nugget, just as transfixed. Kirsten, unable to see the Essence layer, looked back and forth between us and the cliffs, clearly trying to understand the reason for our sudden paralysis.

Then, it seemed, she figured it out.

"Big?" she asked curtly. There was tension in her voice.

Only now did I notice the readout that had appeared next to the nugget on my display:

411q, 1974α.

Art didn't answer right away. When he did speak, he did so slowly, as if trying to keep himself under control—but his voice betrayed him anyway.

"Kirsten, you know the strider classification. Tiny clumps we call crumbs. Decent nuggets are goodies. Big ones are pies. And the really big ones—we call cakes."

He paused.

"What we're looking at here is a lavish wedding cake. Soaked in syrup, covered with icing, and decorated with sugar roses."

Chapter 13. The Drift

“Do they have little figurines of the bride and groom dancing on top?” Kirsten laughed.

We moved closer to the cliff, still studying it. There was something ominous in the nugget’s heavy, densely emerald glow.

“My Net Aide says this is the largest officially recorded nugget in the entire history of observations,” Art said in a low voice.

We stood there, spellbound, staring at the treasure. Kirsten looked at the cliff as well for a while, even though she couldn’t see the nugget itself. When she finally turned back to us, her expression was unexpectedly serious and focused. She was looking at Art. I followed her gaze.

Art nodded—as if answering a question she hadn’t voiced.

It felt like the two of them were thinking about the same thing. Kirsten narrowed her eyes, clearly analyzing the situation and making decisions.

“All right,” she said tensely. “Art, start extracting the nugget. Mac, stay close and keep watch—especially on the tunnel exit. If you notice anything unusual or suspicious, tell us immediately. I’ll look around as well.”

I understood what they were thinking.

At this moment, we were carrying values worth an obscenely large sum. Which meant we were extremely attractive prey—to anyone who could see those values and grasp their scale. And we were practically in a trap: sheer cliffs on three sides, the sea on the fourth. As far as I could tell, there was only one way out—back along the trail with its tunnels.

Perfect terrain for an ambush.

Realizing this, I felt my heart start pounding hard and fast. I scanned the surrounding cliffs with frantic intensity. The canyon was empty. Twilight had almost fully given way to night—clear, star-filled. Above the sea hung a bright, southern moon, large and sharp-edged.

My companions, meanwhile, were calm and businesslike.

Art stepped closer to the cliff, turned his backpack toward it, and—something I sensed rather than saw—activated the tackle.

Kirsten was “looking around”, though clearly not here, not directly around us, but through the cameras of the mini-drones. She stood motionless, staring ahead, her eyes flicking rapidly. Her face remained composed and focused.

Then she flinched—just slightly.

“Well,” she said tightly, “this was to be expected.”

A screen popped up in my mask, streaming footage from one of the drones. It showed a large rock on the ground with a flat top. Standing upright on it—as if suctioned to the surface—was a familiar object.

A resonator.

And in the corner of the drone feed, a circle with the number “1” glowed with a menacing amber light.

The drone slowly pulled back, panning left as it did. Now I could see the trail we had come along—the very path we’d have to use to leave—and the entrance to the first tunnel on that side.

The lens of the active resonator was aimed straight at it.

My heart was hammering somewhere up in my throat. I darted a hunted, cornered look from Kirsten to Art.

Neither of them looked even remotely frightened or confused.

Kirsten's face carried the thrill of a hunter—the look of a lioness watching a nearby herd of antelope. Art's expression said something closer to: *Now this is getting interesting.*

Their calm confidence was contagious.

Kirsten looked at Art.

"How long do you need to handle this beauty?"

"Half an hour. No less," Art replied evenly.

"Good. One more question. Battery levels—how long can you drift?"

Art nodded, understanding immediately.

"Just under half. About twenty minutes at cruising speed. With double load—less."

"That's what I thought," Kirsten said, nodding. "I'm nearly fully charged. So—Mac rides with me."

Art spread his hands in an apologetic, slightly ironic gesture.

I looked from one of them to the other, completely lost.

It must have looked pretty funny, because when they glanced at me, both of them laughed.

"Explain it to Mac for now," Kirsten said. "I'll take care of the next transport step."

She turned and walked a couple of steps away.

I looked at Art questioningly. He smiled—half apologetic, half encouraging.

"Sorry, Mac," he said gently. "There's just too much to explain and show all at once. You understand—this is all still very new for you."

"Yeah. It's fine. I get it," I said, feeling just as awkward.

Kirsten suddenly said, "Hello," and we both turned toward her.

She switched to the local language. I realized she was talking on the phone through her clip. In the few months I'd lived in this country, I'd picked up a handful of words, so I could catch fragments of what she was saying:

"Hello... yes, I'd like to rent a car... for one day... we'll be there in about two hours... yes, I understand, the double rate is fine... of course... yes, cash deposit... thank you."

She ended the call and turned back to us.

"There's a fairly large resort city about an hour from here," she said briskly. "They have a 24-hour rental service. I've booked a car for us. Now we just need to get to that place." She gestured away from the sea.

"There's a road on the other side of the mountain. Somewhere nearby there's a well-known tourist spot—something like a trailhead. It's over there, about five hundred meters from here."

I looked in the direction she was pointing: a steep slope covered in pines.

"I'll call a taxi there... Hello..." She was already back on the phone.

I studied the mountain, trying to spot at least some kind of path. There was none. And the slope was clearly far too steep—pine trees clung to it as if gripping the rapidly rising rock with their roots. I shot a confused look at Art.

"And... how exactly are we supposed to get up there?" I asked.

"On drifters," he explained readily. "Remember I told you there's a portable drifter built into my pack?"

I nodded.

"Kirsten's pack has the same one. They're very low-power, of course. Essentially, a drifter is just a compressor—it compresses air and releases it under pressure in a controlled direction, creating thrust. By the way, the heat generated during compression is used to warm the agrav, which makes the whole system more efficient." He tapped the tacle behind his back. "Can't demonstrate it right now, but you'll see soon enough. We'll use the drifters to reach the road."

Kirsten finished her call and came over.

"All set. The taxi will be waiting for us in forty minutes." She glanced at Art. "Did you explain the drifters?"

Art nodded.

"Great. Then I'll show you." She turned to me. "Watch closely, Mac. It's very simple."

She turned her back to me. Four openings appeared near the corners of her backpack. The pack itself subtly changed shape, flattening slightly and fitting more snugly against her back. Then—without me quite seeing how—the agrav kicked in, and Kirsten rose smoothly off the ground.

A quiet hissing, whistling sound followed, like a vacuum cleaner running at a distance. She tilted forward slightly in midair and began gliding above the ground, tracing a slow circle. As she did, she waved her hands, comically flapping them like wings.

Completing the circle, Kirsten stopped in front of me, rose a little higher to a vertical position, and gently settled back onto the ground. Then she finished with an exaggerated, theatrical bow.

I genuinely felt like applauding. Because it looked—put mildly—impressive.

"And how exactly am I supposed to use this... drifter?" I asked uneasily. "I don't have one of your magical backpacks."

Kirsten looked at Art. He was grinning broadly.

"You'll see," she said lightly, waving it off.

The next half hour passed in tense waiting. At least for me. My companions, on the other hand, seemed to find nothing unusual or worrying about our situation. Kirsten immersed herself in the virtual Layers again. Art continued collecting the nugget, calmly scanning the surroundings with the relaxed air of a tourist at a scenic overlook.

I paced back and forth, repeatedly casting anxious glances toward the tunnel entrance, the sheer mountain slope, and the dark sea. And then, as my eyes swept the shoreline once more, something caught my attention—something that felt... wrong.

It took a few seconds to understand what it was.

Along the waterline lay clumps of seaweed, thrown ashore and dried by the sun. But one of those clumps was... different. Slightly darker, and it didn't look dry or dead like the rest.

The moment my gaze fixed on it, the thing moved.

"Tumbleweed," the Creature introduced itself.

Its shape began to shift smoothly, becoming more rounded. A moment later, the Creature rolled away from its spot and started moving across the beach toward the tunnel entrance, now truly resembling a dry bush blown across an open field by the wind.

I spun back toward my companions. They had noticed the Creature too—or heard its introduction—and were now following it with attentive gazes. Kirsten narrowed her eyes with interest, her head tilted slightly to one side. Art, faintly smiling, nodded to himself a couple of times, as if confirming something internally. I noticed that he had already stepped away from the rock—the harvesting was apparently finished. Kirsten noticed it too.

“Done?” she asked briskly. “Excellent. Then it’s time to get out of here. Art, you’re in front—you set the course. I’ll put the drifter on autopilot, locked to your trajectory, so I don’t have to split my attention. And one more thing—” She paused briefly, as if weighing the decision. “Activate your resonator and prepare two impulses. We need to be ready for surprises.”

Art nodded silently, pulling the resonator from his belt. I saw his pack begin to reconfigure, clearly switching into flight mode.

Kirsten stepped up to me.

“Mac, may I ask you to put your backpack on in front?” she said, unusually polite. It felt like she was trying to hide a hint of embarrassment.

I did as she asked, already beginning to guess what would happen next. Kirsten gave a small shrug, as if to say *don’t take it the wrong way*, walked around me, and took position behind me. Then she gently pressed herself against my back and wrapped her arms around me.

Even though I had more or less expected this, I couldn’t avoid a flush of embarrassment—and a moment of confusion. Nor could I avoid sensations of a very different, and very pleasant, kind. But Kirsten—or rather, her backpack—quickly brought my thoughts back to something more practical.

I felt the straps slide around my sides and close beneath my front-mounted pack, softly but firmly securing me in place. Then I felt my feet leave the ground.

“Don’t worry,” Kirsten said quietly, right by my ear. “You don’t have to do anything. Just relax and enjoy the ride.”

I couldn’t help noticing the playful note in her voice.

Art was already ahead of us. I heard the hiss of compressed air and saw him lift off as well, tilt forward slightly, and surge ahead, smoothly gaining speed. Our shared “rig” with Kirsten leaned forward too, and we followed Art, keeping about five meters behind him.

The speed was perfect—not fast enough to be frightening, but more than enough to enjoy the sensation of swift motion. Art navigated expertly around rocks and trees, and we mirrored his maneuvers precisely. As we approached the mountain slope, we slowed and started to climb steeply upward, keeping just a couple of meters above the treetops of the pines growing along the incline.

Soon we heard the sound of cars passing on a road. Then, as we crested the ridge, the road itself came into view. Art turned to follow it, dropping almost to ground level and continuing forward among the trees. We stayed exactly on his course.

A few minutes later we spotted a small parking lot on the opposite side of the road, bordered by a low fence made of stones bonded with cement. There was a gap in the fence marking the start of a narrow road leading into the forest. I noticed a post with several arrow-shaped signs pointing that way.

This, I realized, was the beginning of several hiking trails.

There was only one car in the parking lot, marked with the logo of the local taxi service.

Art picked a level patch of ground near the edge of the road, shielded by trees, and eased himself down. We touched down beside him. The straps holding me loosened and released at once, and Kirsten stepped back. I felt a strange mix of relief and regret—though relief, in the end, won out.

We crossed the road and approached the car. Kirsten leaned toward the driver's window, flashed a disarming smile, and exchanged a few phrases with him. I caught the words "*got a little lost.*"

After that, we loaded into the car without incident. Kirsten took the front seat beside the driver; Art and I settled in the back. I noticed that Art was still holding his resonator in his hand.

We set off in the direction opposite to the resort town we had just left—the one where, apparently, a *warm welcome* had been waiting for us. About forty minutes later we entered another town I recognized, one I'd visited a couple of times before. We reached the rental office without trouble, paid, and let the taxi go.

Kirsten went inside the office and soon returned with an elderly man whose deeply lined face was adorned with a full gray beard. He was clearly in high spirits—no doubt thanks to the double advance payment.

Kirsten chose a compact SUV that, judging by its looks, was built for extreme off-road conditions. After signing the paperwork and taking the keys, she tossed her backpack onto the back seat rather than the trunk and confidently took the driver's seat. I threw my pack into the trunk and climbed into the back; there was barely any room, my knees pressed against the seat in front of me. Art sat beside Kirsten, also keeping his backpack with him instead of stowing it away.

We pulled away—but after just a couple of blocks, Kirsten turned onto an empty roadside shoulder and stopped the car.

As if expecting this, Art didn't say a word. He began pulling—or rather, peeling—small clumps of foam from his backpack and pressing them onto each of the windows. The material stuck instantly and spread across the glass, forming a semi-transparent film—or more accurately, a membrane. Visibility through it was worse than through the darkest tinting. Within a couple of minutes, all the windows were covered, and we found ourselves in near-total darkness. Only a faint glow from the headlights seeped through the windshield.

When he was finished, Kirsten shifted into gear and pulled back onto the road, accelerating smoothly. I realized she wasn't watching the road through the windows or mirrors at all, but through the feeds from her drones.

"Now we've got one hundred percent protection from a resonator impulse," Art said, answering the question I hadn't voiced.

I nodded.

"When we get there, we should probably check my place too," I ventured, trying to show off what I imagined were my budding tactical instincts. "Make sure nothing's been planted."

Kirsten turned her head slightly. In the near darkness, I thought I saw an ironic smile flicker across her face.

"Haven't you figured it out yet, Mac?" Art said calmly, without turning around.

"We're not going to your place. We're going straight to the Gate."

Chapter 14. Bungee Jumping

It didn't sink in right away what Art had just said. And when it finally did, my breath caught in my chest.

At that moment, I remembered my first bungee jump.

We had been walking through a park with friends and happened to pass a bungee-jumping tower. Out of sheer curiosity, I wandered closer, studying the structure and imagining what it must feel like to stand at that height and jump off. I imagined it calmly, abstractly, as if it were happening to someone else—someone who had nothing to do with me personally. Thinking about it that way was amusing, even pleasant, and caused no discomfort at all.

Then I noticed a man sitting on a chair nearby, his back turned to me. He was probably an instructor or the attraction's administrator. The moment I looked at him, he suddenly turned around. He gave me a quick, assessing glance and asked, briefly and matter-of-factly:

"Gonna jump?"

Of course I wasn't planning to jump. But whether out of surprise or politeness, instead of answering with a firm *no*, I just shrugged vaguely.

The administrator immediately stood up and, addressing someone somewhere nearby, said in the same businesslike tone:

"Guys, we've got a customer. Let's work."

He wasn't looking at me anymore. He simply turned and headed toward the tower. And suddenly I understood that it was already too late to say anything—that everything had been decided. I was going to jump.

In that very instant, the full horror of that necessity crashed down on me. I looked at the tower again, judged its height—but now I was thinking and feeling completely differently. This was no longer about some other person. This was about me.

The same thing was happening now with the Gate.

When Art had first told me that I could pass through the Gate and enter another world, I'd imagined it as an abstract possibility—something that might happen not to me, but to someone else. Or to me, perhaps, but someday later. At some undefined point in the future. Something I didn't need to think about yet.

And now, suddenly, I realized that it was happening for real. Not to someone else—to me. Right now. And just like before that bungee jump, the realization unleashed a wave of primal fear that swept over me.

"Wait... but... what about my things?" I blurted out. "What will my landlady think?"

I trailed off mid-sentence, realizing that this was just a defensive reflex—my subconscious frantically trying to find a way to avoid, or at least delay, the inevitable.

"Don't worry, Mac," Kirsten said calmly, professionally. "I'll take care of everything. That's my job. If you want, your landlady won't even remember that anyone's been renting her place lately."

"No, no, don't do that!" I said quickly. "She's a wonderful woman!"

Kirsten and Art burst out laughing.

"She's joking—relax," Art said reassuringly, quickly returning to a serious tone.

"I'll figure something out," Kirsten added, just as seriously. "I can be your caring sister for a while. Or your jealous wife. Or whoever else is needed. Though honestly, if you can just text your landlady, that'll be much simpler."

"Yes, of course—I'll write to her," I said immediately, pulling out my phone.

"Perfect," Kirsten summed up. "Your personal belongings, documents, money—everything you left behind—I'll be able to pass on to you later."

"I've got my documents with me, and my bank cards too," I said, thinking as I typed. "Yeah... I guess there's nothing really important left there. You can throw my things away or give them to someone."

And suddenly I realized it was true.

I'd been traveling light, living lightly. I hadn't accumulated anything of real value yet—and everything I might need could be bought again.

"You're an ideal client," Kirsten said, slipping back into her ironic tone.

I sent the message to my landlady, then turned off the phone, and pocketed it. I leaned back against the seat—and unexpectedly felt a sense of relief.

I wasn't leaving anything behind. Which meant I had nothing to worry about in the past. I wasn't losing anything by turning the page—by, in essence, starting my life over.

"Let's go over the details of the crossing itself," Art said, his voice serious and focused. "When we reach the Gate, we'll need to wait for the transition to our Variant."

"Oh—and wait," he interrupted himself. "I don't think I ever explained how this works."

"Variants on the far side of the Gates rotate. The switch happens every five to ten minutes. The sequence isn't fixed, but each Variant appears at least once within roughly an hour."

"Really?" I said, surprised. "I always thought each Gate led to one specific Variant. Probably because the number of Gates and Variants is the same."

"If that were the case," Art replied calmly, "there would be one fewer Gate than Variants. Think about it. One of the Variants is the one you're already in."

"Oh... right. Of course," I said, feeling slightly embarrassed by my own oversight.

"So," Art continued, "while we're waiting for the right Variant to appear, we'll be at our most vulnerable. We'll be forced to stay in one place—one where our presence is obvious to whoever's been following us. Kirsten will be monitoring the perimeter, and she'll warn us if anything shows up, but still—it's better to be prepared."

He paused, as if giving me time to absorb this, then went on:

"If an emergency situation arises, remember three rules. First: stay calm. Don't panic. Second: watch me and do exactly what I do. And third: if anything happens to me, go straight through the Gate. It doesn't matter which Variant is on the other side. Just cross. That way, there's a chance whoever's chasing you won't be able to follow—or won't make it through before the Variant switches."

I took a deep breath. It came out sounding more like a suppressed sob.

"Hey," Art said more gently, "Don't worry. Everything should be fine."

Silence settled over us.

I leaned back against the seat and tried not to think about anything at all. That wasn't easy. But eventually, I think I did manage to shut down—and may even have drifted off for a short while.

I was pulled back into reality when the car, barely slowing down, left the road and continued across rough terrain. We were jolted violently, thrown from side to side. Despite the shaking and the still near-total lack of visibility, I made out a ghostly shimmer ahead through the windshield.

The Gate.

Fortunately, the wild jolting didn't last long. The car began to slow, almost stopping several times—apparently navigating particularly difficult patches—and finally came to a complete halt.

“That’s it. No way we’re getting any farther,” Kirsten commented briskly.

At that very moment, night inside my mask turned into day.

Everything around us snapped into sharp focus—too sharp, in fact. The outlines of objects were unnaturally crisp, overly contrasted. In the upper-right corner of my view, an icon shaped like a crescent moon appeared. I realized night vision had switched on.

“Mac, grab the pack,” Kirsten said as she opened the door and stepped outside. Art followed her. I slung her backpack over my shoulder and climbed out as well.

It took me a few seconds to adjust—not to what I was seeing, but to *how* I was seeing it.

The colors of the grass, trees, rocks, the moon and stars were perfectly familiar. Normal. Exactly as I knew them. Except for the sky—it wasn't blue, but gray. That, combined with the unnatural clarity and contrast, created a strong sense of unreality, like a lucid dream.

We were standing on the top of a small, rocky hill. Ahead of us, the slope dropped sharply downward, and beyond it—two kilometers away at most—loomed the colossal structure of the Gate.

It looked exactly as I'd seen it before. Or rather, as I'd seen it for the first time just a few days ago. The gray haze was gone now, reduced to a faint shimmer, a subtle ripple. On the other side, I could make out only very vague, blurred shapes—an uneven horizon line, and sky above it. The sky inside the Gate was gray as well.

My companions walked a little farther ahead. I came up to them and held out the backpack to Kirsten. She smiled and shook her head.

“No, Mac. It’s yours now. A gift. Don’t worry, it’s almost new, everything works perfectly. Later, if you want, you can exchange it for a newer model. But I’d be glad if you kept mine.”

I felt embarrassed.

“Thank you, Kirsten.”

She stepped closer and helped me slip my arms into the straps. The backpack seemed to be waiting for this—the straps immediately slid forward and closed across my chest, snugly but gently locking me in place.

Still holding my shoulders, Kirsten leaned in and gave me a quick peck on the cheek.

“Take care, Mac. I hope we’ll see each other again soon.”

I felt even more awkward.

“Take care, Kirsten,” I managed.

She stepped back and turned to Art.

“Bye, Art. Say hi to Mona.”

“Thanks, I will. Take care, Kirsten,” Art replied, scanning the surroundings, already half lost in thought.

Kirsten turned and headed for the car. She slipped into the driver’s seat with practiced ease, slammed the door, spun the vehicle around, and moments later it vanished among the trees.

I looked at Art. He seemed to have been waiting for this moment. Once he had my attention, he half-turned toward the Gate. Against its shimmering backdrop, a label instantly appeared in the left corner: V7.

“That,” Art commented, “is the Variant currently behind the Gate. We need Variant One. As soon as it appears, we assume we have five minutes—that’s the minimum interval before the next switch. We must pass through the Gate within those five minutes. And we must walk through—drifters don’t work inside the Gate. Also, we’ll need to shut down all electronic devices, including the mask and the clip.”

I realized that we wouldn’t be approaching the Gate on foot. My suspicion was immediately confirmed. I heard a soft hiss of compressed air behind me and felt the backpack’s straps lift me gently off the ground. Art was hovering as well.

“Your drifter will be on autopilot, following mine,” he said. “You don’t need to do anything. Try not to make any sudden movements while drifting. If you notice anything unusual, tell me—don’t act on your own. That should be everything. Any questions?”

He said all this while hovering in midair, facing me, with his back to the Gate. As he spoke the last words, I suddenly noticed the rippling surface of the Gate intensify. The image within it shuddered, shifted—and changed. The label in the corner flicked to V1.

“Uh—” I said, pointing at it.

Art turned around. A timer flared up next to the label: 4:59, 4:58, 4:57...

Art gave me a short, focused look.

“That’s it. Let’s go.”

He carved a sharp arc in the air, turning, and shot toward the Gate. I followed instantly. Our speed climbed rapidly. Like skiers, we skimmed over the slope of the hill, plunged into the forest, and raced between the trees, weaving effortlessly. The Gate disappeared from view, but the timer remained fixed before my eyes. As the seconds ticked away, my tension grew.

A minute passed. Then another.

When we burst out of the forest and the Gate reappeared directly ahead of us, the timer read: 1:01, 1:00, 0:59...

We rushed up to the Gate, stopped abruptly, and dropped to the ground. Art must have deactivated our masks and clips, because night instantly returned. But now the darkness was pierced by the ghostly glow of the Gate itself.

My heart was hammering wildly.

My first bungee jump came to my mind again.

I remembered the platform lifting me higher and higher, the ground drifting farther and farther away. I remembered the rising terror at the thought that I was about to fall into that emptiness, where the earth lay impossibly far below. Behind me stood two instructors, checking my harness. Then one of them opened the small gate in the railing. Beyond it there was nothing—only air, only void. And I had to step forward. Right now. Step straight into nothing.

The sheer impossibility of the act drowned me in terror.

“One! Two! Three!!!” the instructors shouted into my ears.

And I stepped forward.

In that instant, everything changed. Fear vanished completely. That must be how the survival instinct works—it holds you back from danger only while escape is still possible. And then it simply shuts off. Fear disappeared in a single heartbeat, replaced by an overwhelming, intoxicating exhilaration of free fall.

Standing now before the immense, shimmering wall of the Gate, I remembered all of this. And just like then, my terror dissolved in an instant.

I turned my head and looked at Art. He met my gaze calmly, confidently, smiled—and nodded.

I looked forward again, at the wavering, sparkling surface directly in front of me.

And then I stepped into the Gate.

Chapter 15. False Memory 1: Essence Picker

It seems to me that the best way to talk about the worlds of the Delta is the same way the Agency does when preparing us—striders. During a download, they don't just give us information about the Variants. They implant what are known as *false memories* directly into the brain.

A false memory is, essentially, a set of memories belonging to a person who was born and lived an entire life in a particular world. That person—real or fictional—has a profession or occupation closely aligned with what striders do. These roles are never chosen at random: in closed worlds, they allow Essence picking to be masked as something mundane; in open worlds, they make it possible to do the same work openly, without raising unnecessary questions. As a result, such professions are almost always tied to free movement across large areas, especially near the Gates.

And, of course, a false memory is not a record of an entire life from beginning to end. It consists only of selected, key events and episodes.

Who exactly the “owners” of these memories are—real people or composite constructs—I don't know. I tried asking the guys who did my downloads, but every time they just brushed it off with jokes.

What makes false memory so effective is that it doesn't merely tell you what happened and what is happening in a given Variant—it allows you to *be* the person who lives there. And that comes with at least two major advantages.

First, along with facts, you receive living impressions: emotions, sensations, subjective experience. You see, hear, and feel the world exactly as that person did. And layered on top of that is your own perception—as an external observer, aware that these memories are not originally yours.

Second, when you possess a false memory of another world, you're able to behave naturally while in it—meaning, at the very least, your behavior doesn't betray the fact that you're an outsider. It's not a mask and not a role you're playing; it's an internal understanding of how everything works, embedded directly into perception itself.

So, from here on, I'll try to convey the false memories of each of the Delta worlds that were downloaded into me.

And I'll begin, naturally, with Variant 1.

In that world, I was—essentially—myself: a strider working for ARK as an Essence picker. The only difference was that, in the false memory, I had been born and raised there, in that Variant.

My childhood and adolescence passed in a small town about half an hour's flight from one of the continent's largest megacities. My father was an architect-designer of residential complexes; my mother was a content developer for the net Layers.

As one might expect, my father designed our house himself. He used to say, with no small amount of pride, that a team of ten construction mechs from the building company needed only three days to complete the preparatory and structural work. But all finishing and interior design he carried out personally, together with two of his own mechs—and that took him more than three months.

The plot of land he purchased was almost entirely occupied by a steep, inaccessible cliff. The mechs leveled its summit, essentially “cutting off” the top and creating a broad plateau. The house stood there, surrounded on three sides by a park. The fourth side extended beyond the edge of the cliff and, in effect, hung over the abyss.

The road reached only the base of the cliff, where a garage for ground vehicles was located. From there, two elevators led upward: a panoramic passenger lift and a cargo lift running inside the rock itself. The plateau could be reached only by these elevators—or by air.

The exterior surfaces of the walls and roof were adaptive, giving the house an almost living quality. It reacted to temperature, light levels, and even the emotional state of its inhabitants. During the day, the walls became nearly matte, reflecting excess light; in the evening, they warmed softly, as if exhaling an amber glow from within. Sometimes it felt to me as though the house was breathing.

Inside, there was a sense of space and light. Almost the entire first floor was occupied by a vast living area, where functional zones—the kitchen, living room, dining space, lounge, and home office—were only loosely defined. Near the center stood an ample platform that, in winter, transformed into a cozy fireplace, and in summer became a living installation of stones and flowing water, with mosses and miniature plants growing between them.

The floors were sensory. They responded to footsteps, adjusting temperature for bare feet, softly illuminating furniture outlines in the dark, and even displaying a faint “echo-trail” of movement—a subtle glow that faded after a few seconds.

The lighting adapted to the inhabitants’ biorhythms. In the morning, the air filled with a cool, bluish-golden light to help you wake up. During the day, it shifted to a neutral white. In the evening, it warmed into amber and rosy hues. Sometimes, if the house sensed fatigue, it would dim the lights and play barely audible sounds of rain or distant surf.

The shape—or, as my father liked to say, the *architectural solution*—of the house was somewhat unconventional. The second floor was shifted relative to the first, creating recessed spaces above and below. The upper one held a veranda with an orangery and a winter garden. The lower formed a spacious terrace. It was this terrace, and my parents’ bedrooms above it, that hung over the cliff’s edge, as if suspended above the abyss.

All technical facilities were located on the underground level. On the roof, there was a landing pad for four floaters and a small telescope tower that my father had built himself, for his own pleasure.

My favorite place in the house was a detached fitness hall connected to the main building by a short gallery. It contained training equipment, two saunas, a large pool with a retractable transparent roof, a lounge area, and another home office where I usually attended virtual classes and did my homework.

Behind the house stretched a landscaped park, crossed by an artificial stream that flowed into a small pond. The park did not stop at the edge of the upper plateau but gradually spilled down the mountain slope, so that some of its steeper sections could only be reached using a drifter. Taking care of the park was my mother’s favorite occupation. Accompanied only by a gardener mech, she would hover above the slopes for hours, trimming, watering, and tending the plants.

This kind of fundamental, almost monumental approach to one’s own home was becoming increasingly rare in the modern world. In our case, it was defined more by my father’s profession than by prevailing trends.

In contemporary society, most people prefer to live in more or less standardized houses or residential units that can be rented or exchanged through numerous net services. This system long ago replaced the notion of a *permanent address*: now a person can change their place of residence as easily as switching an interface theme in a terminal.

Thanks to unified architectural standards and autonomous construction mechs, moving became a matter of hours. Mechs from management companies adapt a unit’s interior and exterior environment to the tastes and habits of new residents almost instantly—retuning lighting, wall textures, furniture, climate, even ambient sound. Some units feature a neural-trace function: they remember their occupants’ emotional responses and automatically recreate a comfortable atmosphere upon their return, as if *recognizing* the resident.

Housing turned into a kind of hybrid service—a middle ground between a home, a hotel, and personal space. One could easily move from a unit in a megacity skyscraper, with its frantic rhythm and endless entertainment, to a secluded house on a mountain spur or an ocean shore, where the only sounds are wind

and surf. Many people prefer a *rotational* lifestyle, changing environments every few months: megacity for projects, coastline for rest, a research dome in the tropics for inspiration.

When I began living on my own, I too got used to moving about once a year. It helped prevent stagnation—changing surroundings, people, the energy around me. And yet, despite this now-familiar mobility, my warmest memories are still tied to that old-fashioned, almost patriarchal house on the cliff that my father built.

In fact, that house—or rather, the place where it stood—largely shaped my main hobby: rock climbing.

Since people learned to use agrav—more precisely, since the invention of the safety vest—this sport became nearly as widespread as running or cycling. The vest made it possible to climb any cliffs or vertical surfaces without fear of falling to one's death. The moment you felt your grip slipping, it was enough to give the vest a short command—*float*—and it would immediately activate support mode, holding you in the air or gently lowering you down. Even if you failed to react in time, the built-in NA would do it automatically, instantly identifying a critical situation.

I started climbing the slopes beneath our house as a child—first under my father's supervision, later on my own. Gradually, the hobby grew into something serious: I took part in net competitions, trained almost every day, and became an active member of the climbing community, where, somewhat unexpectedly, I even earned a certain amount of respect.

When I finished primary school, as it's done for all children at this stage, my NA generated my profile—a description of my abilities and inclinations in the context of fields where I could perform best. In my case, these areas turned out to be research and development, control of machinery and mechanisms, and mediated social interaction. One could say I was lucky: this set almost perfectly matched the work I do now. For I chose that path more out of necessity than conscious intent. Necessity—because while I was still in middle school, the Gates appeared in our world, and a few years later, finding myself near a forming Essence nugget during a Storm, I became a strider.

How that happened—I'll tell later.

After finishing secondary and higher school, choosing subjects aligned with my three priority areas, I joined Orbit Connect as a Transport Systems Architect on the construction project of a new orbital tether.

Orbit Connect's tether lines are systems of nine to sixteen ultra-strong cables linking ground stations on Earth's surface with stations in orbit. Elevators travel along these cables, carrying people and cargo from the planet into space and back. The uppermost station is placed above geostationary orbit, at an altitude sufficient to create the centrifugal tension that keeps the cables under constant pull.

By definition, structures like this can only be built along the equator. Three tethers are located in Andana, two in Africa, one in Asia, and two more are anchored to oceanic platforms in open equatorial waters. The project I worked on would add a third African tether. Beyond Earth, several Orbit Connect facilities operate on Astrida—the term commonly used for off-world territories. Two lines are already active on the Moon, where construction is far simpler thanks to lower gravity, the near absence of atmosphere, and therefore reduced cable-length requirements. One tether operates on Mars, almost half the length of an Earth system due to the planet's smaller radius and weaker gravity. As far as I know, early development is also underway for tether projects in the Belt—on Psyche and Ceres.

My area of responsibility covered cargo transport from the surface up to one of the lower segments of the structure—the stabilizing platforms. Each tether has ten of these platforms, spaced at certain intervals along the lower section of the line. They do not bear the weight of the cables—the upper station provides the pull—but they dampen oscillations, reduce wind load, and stabilize elevator trajectories within the atmosphere.

The platforms consist partly of helium-filled aerostat elements and partly of structures made almost entirely of agra. Everything is bound together with ultra-strong monomolecular plastic—a material often described as an engineering miracle. The cables themselves are made of the same substance.

My work involved very little direct control of machinery. On my section, as everywhere else, NA oversaw the operation of loader mechs and unmanned heavy lifters. What I did was design, coordinate, and continuously refine the transport processes themselves: elevator schedules, mech workflows, cargo distribution between platforms—and, most importantly, the trade-offs between time expenditure and resource efficiency.

Most of my work was remote. Still, from time to time I was required on site, and eventually I decided to relocate to Africa to be closer to the project. I settled in a major metropolitan area surrounded by mountain ranges. It was a practical compromise: only a couple of hours' flight to the construction zone, yet close enough to the mountains that I could continue climbing on weekends.

The construction site lay away from settlements, and public transport was planned only for the commissioning phase. So whenever I needed to be there physically, I flew my own glider. Even with a cruising speed of 230 kilometers per hour, the trip took over an hour, which meant flying not in the zero sky level, but in the first.

For convenience and safety, ground travel uses roads. In the air, the same function is served by levels, horizons, and directions. Unlike roads, these structures are invisible to the naked eye; to see the aerial traffic architecture, one uses a dedicated net Layer—Maps. Ground roads and surface objects, of course, are displayed there as well.

Because the lower levels are tightly tied to the contours of the Earth's surface—and this linkage gradually smooths out with altitude—the shape of aerial levels, like that of ground roads, is complex and often intricate. The basic principle, however, is simple: the higher you are above the ground, the higher the permitted speed—and the stricter the traffic regulations.

For most floater pilots, it's enough to know that in Level Zero, whose altitude varies roughly between one and three kilometers, speed must not exceed 100 km/h, and that you must yield to anyone approaching on an intersecting course from the right or from above. In Level One above it, speeds of up to 300 km/h are allowed—but movement is permitted only in the direction defined by the current horizon.

Each level, starting from Level One, contains twelve such horizons. The direction of travel in each is shifted clockwise relative to the previous by thirty degrees—or, as people like to say by analogy with a clock face, by five minutes. If you're moving in a direction that doesn't match the assigned one, you're required to yield to all other traffic.

Every pilot is obligated to follow these rules, but compliance is monitored by NA, which is built into everything that flies. NA either limits itself to supervision when you're piloting manually, or takes full control once autopilot is engaged.

Like most people, I rarely bothered with manual piloting. On my way to and from work I switched on autopilot immediately—and then usually immersed myself in the net Layers.

Of course, the Net is an enormous and essential part of modern life. Most people access it through a mask and clip, though many other devices exist as well—mobile and stationary, individual and collective, two-dimensional and three-dimensional. All of them allow connection to the Net and are primarily operated via the n2e interface, though some people still prefer physical manipulators for text input and option selection.

The Net is made up of Layers. A net Layer is such a basic, everyday concept that I honestly don't even know how to define it. The word *layer* itself feels both necessary and sufficient as an explanation.

Layers can be transparent or opaque. This probably doesn't need much explanation either—but I'll explain it anyway.

Transparent Layers are overlaid onto the real world in the mask and thus augment it. The most common transparent Layers are Maps, People, Shopping, Services, Learning, and others like them. Each Layer has its own sublayers and filters, allowing you to see only the information you need at any given moment. Besides these widely used transparent Layers, there are countless niche and even fully personal ones, used less for practical purposes and more for atmosphere and mood. Such Layers can *repaint* the surrounding world with different colors and tones, fill it with sounds, melodies, and emotional textures—the later transmitted by the clip through gentle, safe e2n stimulation.

Opaque Layers require a safe environment. The mask's protocols won't allow access to them, for example, while operating a vehicle or standing on a street with active traffic. In practice, opaque Layers are often accessed not through the mask at all, but via two- or three-dimensional displays—most commonly, the monitors of personal terminals.

There are far more opaque Layers than transparent ones—mainly because they're easier to create. Companies, net communities, and individual users all build their own Layers. Large, well-developed ones evolve into full-fledged virtual worlds where people work, socialize, and, of course, play. Popular gaming Layers can have millions of participants.

By interface type, Layers are divided into spatial, graphical, and command-based. A spatial interface simulates three-dimensional physical space and movement within it. A graphical interface is controlled through touches and scrolling. A command interface, naturally, operates via commands entered through n2e or a physical keyboard.

Most Layers combine multiple interface models, although there are, for example, purely command-based ones as well. As I learned recently, those are mostly created by hardcore geeks who remain devoted to that particular mode of interaction with the Net.

Of course, an inseparable part of the Net—and of our world as a whole—is the Net Aide, or simply NA. I don't remember who first said this—some writer, perhaps, or a stand-up comedian—but the line stuck with me: *"The Net Aide's greatest virtue is that it cannot get bored."* And that, in my view, is absolutely true.

The greatest benefit NA has brought to our lives since its emergence over a century ago is that it took over all the boring, repetitive, exhausting, routine work—and does it in a way no human ever could: precisely, consistently, without fatigue, irritation, or complaint. If we imagine the alternative—having to perform this endless volume of dull routine ourselves—humanity would probably have howled in despair.

I recently read that the combined computational capacity of the entire NA structure exceeds the human mind by roughly a million times. What's even more striking is how gently and delicately that power is used. NA never pressures, never interferes, never claims authority. It is a partner—an ideal colleague who takes on any burden the very moment it begins to weigh you down.

NA assists the Forum at all levels—from solving local technical problems to implementing planet-scale projects—and does it so efficiently that over the course of a century the economy expanded by orders of magnitude and became an almost perfectly precise system of resource distribution. Hunger was eradicated on the planet even before NA appeared, but poverty as a phenomenon vanished entirely in its era. Every person received a guaranteed baseline of comfort: housing, energy, transport, healthcare, education. Money became a means of self-expression rather than survival.

In my history of technology course, we were told that without NA humanity would likely still not have discovered agrav, nor created molecular mechs.

In the case of agrav, the story was almost anecdotal: NA, possessing the full body of relevant data and having analyzed a vast array of often contradictory theories, concluded that agrav *had* to exist. Humans learned where to look—and found it.

With molecular mechs, the path was longer. The necessary technologies were scattered across different scientific domains, like pieces of an enormous puzzle. NA simply showed how to assemble them correctly.

During that same history of technology course, we were told that when the NA first appeared and mechs began to be produced on a mass scale, many people were deeply anxious about the consequences. Some predicted widespread unemployment, a collapse of motivation, cultural decline—a future in which humans would become mere appendages to machines.

None of that happened.

Neither the NA nor the mechs ever took over human decisions—only human labor. They did not replace people; they amplified them. Thousands of monotonous and routine professions gradually disappeared, but in their place emerged roles centered on creativity, empathy, research, engineering, architecture, medicine, and the arts. At the same time, the average working day and workweek shortened. Today, people work roughly five hours a day, four days a week.

There are, of course, those who choose not to work at all. All continental tax systems include what is known as a negative income tax. In practice, this means that if a person's income falls below a defined threshold, it is not they who pay tax to the Forum—the Forum pays them. The system is structured so that working, even part-time, remains more advantageous than not working at all, but no one is left without support.

Over the century of the NA's existence, attitudes toward personalization and “humanization” have gone through several distinct cycles.

At first, people addressed their aides in deliberately formal tones, as if speaking to austere machines. Then came the era of friendly interfaces: users gave their NAs pleasant voices, assigned them names, and designed dialogue windows to resemble chats with old acquaintances. After that followed a period of “anti-humanization.” It became fashionable to communicate with the NA in pure commands—no emotion, no simulated personality—as though emphasizing the boundary between human and machine. A few decades ago, the pendulum swung again. People grew tired of dry functionality, and personalization returned, this time in a more mature form. It no longer surprised anyone that many gave their NA ordinary human names and spoke to it—or to her, or to him—as to a living interlocutor. Not because the NA possessed a personality, but because it is easier and more comfortable to speak to a voice that sounds warm rather than metallic, to hear intonations that suggest care, to feel understood—even if what understands you is an algorithm.

A similar shift occurred with mechs, though in their case the cycle was shorter. The fashion for humanoid designs lasted only a short period after the first mass-produced models appeared. At the time, it seemed obvious that the more a mech resembled a human, the easier it would be to accept. People projected familiar expectations onto them: legs, arms, a head—even stylized ones—felt necessary to make the transition into a new technological world less abrupt.

Agrav changed that completely.

Once stable antigravity became reliable and affordable, the old engineering logic lost relevance. Flying mechs proved far more maneuverable, stable, and adaptable than their walking predecessors. They could hover near ceilings, rise vertically without inertia, pivot in midair almost instantly—all without the risk of stumbling, falling, or getting stuck, as early bipedal models sometimes did.

When legs disappeared, so did the intuitive sense of kinship between human and machine. Arms soon followed, replaced by task-specific manipulators that could fold, reshape, deploy tools, and operate with a precision beyond human motor control. Heads became unnecessary as well: a mech did not need to look, and humans did not need to see a face.

Most modern mechs now resemble neither people nor animals, but optimized constructions—sometimes cylindrical, sometimes disc-like, sometimes intricate multi-component structures designed entirely around function. Society adapted quickly. Today humanoid mechs are used only where “humanoid” is itself the function—for example, in teaching dance or martial arts. The discomfort people once felt in the presence of non-humanoid machines has largely faded. What emerged instead was a kind of clarity: the mech performs

its task without pretending to be human, and humans accept it as the most efficient embodiment of its purpose.

Naming conventions evolved in parallel. There were periods when mechs were given predominantly human names, and others when they were referred to strictly by technical codes. Eventually a stable compromise emerged: people began using official model designations, extracting certain letters and numbers—usually the final ones—and transliterating them into something name-like. The names seemed to grow naturally out of the markings themselves: A4 became Eyfor, 3X became Triex, U2 became Yutu, 53D became Fivetridi.

The names were not unique, but that rarely mattered. After all, humans share names too. Mechs relied on far more reliable identification systems. Their integrated NA could distinguish when it was being addressed by analyzing not only sound, but context, intonation, current task, and spatial position. Over time, this hybrid naming system became ordinary—and universal.

So, after that technical digression, let me return to myself.

As I mentioned, in order to be closer to the construction site, I moved from Alpida to Africa and settled in a suburban district of a large megapolis. I rented a compact unit on the sixty-seventh level of a residential complex made up of twenty-four towers ranging from forty-eight to ninety-six levels in height. The towers were connected by a web of multi-level galleries that crossed the open space at different altitudes, so the entire structure resembled both a vast beehive and an anthill.

The resemblance was reinforced by transport capsules moving along the outer surfaces of the towers and galleries, gripping magnetic rails, as well as gliders and drifters hovering between the buildings or parked on suspended platforms along the walls. The constant motion of this swarm created the sense of a living, self-sufficient urban organism.

I liked living there—especially the view from my window toward the central districts of the city. Office and residential clusters rose in dense formations, intertwined by bridges, shaped into rings, spirals, and cascading tiers.

Above several neighborhoods floated thin solar membranes—broad, almost invisible planes supported by agrav cushions. During the day they created shadow and, at the same time, fed the district's energy systems; by evening they transformed into luminous domes, spreading a warm, diffused glow over the city.

The upper levels of the towers were covered with gardens, groves, and shrubs. Parks hung in the air dozens, sometimes hundreds of meters above the ground, linked by walkways and narrow bridges where a steady breeze always moved.

My unit consisted of a large main room zoned into a kitchen, living area, and home office, plus a separate bedroom and bathroom. Like most modern dwellings, the walls could alter their transparency and texture. A simple mental command would turn a matte surface into a panoramic window—or into a softly illuminated decorative panel. Sometimes I used them as screens for video calls or work interfaces, but more often I left them nearly transparent to let in as much daylight as possible.

I rarely used the kitchen. I never enjoyed cooking and preferred buying food or ordering delivery from shops and restaurants. I also often stopped at one of the many nearby places on my way home or to work. Like most people, I didn't limit myself to a single food class. I could eat organic, replica, or eco—depending on my mood and what happened to be convenient.

Organic meant food produced entirely from natural components using traditional methods. Eco referred to fully synthetic products created in bio-complexes with minimal environmental impact. Replica was something in between—eco food engineered to imitate organic so precisely that only laboratory analysis could reliably tell the difference.

Around my unit there were countless cafés, small shops, and restaurants offering every class of food, cuisines from around the world, and options for any budget. Everything necessary for comfortable living was either a few minutes' walk away or a short drifter hop.

My unit was maintained not only by standard service systems but also by micromechs—tiny, nearly invisible devices that kept surfaces clean, collected dust, repaired minor scratches, and even adjusted ambient scent to match my mood. Thanks to them, the apartment always felt freshly tended, as if I had just finished cleaning.

The unit's climate shell operated just as unobtrusively. It gently regulated temperature, humidity, air composition, and airflow direction. In the mornings it created a light, invigorating breeze; in the evenings, warmer and more relaxing currents; at night it maintained subtle ventilation to support recovery during sleep. I noticed this background comfort only when I was elsewhere—in spaces without a climate shell, the difference was immediate.

Several levels above mine lay a spacious plaza filled with retail centers, cafés, entertainment studios, and small green courtyards tucked between galleries. The place was never empty. Some people lounged outdoors, some conducted work calls while walking, others occupied gaming capsules embedded in the walls.

Just five minutes away via moving walkway stood a major transit hub. Three metro lines passed through it, including a high-speed line that reached the city center in seven minutes. Several bus routes intersected there as well, though like most people I rarely used buses. It was far more convenient to summon a rental or exchange vehicle through a net service: a free car would usually arrive within seconds and take you anywhere—from the next district to the outskirts.

Two metro stops from my unit stood a vast sports complex with pools, aerial game fields, virtual arenas, and a fully equipped climbing center. I spent most evenings there—training, competing, meeting friends from the climbing community. And on weekends I almost always left the city: real rock, wind in my ears, the scent of sun-warmed stone. Nothing replaced that.

One day, during one of those trips outside the city, I was climbing a training route along the nearly vertical face of a fairly high cliff. The route had been certified as a qualifying climb for a competition scheduled the following week, so it was important for me to complete it that day and register the result with my NA.

As it happened, the cliff lay not far from a Gate. And when I was less than halfway to the top, a Storm began.

I knew that if I descended now, I wouldn't have the time or the strength for a second attempt. The qualification route allowed a generous time margin, so I decided to wait out the Storm right there on the rock. A little higher up I noticed a shallow indentation—a small, almost invisible cave. I pulled myself into it, secured my harness, and waited.

Of course, I couldn't have imagined that my little shelter—seemingly protected from the main flow of the Storm—would turn out to be near a vortex forming within it, a small tornado that “attached” itself to the cliff and began generating a nugget. The cave shielded me from the direct current, but not from the turbulence. Staying there during the Storm became agonizing, nearly unbearable. My head vibrated from within, my chest felt crushed, pressure spiked erratically—all at once.

By the time the Storm finally subsided, there was no question of finishing the route. My hands were trembling, my body felt hollow and unreliable, and my thoughts came only in fragments.

What I also did not expect was that during that time spent in that cave, the level of my Essence contour would more than double—enough to turn me into a strider and give me the ability to walk through Gates.

By then, both Essence and striders had long been known in our world. From time to time, net channels aired the same social message everyone had grown tired of: anyone who had experienced a Storm was

encouraged to undergo monitoring at the ARC. Those found to possess strider capabilities were promised interesting, well-paid, and widely respected work with the Agency.

Naturally, I took the opportunity.

And so now I am a Green strider, a fourth-class Essence picker and a third-rank agent of the Agency for the Regulation of Quintessence—the ARC.

The ARC is one of the many executive structures of the Forum. In our world, “the Forum” refers to the entire system of public institutions and organizational frameworks responsible for governance, regulation, and the long-term development of social life.

At the top stands the Central, or World Forum—the body that addresses global-scale matters: coordination of planetary projects, resource allocation, intercontinental transport systems, major scientific initiatives, and security in its broadest systemic sense.

Below it are the eight continental Forums: the Forum of Andana, the Forum of Alpida, the Forum of Arctida, and the others. Each oversees the strategic development of its continent—from infrastructure megaprojects to environmental monitoring, energy systems, and distributed production networks. Continental Forums are also responsible for citizenship and taxation.

At the base level are regional Forums, dealing with what touches people most directly: urban and local infrastructure, transport, utilities, educational clusters, local resource distribution, and social services.

The work of all Forum levels is transparent and highly rational. Institutional NAs handle most of the analytics, modeling, and coordination, which allows the human members of the Forums to focus not on bureaucracy, but on decisions that require intuition, experience, and a human perspective. Thanks to this combination of human judgment and computational precision, our world has developed for decades without crises, conflicts, or chaotic distortions—in the steady way a mature civilization is meant to function.

When the Gates appeared in our world, interest in them flared instantly and intensely. Scientists, enthusiasts, philosophers—everyone tried to understand their nature, the mechanism of the Storms, and the strange energy that surged within.

The Creatures appeared almost simultaneously. At first they seemed as intriguing and mysterious as the Gates themselves. People tried to study them, photograph them, measure them, describe them.

But it soon became clear that the Gates and the Creatures seemed to generate a peculiar resistance—something that actively countered every attempt to examine them. Instruments registered meaningless noise. Photographs came out blurred. Observations contradicted one another. Several attempts to approach the Creatures ended with serious consequences.

Gradually, scientific enthusiasm faded. Gates came to be treated as a natural phenomenon—unusual, but ordinary in its own way. The Creatures were regarded much like any other inhabitants of the world: with cautious respect and quiet curiosity. Our culture had long embraced a careful attitude toward wild animals, and the Creatures seemed to settle naturally into a similar niche. People spoke of them almost as they did of rare birds or forest creatures—present somewhere nearby, occasionally glimpsed, but not something that required life to change around them.

For a time, scientific inquiry shifted focus. Instead of studying the Gates, the Storms, or the Creatures directly, researchers began investigating the force that prevented understanding. Small groups of persistent minds supported one another, trying to push forward despite everything.

But the results remained discouraging. Experiments collapsed. Theories ran dry. People withdrew. The community thinned, the passion for inquiry burned out—and the movement nearly disappeared altogether.

And it was at that moment that the great Hikaru Yugura appeared.

Or rather—his diary did.

It was published on the site of a half-forgotten net club where the Gates had once been debated with passion, though by then only a faint residue of activity remained.

Yugura had been a researcher at a small, largely unknown institute. He lived near one of the Gates, practiced various contemplative disciplines, and spent long stretches alone in the mountains. Like thousands of other scientists, he had tried to understand the phenomenon of the Gates—but as far as anyone knew, prior to creating his famous diary he had achieved no more success than the rest.

The diary contained his now-classic work *On Quintessence*, the schematics of a quint-pump and an Essence scanner, as well as an extensive explanatory note.

In that note, Yugura described how, during meditation, he once found himself caught in a Storm. Instead of fleeing, he chose to endure it—taking shelter behind a small rock outcrop and sinking as deeply as he could into concentration. Neither the rock nor the meditation helped. He wrote that the pain he experienced was beyond language.

But when the Storm passed, Yugura realized that his perception of the world had changed.

He wrote that he simultaneously understood and felt that at the foundation of the Gates lay a special substance—both energy and essence at once. He named it Quintessence, in homage to ancient thinkers, and introduced the shortened form—Essence—for practical use.

What followed he described as a kind of tightening spiral: he would ask a question—and the answer would arrive on its own. One question led to another. Knowledge seemed to arise from nowhere, as if something vast and immeasurably wise were guiding his hand.

Within days, he grasped the principles behind the scanner. Soon after, the quint-pump.

But the knowledge carried weight. He described it as a burden pressing harder and harder against his mind. Answers came—but each insight seemed to drain him. He wrote that he had reached the limits of human endurance, that one more step into that spiral would have taken him beyond what he could bear—and that he felt unbearable shame for stopping there.

At the end of the diary, Yugura apologized to humanity for what he called his weakness and urged anyone who read his words not to attempt to repeat his path. First, because, as he put it, the road had been “allowed” only to him. And second, because it was too much to endure.

It is reliably known that Yugura uploaded the diary to the Net himself.

And then he vanished.

Neither friends nor colleagues were able to find the slightest trace of where he had gone. His followers proposed countless theories: that he had withdrawn into a secluded mountain monastery... or stepped through a Gate into some new Variant inaccessible to anyone else. What truly happened to him remains unknown.

Despite his warning, many attempted to retrace his steps. As far as anyone knows, none achieved meaningful results. Most efforts ended in failure. Some ended in tragedy.

Hikaru Yugura’s discoveries were so fundamental that within a few years they reshaped the entire scientific landscape. What had once seemed unreachable metaphysics became experimentally accessible.

It was during this period that the first strider was identified—Ritvik Shukarti.

He had survived a Storm in the mountains and later, by chance, found himself near a Gate. There he realized that he now perceived it differently—not as he had before, and not as others did. Intrigued, Ritvik contacted one of the research groups working on Yugura’s findings. That group had recently constructed a prototype Essence scanner based on Yugura’s schematics, though early attempts to use it had failed. Ritvik was asked to try.

Events unfolded rapidly.

Ritvik perceived and described the Essence field—its varying levels in different people, the distinction of his own level, and its apparent alignment with the threshold level within the Gate. The conclusion was obvious. It merely required experimental confirmation.

Without hesitation, Ritvik volunteered to attempt entry.

Thus the first inter-Variant transition took place.

Ritvik stepped through the Gate, documented what he found beyond it, and then—after waiting for his own level to recover to the threshold—returned. By fortunate timing, he managed to do so before the Variant within the Gate shifted.

The experiments continued. Other individuals with abilities similar to Ritvik's were soon identified. Step by step, we learned what we now know about the Delta and the other Variants.

Under the World Forum, the Committee for Intervariant Interaction was established, along with its three executive agencies: the Agency for the Regulation of Quintessence (ARC), the Agency for Intervariant Operations (AIO), and the Intervariant Cooperation and Development Agency (ICDA).

It is in the first of these that I have the honor—and the pleasure—to serve.

The central offices of all three agencies are located in the same place—the Trillium complex, nearby the first Gate. Regional branches stand near the others. Each office includes Quintessence vaults: we striders are required to deposit all collected quinta immediately upon returning from every picking.

The offices also maintain hangars with fleets of gliders and all necessary equipment. The central complex houses a neurocoding center, a training facility with its simulation grounds, and residential quarters used by staff from all three agencies as needed. Most of the time those quarters stand empty: the majority of striders and technical specialists live in nearby towns, usually no more than an hour's flight from Trillium.

I was no exception. I rented a small cottage on the outskirts of a quiet town not far from headquarters—and, more importantly for me, from the training grounds. That is where we “field” striders can most often be found, when we're not out on a picking. We spend a significant portion of our free time there engaged in honing—refining our professional skills.

What those skills are—I'll explain now.

The size and structure of an ARC Essence picker's compensation package depend on two things: rank as an agent and class as a specialist.

Rank is essentially a formal measure of trust. It grows with tenure, with the number and quality of completed pickings, with the volume of Essence delivered to the vaults, and with the level of responsibility entrusted to you. There are five ranks. Each one unlocks new levels of access, authority, and, naturally, reward.

Class works differently. A picker's class is not about seniority or loyalty—it's about competence. About how well you can do the job you came to the Agency to do.

Class is determined by a cumulative score assessing professionally significant skills. The NA assigns these scores automatically and impartially—both during real operations and during honing sessions. The higher the total, the higher the strider's class. There are five classes—just as there are five ranks, and five core skills. I don't know whether there's any deeper meaning in that symmetry. Most likely not. It simply turned out that way.

The first and primary skill of a picker is, of course, picking itself. This includes the ability to locate nuggets, work with tackle, scanners, mask, and Layers—everything without which efficient Essence collection would be impossible.

The second skill is piloting. It begins with operating floaters in our Variant—gliders, drifters, and other vehicles. But it doesn't end there. Piloting extends to any mode of transport a picker encounters in other Variants. And there, transportation can vary wildly. In Variant Two, for example, striders travel on riding dragons. In Variant Three—on blimps, compact and highly maneuverable dirigibles. In Variant Four—on bikes, trikes, and quads. And so on, across the Delta.

The third skill is dodging. This is the art of avoiding a resonator strike through a specific movement technique—sharp, irregular, unpredictable. A resonator does not aim at a person, it aims at the calculated point where that person is expected to be in the next moment. The goal is simple: not to be there when the shot arrives.

The fourth skill is unarmed control. This is not about aggression but about receiving an attack and working with its momentum: managing distance, balance, and the opponent's center of gravity; breaking holds; redirecting force; applying locks and control techniques.

And finally, the fifth skill is resonator handling. Here, accuracy matters—but judgment matters more. It is less about hitting the target than about knowing precisely when a shot is truly necessary. As we say: "A good strider shoots rarely. A very good one... almost never."

Pickings. Honing. A bit of fitness. A bit of personal life. That's how time passes.

And, if I'm honest, it passes well.

I like being who I am: a strider, an ARC agent, and a Quintessence picker of Variant One.

Chapter 16. Big Tom

The sensation of passing through a Gate most closely resembles the feeling of falling asleep—and then waking up.

In the very second you step into the Gate, a wave of blissful, almost dizzying relaxation rolls over you. It feels as if you're slipping into sleep—light, warm, gentle. Your body loosens completely, to the point of a faint tingling lightness, as though you're drifting in clouds. Your mind relaxes just as effortlessly; thoughts simply dissolve. Your sense of self sinks from deliberate awareness into a realm of carefree, wordless feeling. There is perfect calm. Harmony. A quiet, radiant peace. The sensation deepens rapidly, pulling you farther and farther inward.

But that rising euphoria lasts only a few fleeting moments.

Then some unseen force suddenly seizes you and drags you back—back into consciousness, into reality. It comes with a growing heaviness: fatigue, dull melancholy, a strange apathy. Like waking after days of sleep deprivation on a gray November Monday morning.

That was how the reality of another world received me.

Subjectively, the transition feels as if it lasts several long seconds. In truth, it happens in an instant—within a single step. I had barely lifted my foot and moved forward when I was already setting it down again, the vast shimmering wall of the Gate sliding through me and settling behind my back.

I swayed and took a couple of quick steps to keep from collapsing onto the ground.

I was standing on grass. It was night. The same—or almost the same—mountains and pines bathed in moonlight. The same sky. The same stars.

I felt terrible. A vast, all-encompassing exhaustion clung to me—physical and psychological. I wanted to surrender again, to let go and return to that infinite, blissful surrender at any cost. But it was impossible. I had to endure it, fight it, force myself back into this harsh and unpleasant reality.

I turned my head and saw Art. He stood nearby, watching me carefully, looking perfectly composed.

"The first few minutes are the worst," he said. "Then it stabilizes—to almost normal. You'll still feel residual effects for a few hours. Your Essence level drops sharply during the transition. Recovery follows a kind of hyperbolic curve—very fast at first, then gradually leveling out. Better sit or lie down. And try not to think."

I followed his advice and lowered myself onto the grass. My pack immediately began to shift and reshape, forming a comfortable cushion with a headrest. I stretched out my legs, settled back, and stared up at the night sky.

That was when I noticed—or rather realized—the first unmistakable sign that we were in another world. There were noticeably more stars. And many of them weren't fixed in place—they drifted slowly across the sky, moving in different directions.

A second later I understood: they weren't stars. They were floaters—flying vehicles, the kind Art had told me about.

"Feeling any better?" he asked.

I turned my head. Art was sitting on the grass as well, reclining against his own pack-backrest.

"Yeah... I think so," I replied weakly, enunciating carefully.

"Big Tom will be here any minute," Art said. "Think you'll manage to get aboard?"

"Big Tom?" I repeated.

"Mm-hm. My Agency-issued glider. I named it after Thomas—our Head of Personnel Affairs. He grumbles every time he hears it, pretends to object, but..." Art smirked. "It's mostly for show."

Curiosity was beginning to outweigh my weakness—which, to be fair, was already fading.

"And what did Thomas do to deserve that honor?" I asked.

Art shrugged.

"He picked exactly the right glider for me. And generally... You'll understand once you meet him."

"What's so special about the glider? And why was it hard to find one like that?"

"Well... not exactly hard," Art said thoughtfully. "But still. The thing is, it's entirely my taste. As if it had been designed specifically for me."

I waited for him to elaborate.

"You see, I like things compact. Or rather... optimized." He paused, searching for the word. "I value quality over quantity—or, in this case, size. Agency policy assigns us full-scale intercontinental lounges. They're comfortable, sure. But to me they feel unnecessarily bulky."

He interrupted himself.

"I haven't told you yet. Cabs and lounges are the two main types of passenger gliders. A cab is basically a flying car—sit down and go. They're meant for short, lower-altitude trips. A lounge is more like an apartment in the sky: you can move around, there are pilot seats, a rest area—everything you need for long-distance flights at higher altitudes, when frequent descents aren't practical."

He paused briefly.

"When a Storm breaks, it's critical for us striders to reach the required Gate as fast as possible. And since the right Gate is often on another continent, the flight can take many hours. During that time you need to rest before the picking—especially if you've been called out in the evening or at night. That's why everyone flies lounges. But..." He raised his eyebrows meaningfully. "Lounges are bulky by definition. Heavy. Which means—everything else being equal—slower. And the maneuverability... tolerable at best. Big Tom, on the other hand..."

At that moment I heard a low, rising hum. One of the "stars" detached itself from the sky and began descending rapidly toward us.

"...is a compact semi-lounge fitted with top-tier engines and an exceptional range," Art continued. "On full tanks, he can circle the Earth without refueling."

The approaching star took on the clear outline of an aircraft, seemingly illuminated from within—or perhaps from every surface at once. I made out short, powerful wings arranged in a horizontal X, each ending in thickened pylons. In the center glowed a brightly lit cockpit. The engine hum shifted into a softer, whistling hiss as the craft decelerated.

"The cockpit and lounge are integrated," Art went on, "which maximizes not only range, but maneuverability."

Now close enough to study properly, the glider revealed more detail. The X-shaped wings doubled as pylons; at their tips were mounted four horizontal cylinders, each housing a pair of engines. Four smaller maneuvering thrusters were embedded along the plane of each wing-pylon. The central cabin—about the size of a small bus—projected forward in a teardrop-shaped transparent canopy, through which two massive pilot seats were clearly visible. The upper engine blocks were capped with bulky, ribbed structures; beneath the lower ones I could see twin rows of partially recessed landing gear. The entire structure

emitted a soft white glow, though I could see no distinct light sources. Apparently, the material itself possessed a luminous quality.

Art continued, almost casually:

“Honestly, that kind of range and agility aren’t often required on duty. But an Agency glider can be used privately as well—it’s part of the compensation package. So with Big Tom I can, in theory, fly to any point on the planet every weekend and explore every corner of it.”

As if to confirm his claim, Big Tom swept in close, executed a smooth horizontal roll around his axis in the final meters, and then settled confidently onto the ground before us. The engines powered down. Silence fell.

Only a few tall blades of grass swayed for a moment longer.

I noted, with quiet satisfaction, that I already had enough strength to widen my eyes and drop my jaw. That meant I could probably manage standing up as well. I rose slowly, swayed slightly, but kept my balance.

The forward section of the glider’s floor detached and unfolded into a stepped ramp. Its edge lowered gently to the ground, and the white glow of the steps shifted to a soft green—as if Big Tom were politely saying: welcome aboard.

I glanced at Art. He smiled and gestured invitingly—there was a hint of theatrical flourish in it.

I climbed the steps slowly, feeling like a character in an alien-invasion film boarding a flying saucer.

The top of the ramp opened into the rear section of the cabin. Inside, my gaze landed on three outlined door frames set into the back wall, each marked with softly glowing green icons. The two side doors bore suitcase symbols; the central one displayed a water droplet. As I approached, all three doors slid open silently.

“You can use the sanitizer if you need to,” Art said. “Throw your backpack into any locker. You can take off the mask and the clip now. Big Tom’s security systems fully comply with Quintessence transport protection protocols.”

“I’d almost forgotten those existed,” I said with a faint grin, removing my backpack, mask, and clip and placing them in the right-hand compartment.

Then a thought occurred to me—one that suddenly seemed important.

“Wait... how is it that our backpacks, clothes, shoes—all of it—passes through the Gate with us?”

A second thought followed immediately:

“And that means... theoretically... we could fly Big Tom straight through as well. Right?”

Art gave me an approving look.

“That’s an important subject,” he said evenly. “We’ll discuss it over dinner.”

Then I saw a narrow panel slide out of the rear cabin wall, between the doors and directly in front of Art. On its upper surface were two rectangular recessed slots. Art took two identical boxes from the backpack standing beside him and, with visible satisfaction, carefully set them into the slots. The panel glowed green, then silently retracted back into the wall.

I nodded to myself and moved toward the front of the cabin. Two luxurious light-beige seats stood there—and nothing else.

I glanced back at Art and, after receiving his confirming nod, lowered myself into the left seat, opposite “my” storage compartment. Art settled into the right one without haste, almost casually.

“Well,” he said, “there’s nothing left keeping us here. In fact, our direct duty at this moment is to deliver the boxes to the vault immediately—with full urgency and in strict compliance with security protocols.”

He leaned back in his seat.

“There’s a vault at every Agency branch—meaning near every Gate—except this one. The nearest one, fortunately for us, is by the Central Office. About two hours from here.” He smirked. “Two hours on Big Tom, that is. His cruising speed is over two thousand kilometers per hour. Though, of course, some time will be spent climbing and descending through the regulated levels. So the average speed will be lower.”

“Levels?” I repeated.

“You’ll learn tomorrow. You’ll have your first download. It includes all the basic information, everyday skills—and a false memory. It’ll let you feel here, in Variant 1, as if you belong.”

I had neither the strength nor the desire to ask more. If he said tomorrow, then tomorrow it would be. I simply nodded.

“Excellent,” Art concluded. “Then we depart.”

The edges of the seat extended smoothly along both sides of my body and behind my shoulders, folding inward like petals closing around a bud. They met at the front, forming something like a soft vest—though it did not press against me, leaving a couple of centimeters of air between the structure and my clothes. I leaned forward slightly to test it, and the front section parted just as smoothly, still without touching me. I thought that if I were wearing a perfectly tailored suit, this “seatbelt equivalent” wouldn’t wrinkle it in the slightest.

A soft hiss sounded behind us. I turned—and for a moment couldn’t tell what had changed.

The hatch we had entered through was gone. Not merely closed—gone. The floor showed no trace of its outline.

A pleasant two-note chime sounded in the quiet cabin, and before us appeared a three-dimensional projection of a segment of the globe, with an arcing route traced above it. At the beginning of the arc glowed a tiny icon representing our glider.

Beneath the map appeared the text:

Destination: ARC Central Office, Quintessence Vault

Estimated time remaining: 1 hour 54 minutes

And below that:

Initiating departure

Outside, there came the faint whisper of engines coming alive. Almost at the same moment, Big Tom lifted smoothly from the ground, inclined slightly forward—as if offering a courteous bow to the towering arch of the Gate ahead—then moved forward, upward, and to the right. He completed nearly a full turn, leveled out, and began accelerating rapidly, gaining both speed and altitude.

I felt myself pressed firmly into the seat.

Chapter 17. The Flight

The bottom line on the holographic display changed to:

Engaging course

The sound of the engines shifted—lower, deeper—and the acceleration increased noticeably. The walls and ceiling of the cabin, along with the floor beneath our feet, were fully transparent, giving us an almost panoramic view. I watched the ground drop away at astonishing speed. For a brief moment I could still make out a few illuminated structures in the distance, but they quickly dissolved into scattered points of light.

Almost immediately after that, the cabin shell gradually lost its transparency, as though veiled in a soft, warm beige glow. The world outside faded, and the interior became cozy—almost domestic.

The steep climb lasted about a minute. Then the angle of ascent eased, the glider leveled out, and we transitioned into near-horizontal flight. The acceleration faded to almost nothing.

A new line appeared beneath the route map:

On course

The edges of the “safety vest” unfolded smoothly and retracted back into the seat.

Art glanced at me.

“Dinner will be here in nine minutes. For your first time—something familiar: beef steak, fried potatoes, a vegetable salad, and orange juice. Sound good?”

“Yes, perfect. And... is there a kitchen on board?”

Art smiled.

“No kitchen. I just ordered delivery.”

I stared at him, waiting for a grin or a *Got you*. But he looked entirely serious.

“Oh. I see,” I muttered. “In that case, I’ll take you up on your offer to use the... what did you call it?”

“Sanitizer. Yes, go ahead. It’s intuitive, but ask if you need anything. I’d suggest a shower—you’ll appreciate it right now. Toss your clothes and shoes into the bin; they’ll be cleaned while you wash.”

I stood and walked to the rear section of the cabin. The door marked with a water droplet slid open silently. Inside was a compact but surprisingly spacious compartment equipped with everything one might need.

I used the facilities, and as soon as I washed my hands, a shower icon illuminated beside the mirror. I touched it.

The fixtures withdrew seamlessly into the walls. A neat recessed compartment slid out—a clothing bin. I undressed quickly and placed everything inside. The bin retracted, and the surface sealed smoothly over it.

The air began to move around me, swirling gently. The walls and ceiling took on a soft silver sheen. The shower activated—not from above or the sides, but seemingly from everywhere at once. Warm water enveloped me in fine, almost weightless streams. Then the flow shifted into a light mist, faintly tingling, as if electrically charged; it seemed to cleanse more thoroughly than any soap or gel I’d ever used. Finally, a cocoon of warm air wrapped around me, drying me as gently as if by invisible hands.

The entire process lasted less than a minute.

When the air stilled, a panel slid out from the wall with my clothes—clean, dry, and slightly warm. I dressed, put my shoes back on, and returned to my seat feeling refreshed and unexpectedly alert.

“Perfect timing,” Art commented. “Now it’s my turn.”

He headed toward the sanitizer.

Barely seconds after the door closed behind him, the hologram in front of the windshield changed. The map dissolved, replaced by a slowly rotating three-dimensional image of a compact trapezoidal craft with smooth, streamlined edges.

Above it appeared:

Docking request

Small service drone, "On the Fly" delivery

Accept Decline

After a few seconds, *Accept* highlighted softly in green on its own, and the header changed to:

Docking authorized

The display then reverted to the route map, where our glider icon had already advanced noticeably.

A couple of minutes later, Art emerged from the sanitizer, crossed the cabin, and dropped into his seat with visible satisfaction.

At that very moment, a faint jolt rippled through the cabin—more like the soft bump of a pillow than anything dramatic. No bang. No vibration. Just a subtle tremor in the air, as if we had passed through a dense pocket of warm wind.

I flinched—more from surprise than impact.

"What was that? The docking?" I asked.

Art looked at me calmly.

"No. The drone's already gone. That was us catching up with our own sound—we just went supersonic. I've heard that long ago breaking the sound barrier came with a loud crack, even a shockwave you could feel on the ground. These days active wave-suppression systems dampen almost all of it before it fully forms."

I nodded, impressed.

"Well then," he said with genuine enthusiasm, "now we can eat."

I suddenly realized that the weakness and heaviness I'd felt after the transition were almost entirely gone—and that I was ravenously hungry.

Not surprising, I thought. The last time I ate... was in another world.

The armrests of our seats had already unfolded into broad dining surfaces.

A soft hiss sounded behind us. I turned my head—and flinched involuntarily.

Hovering at about eye level was a strange light-beige object, suspiciously similar in size and shape to a compact washing machine.

"Hello, Mac. Hello, Art. May I set the table?" the "washing machine" asked in a cheerful young male voice.

"Hi, Estri. Yes, please. We're starving," Art replied with a grin. "Mac, meet Estri—our butler mech. If you need anything, ask him. He has everything and can do everything."

"Mac, don't listen to him," Estri replied, drifting lazily around our tables. From panels opening along his underside, articulated manipulators extended and began deftly producing plates with food, cutlery, glasses of orange juice, napkins—and even miniature vases with what looked like fresh flowers. "He forgets that my modification doesn't include enough RAM for a proper sense of humor."

“Aha! Caught you,” Art said, picking up his fork and pointing it accusingly at the hovering mech. “You just disproved that with your last sentence.”

“Still could use more memory,” Estri muttered, finishing the table setting before floating off toward the rear of the lounge.

Before me lay a steak glistening with pink juices, perfectly crisp slices of fried potatoes, three sauces—each somehow better than the last—a salad of impossibly fresh vegetables and herbs, and a glass of orange juice that smelled like sunlight and tropical orchards, its surface beaded with cold dew. The sight of it left no room for thought—only total culinary reverence.

We attacked the food in silence.

After a while, Art took a sip of juice, exhaled with satisfaction, and said:

“So. About your question—why a backpack can pass through the Gate, but flying Big Tom through it almost certainly wouldn’t work.”

He spoke while continuing to give proper attention to his dinner. I was doing the same, though mostly in silence—absorbing both the food and the explanation.

Art said that the inner Essence contour of a living being possesses a certain plasticity. It can expand, enveloping small objects that are in close contact with the body. Two conditions matter: contact and size.

“If your backpack fits tightly—almost hugging your body—the contour includes it the same way it includes your clothes. But only up to a limit. About thirty to forty centimeters in thickness. Anything bulkier simply won’t fit inside the contour. It stays outside, no matter how tightly you press yourself against it.”

This rule, he added, makes it possible to carry a non-strider through the Gate on your back—but not in your arms. Because whatever enters your contour quickly—within seconds—rises to match its level. And here’s the surprising part: it doesn’t draw from your internal Essence. It draws from the external field. Your own level doesn’t drop.

“So,” Art concluded, “Big Tom could theoretically be taken through a Gate. But only by boosting his quint level with a quint pump. And given his size—and what he’s made of—it would require so much Essence that it would be cheaper to build a new factory on the other side and manufacture a new Big Tom there.”

He smiled, signaling that the last part was a joke—though not entirely.

By then we had finished dinner. Estri quietly cleared the dishes and replaced them with cups of fragrant herbal tea. Art leaned back with visible pleasure and took a small sip. I did the same.

On the map hovering before us, our glider icon had already covered more than three quarters of the route. A new message appeared beneath it:

Descending for landing at destination

Art took another sip, then turned slightly toward me.

“Tomorrow there’ll probably be an afterparty for our picking,” he said lazily. “That’s what we call the debrief with the team lead. Someone once said it as a joke, and the name stuck. So... what do you think the analysts will find most interesting about this one?”

“The attack,” I answered instantly.

Art responded with eloquent silence—just a faint smile and another sip of tea.

“You’re not about to say they’ll be most interested in the appearance of such a valuable new employee as me?” I tried.

His expression turned unexpectedly serious.

"That's closer. You're not just valuable, Mac. You became a strider under unique circumstances. And it's very possible your abilities are unique as well. And what happened during this picking..." He gently rocked his cup, as if weighing the thought. "It strengthens that assumption."

"What do you mean?" I asked, suddenly alert.

"At least two things. First—the unusual interest from the Creatures. And judging by it, not in both of us. In you."

He fell silent, letting me draw the conclusion myself.

And he was right. First the Black Jellyfish. Then the Tumbleweed. Art had said Creatures almost never paid attention to humans in general—and to striders in particular. I nodded.

"Suppose that's true. What's the second thing?"

"The second..." he said quietly, almost to himself. "The way you found the wedding cake. You practically dragged us there. As if you sensed it. And things like that don't happen by accident. I don't believe in coincidences like that."

He finished his tea and set the cup down. Almost immediately, Estri appeared beside us.

"More tea, Art? We've got time before landing."

"Thanks, my friend, I'm good," Art said, handing over his saucer. I did the same. Estri vanished soundlessly toward the rear of the Lounge.

The cabin walls became transparent again—just as softly and imperceptibly as they had clouded before. As if someone had simply lifted a thin matte filter, and the world outside flared into brilliance.

I rose slightly from my seat, forgetting my fatigue for a moment.

Below us lay not darkness, but a boundless golden radiance. It looked as though a vast sea of light had spilled across the land—billions of sparks from streets, highways, districts, floaters, hovering platforms, and layered interchanges. I had seen something similar before through an airplane window over a night megacity. But here it was as if ten such cities had been superimposed upon one another, merging into a single luminous, multi-tiered continent.

We flew directly above it—over sweeping arcs of transit lines, over fiery aerial highways of moving floaters, over towers that from this height resembled jeweled needles piercing the sky. In some places, light cascaded down the slopes of hills like waterfalls. In others, it gathered into dense geometric clusters resembling constellations.

The glider descended gently. The oceans of light gradually gave way to dark mountain masses. For several minutes we flew over ridgelines—black as silhouettes, cut by silver threads of roads and scattered sparks of alpine settlements.

Then, beyond another ridge, a complex of buildings appeared ahead, shimmering with a ghostly green glow. Its shape resembled a three-pointed star—or more precisely, a flower opening against the mountainside.

"That's Trillium," Art said, and I could hear the smile in his voice. "The central office of the three Agencies. Our second home."

Three elegant structures, slightly curved like petals or rays, radiated from a shared core. Their façades emitted a soft emerald light—not from visible fixtures, but from the material itself—so the entire complex seemed carved from a single immense emerald.

The glider swept over the complex.

A few seconds later, a sheer vertical wall of rock rose before us as if conjured from nowhere.

It was flawlessly smooth, black and dense as shadow. It seemed to absorb light rather than reflect it.

We were flying straight toward it.

Then, several hundred meters above the ground, the wall... opened.

First, a circular outline appeared on the rock face—dozens of meters across, divided into six equal segments. The circle seemed to sink slightly into the surrounding stone. Then the segments slid apart smoothly and silently, like the rotating blades of a colossal camera aperture.

A softly illuminated cavern opened before us, vast enough to house an entire air fleet.

“The Vault,” Art said. “Welcome to the inner sanctum.”

In the surrounding silence, his voice carried a faint note of ceremony.

Big Tom glided inward with quiet authority, as though asserting his right to be there. Behind us, the segmented aperture began to close—just as smoothly, just as soundlessly—and within seconds the light of the outside world vanished, leaving us suspended in the even glow of the interior hangar.

The glider slowed and came to a halt, hovering in the center of the immense chamber. The surrounding walls were matte, suffused with soft diffused light that gradually dimmed above and below, making them appear infinitely tall. It felt as though we were suspended inside a colossal vertical shaft carved into the heart of the mountain. The air was perfectly still—conditioned evenly throughout the entire volume of space.

A hologram flickered to life before us: a translucent rendering of Big Tom with its internal compartments highlighted. One section in the central lower hull glowed mint-green—the same compartment where Art had placed our quint-boxes back near the Gates.

“We’re waiting for the ARC safe-drone to collect the boxes,” Art said.

As if summoned by his words, a substantial silver craft descended from above. Its shape truly resembled an enormous vault safe. The drone drifted closer, slowing as it approached, then slid beneath Big Tom—and simultaneously appeared as a translucent form within the hologram.

We watched as it docked to the glider’s underside. I felt no impact at all.

Text appeared across the holographic display:

ARC Safe-Drone No. 11

Container retrieval procedure initiated

An image of one quint-box materialized. We saw it glide downward and transfer seamlessly into the docked drone. The image vanished.

Retrieval, 1 of 2

Status: successful

Art and I watched in silence. I realized I couldn’t hear a single sound—as if everything were happening in a vacuum.

The drone extracted the second quint-box just as effortlessly.

Retrieval, 2 of 2

Status: successful

The drone’s image detached from our glider at once, and a moment later it appeared before us in the hangar itself. Rising smoothly, the safe-drone gained speed and headed toward the far wall. Just ahead of it,

a smaller circular aperture opened in the stone—the same diaphragm mechanism, only scaled down. The drone slipped inside, and the segments closed soundlessly behind it. Once again, the wall became a flawless, unbroken surface.

A message appeared on the hologram:

Transfer to vault—in progress

Awaiting confirmation

Almost immediately, it changed:

Received:

Container No. 1: 7056α

Container No. 2: 4823α

Status: successful

Then the hologram vanished.

Art leaned back and nodded with quiet satisfaction.

“Well then. Mission complete. Time to go home—and sleep.”

As the vault doors sealed behind us, Big Tom increased speed slightly and glided back into the night air.

Below us stretched a valley threaded with silver ribbons of roads and warm constellations of light. The city thinned gradually, dissolving into scattered clusters, then fading into darkened hills and forest.

Yet the lights did not disappear entirely. Ahead, another illuminated ring emerged—a loose constellation of soft, shifting glows that seemed to pulse with a life of their own. Tom descended calmly, and I began to distinguish small cottages nestled in greenery, gently lit from within. As I understood it, this was the residential complex for Agency staff.

It resembled neither a village nor a conventional town. More than anything, it felt like a nocturnal garden, where luminous houses had sprouted from the earth itself—not aligned along streets, not arranged in rows, but grown organically from the landscape.

The cottages stood at different elevations along a gentle mountain slope. Between them stretched layered lawns—sometimes terraced, sometimes rolling in soft waves—dotted with flowers, low trees, and shrubs that glowed faintly from within. The light did not seem to come from lamps; rather, some of the leaves themselves appeared to emit a steady, subtle radiance.

“There’s yours,” Art said quietly.

I followed his gesture. The cottage he indicated looked... especially welcoming. Its walls, made of a smooth, warm-toned material, glowed with a soft amber hue. A wide terrace wrapped around it, and the short stairway leading up was framed by flowering shrubs dusted with silver blossoms.

Big Tom descended almost without a sound. A small level landing pad lay before the house, clearly designed for gliders like him. Tom hovered above it, rotated slightly—as though offering his side to the moonlight—and settled gently into place. Once again, I barely felt the touchdown.

Silence filled the cabin.

Art stretched, then rose in a brisk motion, as if shaking off the last of his fatigue.

“Welcome to your new home, Mac,” he said with a faint smile. “Tomorrow won’t be an easy day. Get some rest. You’ll need it.”

He headed for the exit.

I followed, feeling a slight tremor in my knees—not from exhaustion, but from that strange awareness that life had just divided irrevocably into *before* and *after*.

Outside, the night was quiet and crystalline.

The cottage truly was “submerged” in flowers—like a small island of calm in a valley of stars. The fragrance made me slightly lightheaded in the most pleasant way.

We stepped inside, and soft light rose from floor to ceiling as if greeting us. The living room was spacious but not empty: low sofas that seemed to grow out of the floor, transparent tables shifting in tone with the ambient light, and a panoramic wall revealing dark trees and softly glowing lawns beyond.

To the left, through a wide opening, lay the kitchen area. It was nearly invisible when unattended, but as soon as one approached, the smooth surfaces awakened—control panels appearing, functional sections sliding open without a sound.

Art walked farther in.

“Bedroom’s here,” he said, gesturing toward a wall that parted silently to reveal a room with a softly illuminated headboard. The bed’s surface rippled slightly in response to my approach, as if inviting me to lie down.

“And the bathroom’s here.” Another wall opened. “You’ll figure out the controls easily—everything’s smart. It’ll know what you need.”

He paused for a moment, apparently checking whether he’d forgotten anything. Then he nodded to himself and turned to me.

“I’ll be back in the morning. Afterparty’s at eleven—you’ll have time to sleep in. No need for an alarm.”

He smiled and shook my hand.

“Welcome to Variant One, Mac.”

I looked at him with sincere gratitude.

“Thank you, Art.”

He stepped outside. Through the panoramic window, I watched as Big Tom lifted smoothly from the landing pad. His light brushed the trees, then he accelerated confidently and vanished into the night sky.

I had just enough strength left to reach the bed, which seemed to gather me into a quiet embrace. The thoughts crowding my mind receded quickly, leaving only one.

Soon, I would see Zara again. She was somewhere nearby now.

Nearby, I realized, now simply meant *in the same world*.

At that thought, I smiled—and slipped into sleep.

Chapter 18. Integration

I woke, opened my eyes, and found myself in complete darkness. It lasted only a second. Then the wall to the left of the bed transformed into a window, letting in soft streams of morning light.

Before me stretched a neat lawn of lush, vibrant green, still faintly shimmering with dew. A little farther on rose a gentle hill dotted with flowering shrubs and solitary blossoms—bright, full, so varied in shape and color that my gaze kept catching on each new shade.

I got out of bed and walked to the window.

Yes. I should have expected that, I told myself.

To the left of the lawn, on the pad in front of the cottage entrance, Big Tom sat nestled in place. Which meant Art had already returned and was waiting for me to wake.

I turned and headed toward the wall separating the bedroom from the living room. As I approached, it obligingly slid aside.

But Art wasn't alone.

He was lounging comfortably in an armchair, feet propped on the low table, and at the sight of me he simply smiled and gave a casual wave.

From another chair rose a young woman I had never seen before.

One glance at her, and the cliché *"looks like a million dollars"* came immediately to mind. Tall, slender—almost strikingly so—a blonde whose hair fell over her shoulders in what looked like effortless disarray, though the effort behind it was clearly meticulous. A face radiant with freshness, touched only by the faintest makeup, just enough to accentuate her natural beauty. Calm, intelligent light-blue eyes. A subtle, friendly half-smile. A perfectly tailored dark business suit that emphasized her figure, paired with a crisp white blouse whose collar was opened just enough to seem unstudied.

Everything about her—every feature, every movement—radiated refined grace and impeccable elegance.

"Mac, I'm glad we finally meet. Mona," she said, stepping closer and extending her hand with fluid poise.

I took her slender, smooth hand. Mona inclined her head slightly toward her shoulder in a graceful, welcoming gesture and smiled.

"Art and I... well... we're seeing each other," she added, glancing toward him.

I looked at Art as well. He raised his eyebrows in exaggerated astonishment.

"You used to avoid phrasing it like that. Mac, you're clearly having a positive influence on Mona. Please, do keep it up."

I felt a flicker of awkwardness—but it was instantly dispelled by the arrival of a familiar figure.

Estri.

He must have been in the room all along; I simply hadn't noticed him at first. The mech drifted toward Mona, offering her a cup and saucer.

"Just the way you like it. Strong, no cream, a touch of caramel syrup," he said warmly. Then, in a different tone, added, "And no, in this case the sweetness won't hurt your figure."

"Estri... as always, you know me better than I know myself," Mona sighed, accepting the cup.

"Mac, coffee?" Estri turned toward me. "Your breakfast will be ready fifteen seconds before you exit the bathroom."

"Thanks, Estri," I smiled. "Message received."

And I headed for the bathroom.

I quickly figured out everything in there—the setup strongly resembled the sanitizer on board Big Tom. I went through my morning routine as efficiently as possible, trying not to keep Mona and Art waiting.

When I returned, however, they did not look like people who had spent the time in patient anticipation.

If anything, they looked conspiratorial—and faintly embarrassed. Art, in particular, was radiating unmistakably excellent spirits.

Before I could dwell on that, Estri intercepted my attention again.

"Mac, since you haven't yet settled on a preferred food class, I deemed it appropriate to begin today with an organic breakfast. Mona and Art assured me they had no objections."

"Thank you," I said—whether to Estri or to the two of them, I wasn't entirely sure—and turned my gaze toward the round table by the broad transparent wall overlooking the pad where Big Tom was parked.

The table was set for three. That much was clear from the number of soft, inviting chairs and the neatly arranged place settings before them. In the center stood a lower rotating round tray loaded with dishes, polished covered serving bowls, coffee pots, and pitchers. Above it all, drifting lightly in the air, Estri busied himself adding yet more plates.

"Mac, Art says you drink coffee in the mornings. Or would you prefer tea?" Estri asked, gliding toward the kitchen area.

"Coffee, please. Black. One spoon of sugar," I replied absently, still trying to orient myself and decide how exactly I was supposed to behave.

"Mac," Art said with a smile, approaching the table alongside Mona, "I think it'll be easier for you at first if Estri stays with you for a while. Estri, will you help Mac feel at home?"

He waited for Mona to sit, then took his own seat.

"Of course. I'll be delighted," Estri responded enthusiastically from somewhere in the kitchen.

"And what about you?" I asked Art, taking my seat as well.

Mona answered for him.

"We've decided Art will be staying with me for now. My Tuvi and I will try not to let him regress into a primitive state."

Art's mood suddenly made perfect sense.

"Tuvi, by the way, has absolutely no idea how to brew a proper herbal tea," Estri remarked grumpily as he drifted toward the table and placed a steaming cup of coffee in front of me.

"That's not true, and you know it," Mona replied calmly and with quiet confidence. "Just because everyone—including me—admires your tea doesn't mean no one else can make it."

As she spoke, she nudged the edge of the upper rotating tier of the table. It began to turn smoothly. When a bowl of lush green salad drifted within reach, she lifted several leaves onto her plate with a pair of serving tongs.

Glancing at Art, I saw an appetizing omelet on his plate, which he had apparently retrieved from one of the covered dishes.

Taking their example as encouragement, I quickly assembled my own breakfast: fried eggs, bacon, fresh vegetables, buttered toast, orange juice, and coffee.

Maybe even as good as Lemar's, I thought as I began to eat.

"Mac," Mona said, turning to me, "Art told me you were asking what it would take for your home Variant to move from closed to open."

It occurred to me that they must have spent quite a bit of time together already if she knew even that detail.

"Yes, that's right," I replied, immediately attentive. "As you can imagine, that question matters not only to me, but to several billion people living there—in my Variant."

Mona nodded.

"I understand. Believe me, I do," she said with an enthusiasm that surprised me.

I met her gaze. There was a spark there—genuine, alive, unmistakably engaged.

"I want to tell you how things stand at the moment. At ICDA we call this process Variant integration. Personally, I believe it's the central purpose of our work. In my view, all our efforts should be directed toward—yes, gradual, yes, careful—but ultimately inevitable integration of all Variants. I believe that is not only the mission of our Agency, but of everyone in our Variant."

She fell silent, as if slightly embarrassed by her own intensity.

"There's... another opinion?" I asked cautiously, glancing from Mona to Art.

They both seemed faintly uncomfortable.

"Yes," Art said darkly. "There's another approach. Segregation. Many people in the Forum—and not only there—believe integration in the foreseeable future is unrealistic. Worse, they fear possible aggression from one of the Variants. So in their view, we should prepare defensively. Including stockpiling non-lethal weapons and other protective measures."

"And what's the result?" I asked. "Which position prevailed? Which direction are you... I mean, are *we* moving in?"

"As usual, something in between," Mona said with a restrained smile. "We develop contingency plans so we're prepared for negative scenarios, while at the same time taking steps toward integration. The good news is that for each closed Variant, ICDA has developed a long-term strategy where integration remains the ultimate objective. But... of course, we understand that in each case we're at a different distance from that goal."

That reminded me of a question that had been lingering in my mind.

"How many Variants are open right now?" I asked carefully. "And... how are things going with them?"

They smiled at the same time.

"There are two open Variants at present—the Fifth and the Sixth," Art said. "And fortunately, relations with both are stable and good."

"Why those two?" I asked. "What makes them different?"

"Excellent question," Mona said approvingly. "And the answer is quite simple. In both of those Variants, knowledge of Quintessence existed long before the Gates appeared."

She continued:

"In the Fifth Variant, what they once called 'magic' has been cultivated for centuries. The word *magic* itself is considered outdated there. Instead, they speak of the Art of the Subtle Field or Fieldcraft. They refer to

Quintessence as Field Energy and treat it as the foundational basis of all Field practices—both theoretical and applied.”

She paused briefly before going on.

“In the Sixth Variant, humanity took a different path—biotechnology. They even look somewhat different from us—you’ll see for yourself. Their long-standing reverence for living systems led them, centuries ago, to recognize Quintessence as well. They call it the Great Mother. For them, it is less a tool than an object of sacred devotion. So their practices connected to Quintessence could also be described as ‘magic,’ in a sense—but it is primarily embedded within religious traditions rather than systematic engineering.”

Mona fell silent for a moment, thinking, then added:

“Incidentally, something resembling magic does exist in the Second Variant as well. There it’s simply called witchcraft, and those who practice it are known as witches and warlocks. They even have their own distinct community—the Order. But their craft is essentially pure art. They refine it through practice without attempting to understand its underlying nature, progressing entirely through experience. So they haven’t yet arrived at an awareness of what Essence truly is. Though personally, I suspect they’re closer than they realize.”

“And that’s why,” Art continued, “when the Gates appeared, only the Fifth and Sixth Variants had at least some framework for understanding what they were dealing with. They already knew why ordinary people couldn’t pass through the Gates—I mean, truly pass through them. So when striders emerged... in a sense, they were already expected.”

“And how do they feel about us now?” I asked. “I assume they’re not thrilled about letting us collect their Essence and keep it.”

Both Mona and Art darkened slightly. I felt at once that my question, though legitimate, had landed awkwardly.

Mona answered.

“It’s an uncomfortable question, Mac—but a necessary one. It touches on something broader and deeply ethical. Do we, as outsiders, have the right to appropriate the key resource of another world?”

She paused.

“A special commission was formed under the World Forum to examine that very issue. It included not only human representatives, but also NA. The commission concluded the following: in the form in which we collect and use Quintessence, it is an unstable, dissipating resource. The people of other Variants would not be able to use it effectively—unless we shared our technologies with them. But doing so would require revealing everything else as well, and for other reasons that is considered unacceptable.”

She continued evenly:

“Therefore, we are permitted to collect and use Quintessence in other Variants—but only until such time as their people learn to work with it themselves. Which, incidentally, is a powerful argument in favor of integration. Ethically speaking, we are obliged at least to attempt to help them learn to use so fundamental a resource for the benefit of their own humanity.”

They fell silent, allowing me to process what had been said and ask possible questions.

The question I asked, however, I asked silently and only to myself.

If we were the ones in their position—if our world were being approached this way—would we choose integration?

I considered it carefully. And in the end, I decided that yes—we probably would. And that the choice, in principle, was the right one.

Perhaps that conclusion showed on my face. Mona, watching me, seemed—unless I imagined it—quietly relieved. Art smiled as well and continued:

“To return to your earlier question—how things stand with the open Variants. Fortunately, in both cases we’ve reached mutually acceptable arrangements regarding Essence.”

“With the Fifth Variant,” he said, “we essentially trade. More precisely, we don’t trade Essence itself, but services related to its collection. We gather quinta for them, transfer it to their authorities, and retain an agreed share. That share isn’t fixed—it depends on multiple fluctuating factors. Overall, the arrangement satisfies both our Forum and their Council of Guardians, so our relationship remains pragmatic and stable.”

“Something similar applies to the Sixth Variant. They permit us to collect—for them, and only for them—a strictly defined quantity of Essence. The amount is determined by the priests of the Church of the Great Foremother. It is believed to be exactly what humanity truly requires—no more. And thus, the Great Foremother may grant that portion of herself. We deliver the collected Essence to them, and in exchange they share resources and technologies with us. In practice, the cooperation has proven highly effective.”

“And most importantly,” Mona interjected, almost cutting him off, “both examples demonstrate that integration—in one form or another—is possible. And ultimately, it fosters the development of both Variants—and therefore of humanity as a whole.”

“And that,” Art said with a smile, “means we’re not only doing something interesting—we’re doing something useful. And we can continue doing it right now, since the afterparty starts in twenty minutes.”

Only then did I realize that the remnants of my breakfast—and my coffee—had gone completely cold. I drained the cup in one swallow and stood.

“No rush, Mac,” Art reassured me. “Trillium is only a couple of minutes away.”

He rose as well.

“This afterparty will be an expanded one. In addition to Ellen and Manish—our chief analyst—Norton will attend. He’s the director of ARC. Mona will be there too, representing ICDA.”

I looked at Mona. She smiled with disarming charm.

“If you don’t mind, of course,” she said lightly.

“Of course not,” I replied. “You’re very welcome.”

“Then let’s get to work,” Art concluded.

We stood and headed toward the exit.

Halfway there, I glanced back and caught an unexpectedly captivating sight. Estri hovered above the table, and three articulated manipulators extended from his underside. With effortless precision, they gripped the edges of the rotating upper tier. Estri lifted it smoothly—dishes, pitchers, coffee pots and all—without the slightest visible strain.

Businesslike, like a bee returning to its hive, he carried the entire assembly toward the kitchen.

Chapter 19. Trillium

“Just grab your mask and clip. The rest—including coffee—you’ll find at the office,” Art said lightly as we stepped out of the cottage.

I smacked my forehead, hurried back into the bedroom, dug the mask and clip out of my pack, and put them on. Almost immediately, a neat icon appeared in the upper-right corner of my mask’s display—a small circle formed by stylized human figures. It pulsed softly. I focused my gaze on it, and it unfolded into a translucent window:

From: Ellen

Required: Mac, Art

Optional: Manish, Mona, Norton

Meeting Request

Time: 11:00–12:00

Location: Conference Room 16

Hi, guys.

I’ve saved your afterparty for dessert—after all the others—so you’ll have a chance to sleep in.

As you can probably guess (Art especially), the lineup will be expanded: besides Manish from Analytics, we’ll have Mona from ICDA, as well as Norton.

See you there!

—Ellen

Accept Decline

I mentally reached for *Accept*. It glowed a soft green, and the message dissolved a second later.

We stepped into the cabin—or perhaps the lounge—of Big Tom, and I immediately noticed the interior had changed. There were now three seats, arranged facing one another as if for a private conversation. As soon as we settled in and the soft safety harnesses folded around us, the glider lifted off almost soundlessly.

I glanced at my companions, wondering how to start a conversation—but then I noticed Mona’s gaze had gone distant, turned inward. I understood: she was speaking to someone through her clip. Art had noticed too. He kept a courteous silence, only occasionally glancing her way.

A few minutes passed like that. Then Mona stirred, looked at Art, then at me, then back at Art. He watched her quietly, questioningly. She seemed unsettled—excited, and slightly thrown off balance.

“It’s Karina,” she said at last, as if committing to the words. “Well... not just her.”

“Karina’s the director of ICDA,” Art explained quickly, flicking a glance at me before turning back to Mona.

She paused again, collecting herself. I noticed her fingers tighten slightly on the armrest.

“They’ve created a project task force at ICDA. Because of the new Gates. And because of... all of this.” She made a vague gesture. “The group’s work is being coordinated directly by a special commission under the Central Forum.”

Art straightened almost imperceptibly.

“And?” he asked evenly.

Mona exhaled.

"Karina just appointed me to lead it."

For a second, silence filled the cabin, broken only by the steady hum of Big Tom's engines.

"And Karina..." Mona added after a beat, "she's joining as an ordinary member."

I caught myself smiling.

Art, however, looked at her differently now—steady, serious, without a trace of irony.

"Congratulations," he said simply. "That's significant. And... it's right."

Mona met his eyes, gratitude flickering there.

"Honestly? I'm a little stunned," she admitted. "Everything's moving too fast."

"You'll handle it," Art said after a brief pause. "There's no one better for it right now."

She gave a noncommittal shrug. The nervousness hadn't vanished—but something else had taken its place: focus.

"Karina will join us via conference link," Mona added. "She said she'll brief us on the latest developments."

I made a mental note that this "afterparty" was shaping up to be far more substantial than I'd expected.

A few minutes later, we descended smoothly onto the wide landing platform in front of Trillium.

When we stepped out of the glider, an image materialized directly on the surface of the landing platform in front of us—a stylized arrow labeled:

Conference Room 16

The arrow drifted slowly toward the entrance, as if inviting us to follow—which we did.

Once inside the building and moving down the corridor, I noticed that the section of floor beneath our feet subtly transformed into a moving walkway, gently accelerating our steps.

Inside Trillium, the corridors opened into multi-level galleries. The space was filled with soft, almost imperceptible music. Miniature fountains murmured from recessed alcoves. The air was fresh and cool, carrying the faintest hint of pine and citrus.

Three-dimensional holographic panels stretched along the walls: mountain landscapes in one section, rolling ocean waves in another, elsewhere slowly shifting abstract forms that seemed almost alive. None of it distracted. On the contrary, it calmed the mind, aligning it quietly toward work.

A brief notification flickered across my mask:

Layer connected: People; filter: ARC

Now, beside each person passing through the space, discreet captions appeared with names, ranks, and positions:

Dong, Agent, Rank Two; Essence Picker, Class Three

Liana, Infrastructure Operator

Hamid, Essence Logistics Specialist

It felt completely natural, as though I had always seen people this way.

Then my gaze fixed on a trio approaching us—three... well, presumably humans—though their appearance made that assumption momentarily uncertain.

All three were noticeably taller and far more... slender—or perhaps refined—than everyone else around them. Their faces and figures seemed, I thought, almost excessively perfect.

In front walked a woman of piercing beauty, dressed in a long gown that emphasized rather than concealed her flawless, slender figure. The fabric resembled the finest scales; as she moved, it shimmered in cool tones—from turquoise to violet. Her hair was arranged in a high, immaculate coiffure, and the gaze of her large blue eyes was proud and cold, matching the palette of her attire.

The caption beside her read:

Elvina, Seventh Lady-in-Waiting to Her Majesty Queen Florianna; Special Envoy of the Royal Court of Christophers

Behind her followed two equally tall men, dressed in something midway between formal uniform and ceremonial costume. Yet one glance at their build and expressions erased any temptation to joke about their attire—or about them at all.

From the waist upward, each of them broadened almost twice toward the shoulders, their frames layered with massive, perfectly defined muscle. Their expressions were identical—what one might describe as *professionally assessing the optimal point on your face for the first strike*.

Their captions read:

Willem, Chamber Page of the Court of Christophers; Protector of the Crowned House

Bjorn, Senior Chamber Page of the Court of Christophers; Protector of the Crowned House

As the striking trio passed us, I noticed something odd:

All three of them were looking only at me.

A voice message from Art sounded quietly in my ear.

“Sixth Variant delegation. Elvina is part of the contact group representing one of their Royal Courts here. Don’t mind the severity—it’s mostly ceremonial. Protocol.”

I turned to glance at them once more and saw Willem glance back at me. His expression shifted instantly—suddenly ordinary, natural... even friendly.

The Chamber Page gave me the faintest wink, then turned away again.

A few moments later we reached a door bearing the inscription:

Conference Room 16

Reserved: Ellen

11:00–12:00

Chapter 20. The Afterparty

When we entered the room, two people were already there.

The first was Ellen.

The second had a caption beside him that was strikingly concise:

Norton, Director of ARC

He was tall and powerfully built, with a straight, assured posture and broad shoulders—strength without ostentation. His dark-skinned face carried noble features, a touch of silver at the temples, and eyes that were both gentle and exacting. When his gaze settled on me, I felt it immediately—intelligent, deep, attentive. The kind of look that makes concealment impossible, even in silence.

Norton and Ellen approached us almost at the same time. Ellen, Norton, Art, and Mona exchanged brief greetings.

Then Norton turned to me.

“Well then, Mac,” he said with a faint smile, extending his hand, “welcome aboard.”

“Thank you,” I replied sincerely, shaking his large hand and doing my best to remain composed.

“At the Agency,” Norton continued, “something is always happening. And in the past few days—especially so. I don’t think you’ll have much opportunity to be bored.”

“That’s exactly what I was hoping for,” I said—and this time it wasn’t just politeness.

We took our seats in the light, comfortable chairs arranged throughout the room. As I settled in, I noticed small platforms attached to the armrests, each with neat recessed slots—clearly meant for masks and clips.

My assumption was immediately confirmed. One by one, everyone began removing their masks and clips and, with what felt almost deliberate emphasis, placing them into the recesses.

Art slid his chair slightly closer to mine and leaned in.

“It’s tradition,” he explained quietly. “At in-person meetings, masks and clips come off. It’s a way of saying: you’re here. With people. Not somewhere else.”

I nodded and carefully placed my mask into its slot. The clip followed.

At that moment the door opened abruptly, and a young man almost burst into the room—dark-skinned, athletic, wearing a brilliantly white shirt tailored so precisely it looked custom-made, slim trousers, and light shoes. Even without the clip, I knew at once: Manish, Head of ARC Analytics.

He moved with quick, elastic energy, as if the world around him operated at a slightly slower tempo than he preferred. His animated expression drew the eye immediately, and his smile carried a habitual irony and an unmistakable enjoyment of the world.

“Whew,” he exhaled, glancing around. “Not late.”

I instinctively glanced at the wall clock. Exactly eleven.

Manish swept the room with a rapid look and greeted everyone at once in a friendly, informal tone. I noticed he seemed entirely at ease in Norton’s presence. The Agency, apparently, operated on more democratic instincts than one might expect.

Then Manish turned toward me.

“Ah! The famous Mac!” he exclaimed, striding over with a wide grin and extending his hand.

I stood, and we shook.

“Why ‘famous’?” I asked, genuinely puzzled.

“Oh, come on,” Manish smirked. “Didn’t Art tell you? From our perspective—the analysts—you’re the most interesting part of this whole story. I’m sure he figured that out—first of all. And second, he’s had more than enough time and opportunity to tell you so.”

I made a mental note that the analysts, Manish in particular, earned their keep.

“Would you mind,” he continued, still smiling but now studying me closely, “if we asked you to recall a few recent events under a scanner?”

“Under a scanner?” I repeated, wary.

Art answered for him.

“Don’t worry, nothing harmful,” Art said. “You’ll just need to sit under the stationary n2e scanner and recall, as precisely as possible...”

He paused for a brief moment—not searching for words, but clearly sorting through the sequence in his head.

“First, the moment you witnessed the Gate opening. Second, your encounter with the Black Jellyfish. And third... the thoughts and sensations that ultimately led us to the Wedding Cake.”

He glanced at Manish.

“Right?”

“Wedding Cake—that was the record nugget?” Manish said, more as confirmation than a question. “Right. And the picnic with the Reds.”

Art nodded, then turned back to me.

“The analysts can capture everything at maximum resolution that way and use it for further study. Of course, if you’re uncomfortable with it, they have no right to insist.”

“Of course I don’t mind,” I said quickly. “Not at all.”

Manish’s smile widened further, and he seemed almost to exhale in relief. He moved to one of the empty chairs and sat.

Only then did it dawn on me that everyone in the room had been patiently waiting for us to finish. I sat down as well and promised myself that from now on I would try to attract as little attention as possible.

I glanced around the room and noticed that everyone was looking not at Norton, as one might have expected, but at Ellen. She spoke first.

“One more thing before we begin the actual afterparty. Karina asked to be notified once we were all present. She’d like to say a few words.”

Ellen took her clip from the armrest, touched it lightly to her ear for a couple of seconds, then set it back in place. In that brief pause, I realized why she was leading the meeting. Formally, this was an afterparty—and that made Ellen its natural moderator, regardless of anyone’s position in the Agency hierarchy.

Beside Mona’s chair, a holographic image of another chair appeared. A woman in her mid-forties sat in it, wearing a business suit—loose-cut but elegant—unexpectedly paired with bright white athletic shoes. Dark skin, short hair touched with gray. She swept her gaze across the room.

“Hello, everyone. Sorry to interrupt—I’ll keep this brief. Mac, hi. I’m Karina. It’s a pleasure to meet you. If you’re ever in our wing, stop by—let’s chat.”

I smiled and immediately realized the smile felt slightly forced. I inclined my head.

“Thank you, Karina. I’m glad to meet you as well,” I replied, trying to sound natural and friendly.

I caught myself thinking that I was already growing tired of my sudden “popularity” and the constant attention. Fortunately, Karina—and then everyone else—shifted their focus to Mona.

“I just wanted to introduce Mona in her new role. We’ve created a special task force that will focus specifically on matters related to the Creatures and the Ninth Variant. Mona will be—has already been—appointed as its leader. In this capacity, she is authorized to act and make decisions on behalf of the entire ICDA and has been granted Level Nine clearance.”

Manish’s chair was directly opposite mine, so I couldn’t help noticing his eyebrows lift in surprise at Karina’s words.

“That’s all from me. I won’t take up any more of your time. Have a productive afterparty.”

Her hologram vanished.

All eyes returned to Ellen. Before doing the same, I glanced at Mona and noted how well she carried herself—calm, natural, without the slightest visible discomfort.

Ellen spoke in a low, steady voice, businesslike but setting a brisk pace.

“All right, let’s begin. We won’t go over the events of Art, Mac, and Kirsten’s picking in detail—you’re all familiar with them. So we can move straight to analysis. Manish?”

Manish, who had clearly been expecting this, nodded and began almost without pause, as though taking a baton from Ellen.

“I suggest we consider what happened during the picking in two contexts. The first—and most obvious—is the familiar context of our, shall we say,” he allowed himself a brief smile, “complicated relationship with the Reds.

“In that context, the picking was anomalous—particularly given the sharp increase in the volume of Essence formed. Aggression from the Reds around newly opened Gate across Variants has predictably escalated. During this period, there were seven attacks, three of which resulted in the theft of quint-boxes. One of those incidents involved your team, Ellen. You’ve already had your afterparty with them—did they report anything noteworthy?”

For a fleeting moment, I thought I detected the faintest hint of embarrassment in Ellen’s expression, but she answered in her usual composed tone.

“Yes. Four Reds ambushed Marisol and Tariq. They managed to fight them off, and two of the attackers were identified. However, Tariq was frozen, and his quint-box was taken.”

She paused briefly, as if organizing conclusions and next steps, then continued.

“They noted that the ambush was clearly premeditated—planned and executed professionally. And the key word here is professionally. Marisol also emphasized that all four attackers bore the mark of experience. The combination of those two factors—the level of preparation and the attackers’ evident skill—suggests to me that the Tribe was involved.”

Ellen gave a slight nod, indicating she had finished.

“We agree with that assessment,” Manish continued immediately. “Especially considering that the scenarios of most—if not all—of the other attacks show similar patterns.

“So, returning to our picking: within this first context, we can reasonably explain both the attack itself and the subsequent pursuit of the team.”

He paused.

“But there is another context. And it...”

Manish let the thought hang and looked at Norton. Norton nodded knowingly.

“I understand,” Norton said. He surveyed the room before continuing. “We’re referring to the emergence of the Ninth Variant and what followed. The nuance here is that information related to the Ninth Variant is classified at Level Seven. However, given the circumstances, I am authorizing disclosure of this information to everyone present—on the understanding that it remains confidential.”

He turned back to Manish.

“Please continue. You may present all facts you consider relevant.”

Manish nodded, the gesture conveying both satisfaction and polite acknowledgment, and continued.

“The sequence of events is as follows. Alongside the new—Ninth—Gate, a passage to a new, Ninth Variant appeared. We immediately noted that the threshold level for this Variant is nearly one hundred quints higher than for any of the others. That alone allowed us to assume that the Ninth Variant is, in some sense, distinct—not simply one among many, but situated on a different tier altogether.

“Of course, we would have taken every precaution in organizing the first crossing regardless. But the elevated threshold compelled us to treat the matter with particular care. I won’t dwell on the preparatory stages of the project. I’ll move directly to the main phase and its results.”

He spoke calmly, almost dryly.

“Eric’s team crossed into the new Variant, conducted local reconnaissance in the immediate vicinity of the Gate, collected environmental readings across all measurable parameters, and returned. You are familiar with the results. Based on the full body of data obtained, the new Variant appears to be the home world of the Creatures. At least in the region surrounding the Gate, numerous instances were recorded, while no signs whatsoever of human presence or activity were detected.”

Manish paused briefly. His expression shifted into something I hadn’t seen before—thoughtful, grave, almost stern.

“Now to the recent developments. The information classified at Level Seven.”

He continued.

“After processing the data from the first visit to the Ninth Variant, we began preparing a second team. That is when we encountered a problem. Both the striders selected for the second crossing and members of the first team reported experiencing the same influence that, throughout the history of the Gates, has affected those who attempted to study or investigate the Creatures.

“Moreover, as striders approach the Gate while the Ninth Variant lies beyond it, that influence increases exponentially, becoming literally unbearable. No one can approach closer than approximately ten meters. As in previous cases of this kind, no method of overcoming the effect—or even understanding its nature and mechanism—has been identified. That is our current status.”

Manish looked around the room, waiting for questions. None came.

“A broader discussion of the situation is not the purpose of this meeting,” he added, glancing at Mona. “We will return to it shortly. And, I understand, without delay.”

“Yes, of course, Manish,” Mona replied. “After this meeting, please come to our wing. Now—why do you consider this the second context of the picking?”

Manish nodded, clearly pleased, and answered without hesitation.

“Mac’s contour level.”

I flinched and glanced around almost defensively. As expected, everyone looked at me—but, to my relief, their attention quickly shifted back to Manish. Without masks, no one could see my contour. However, I realized, they didn’t need to. The number was already known.

“More precisely,” Manish continued, “not only the contour level, also the fact that Mac became a strider very recently. There have been no Storms in that region in the recent past. Therefore, his strider status must be the result of the Gate’s appearance.

“And returning to Mac’s contour level: the result is two hundred ninety-five quints. The threshold of the new passage fluctuates around two hundred seventy and has not yet exceeded two hundred ninety. In other words, Mac is one of the very few striders who can—” he paused slightly, correcting himself, “—or rather, until recently could, enter the Ninth Variant without amplification.”

He abruptly shifted.

“Incidentally, Mac, it would be extremely interesting to test how the Ninth passage responds to your proximity.”

“We can swing by the Gate right after this meeting. Right, Mac?” Art interjected immediately.

“Of course,” I replied, looking first at Art, then at Manish.

Manish broke into a wide smile, then glanced at Norton, awaiting his reaction. Norton gave a short nod.

“Excellent,” Manish said, turning back to us. “There’s no need to attempt entry. Simply approach as closely as possible and report your sensations.”

Art and I nodded in unison. Manish inclined his head slightly as well, then paused for a moment, gathering his thoughts before continuing.

“So, returning to the picking. More specifically—to your encounter with the three Reds. With a high degree of confidence, we can assume they either entered the Eighth Variant through the new Gate or, if already present at the time of its emergence, at least witnessed it. That means they could have noted the threshold level of the new passage.

“And then, seeing Mac—observing his contour level and learning that he became a strider only recently—they could have connected the dots.”

Manish narrowed his eyes slightly.

“I’m speaking about all three of them,” he said. “But I’m primarily referring to one.”

Out of the corner of my eye, I noticed Art nodding briskly, as if he had been expecting this.

“Ion,” Art said with certainty.

Manish smiled, almost with relish.

“Exactly,” he confirmed. “I’m curious—what made you single him out?”

“Pure intuition,” Art replied. “That entire evening I couldn’t shake the feeling that something about him was... off. And I don’t mean his odd behavior. It was more like a sense of a second layer—like he wasn’t at all who he was trying to appear to be.”

Manish nodded approvingly.

“Your intuition served you well. That man—let’s call him Ion, if that’s the name he prefers—is quite well known to us.”

“Illegal?” Ellen asked quietly, almost to herself, her tone more declarative than questioning.

“Not exactly,” Manish turned to her. “We’ve never been able to establish a direct link between him and any specific crime. However, he has—far too often to be coincidence—been nearby. But what’s more interesting is his background.”

Manish leaned forward slightly.

“In the past, he was a rising—indeed, already risen—star in neurocoding. An exceptional designer of e2n devices. A figure of global stature. The e2n interfaces he created more than a decade ago are still considered classics in the field. At the time of their release, they were nothing short of a breakthrough—pushing neurocoding technology to an entirely new level.”

He cleared his throat. A mech, similar to Estri but more compact, detached itself almost silently from the wall, approached him, and offered a glass of water on a small tray. Manish took a sip, nodded in dismissal, and continued.

“Everything changed when he—like others, quite by accident—became a strider. Almost immediately he abandoned his work—he had no family—developed a dependency on quinta, and joined the Reds. And, as I mentioned earlier, since then he has surfaced repeatedly in our field of attention—not so much in connection with attacks or stolen quint-boxes, but through black-market quinta operations.”

Manish paused briefly.

“I assume you’ve already guessed: we suspect ties to the Tribe. More than that, we believe he occupies a position there far from ordinary. Most likely Ion is a Gamma. Possibly a Beta. We do not even entirely exclude the possibility that he is the Alpha—though we assess that probability as low.”

He took another sip of water.

“Given this, in the second context we consider the following scenario. Ion notices Mac’s contour level, recalls the threshold of the Ninth Variant, and decides...” Manish allowed himself the faintest smile, “...let’s call it recruitment into the Tribe. Naturally, using the instrument he knows best—neurocoding. Specifically, freeze—to begin with.”

I noted that “to begin with” and imagined how events might have unfolded had that hypothetical plan succeeded. A chill ran through me.

“That,” Manish concluded, “is the analytical portion we consider appropriate to present. If there are no questions or comments, we can move from analysis to synthesis—meaning the planning of next steps.”

He paused. None came.

“Planning primarily concerns Mac,” Manish continued. “We consider it obvious—” he turned toward me, “—Mac, forgive the bluntness, but we consider it obvious that you are an object of heightened interest. Not only to us—meaning ARC and ICDA—but also to the Tribe. Therefore, given—again, forgive me—your limited strider experience and lack of formal preparation, we would recommend that you refrain, for the time being, from traveling to other Variants. And in general—exercise heightened caution. At least until you complete the standard training program.”

He hesitated.

“Longer term... I would propose two scenarios. The first is to continue along that line: prioritize your safety and refrain from assigning you standard strider operations. The second...” Manish paused. “Though we could reasonably limit ourselves to the first.”

“What’s the second scenario, Manish?” I asked, making a deliberate effort—and, I believe, succeeding—to keep my tone steady.

He seemed to hesitate, then shrugged slightly and answered:

"If the Tribe is attempting to reach you, we could use that to attempt to reach the Tribe."

I let a brief silence pass, so my next words wouldn't sound reckless.

"I vote for the second option."

Manish smiled faintly. There was approval in that smile—but also, I sensed, a hint of indulgence.

"And there are at least two reasons for that," I continued. "Information and initiative."

The indulgence on Manish's face shifted into amused surprise.

"First," I said, "we are currently operating under uncertainty. We lack sufficient information for confident decision-making. In fact, from what you've just said, our... opponents appear to have more information than we do. They clearly know something we don't. Under those conditions, it's logical to try to reduce that imbalance."

I looked at Manish. He responded immediately.

"Agreed. Go on."

"Second," I said, "the initiative currently belongs to the Reds. And that is bad in any scenario. If we limit ourselves to defense and wait for developments, we will have no opportunity to seize it."

A silence settled over the room. I deliberately avoided looking around, but I had the distinct feeling that Art was watching me with quiet approval.

Manish spoke first.

"Mac, listen... if you ever get tired of hauling Essence boxes to the vault, stop by our department. I'm sure we can find you something more intellectually stimulating."

Laughter rippled around the room. The tension that had been hanging in the air dissolved.

Then Norton's calm voice cut in.

"On the whole, I agree with Manish's proposal—and with Mac's reasoning. Mac, under our regulations you wouldn't be sent on a picking in any case until you've completed the standard training program. That part is not up for debate. Finish all required downloads and at least one honing session for each skill. After that comes the final stage: internship. In other words, a standard picking conducted alongside—and under the supervision of—an experienced picker."

He turned to Ellen.

"Ellen, let's design that picking so that, from the outside, it looks entirely routine. But if there's an attack—or any other Reds' activity—your entire team, along with the AIO unit, must be able to respond instantly. I'm making a formal decision here: during this picking, delivery of the boxes to the vault drops to second priority. First priority is protection of every team member and, in the event of an attack, taking all possible measures to identify, detain, and transport the attackers to our Variant. Come by my office later—we'll go over the details."

Ellen nodded, focused and composed.

Norton shifted his gaze to Manish.

"What else?" he asked evenly.

I made a mental note to do something the moment I had the chance to put my mask back on.

Manish looked thoughtful.

“So that we don’t waste time,” he began reluctantly, “I would suggest that Mac and Art try to arrange a meeting with Zara.”

I flinched before I could stop myself and immediately forced my expression back under control. It wasn’t easy. Manish continued.

“We consider Zara’s connection to the Pride unlikely. She’s originally from the Fourth Variant,” he paused meaningfully, “and when she became a strider about four years ago, she almost immediately applied for naturalization with the Alpida Forum. As usual in such cases, the Forum consulted us, and we approved the request. You know our policy—we do everything we can to ensure that neutral striders remain, at the very least, neutral. So we support their naturalization here or in other open Variants.”

He spread his hands slightly.

“She was granted naturalization, and since then, as far as we can tell, she’s behaved like someone who has nothing to fear—from the Forum or from ARC. So if Art, or Mac, or both of them meet Zara here, in our Variant, in a public place, I see no security risk for Mac and no contradiction with what we agreed on earlier.”

I managed to steady myself somewhat, though my heart was still racing. The idea that I would use Zara’s permission to contact her merely to resolve some official matter felt almost monstrous.

I looked at Art and met his eyes. He gave me the faintest smile and a slight nod. I had the sense that he understood without my having to say a word.

“I can reach out to her and suggest we meet,” Art said. “Our conversation that morning was completely normal—we exchanged net IDs and...” He hesitated just a fraction. “...agreed we might call each other sometime. I don’t think she’ll be surprised by a call from me—or by an invitation to meet. We could have dinner somewhere. All of us. Zara, Mona, Mac and I.”

I glanced involuntarily at Mona and caught the grateful look she cast toward Art.

I looked at Art again. This time he was watching Norton, waiting for his reaction. I shifted my gaze to the Director of ARC as well.

“I have no objections,” Norton said succinctly.

“Excellent,” Manish concluded, a faintly mischievous smile playing at the corners of his mouth. “And if anything interesting happens to surface during your... friendly dinner, I trust you’ll share it with me.”

He paused, his expression turning serious again, then cast a meaningful glance at Mona.

“And finally, one last point.”

Mona nodded, understanding, and addressed Norton.

“The Creatures. And their anomalous activity during this picking. I assume this, too, is somehow connected to Mac and the level of his contour. Which means we may well see developments on that front as well.”

“What would you require from my side?” Norton asked.

Mona hesitated briefly, choosing her words.

“I think there may be a situation in which Mac or Art will need to act... not entirely in accordance with ARC’s rules and procedures.” She paused. “Simply because no set of rules can anticipate everything in advance. And the current situation—especially with the Ninth Variant—is far from standard.”

Norton nodded.

“Agreed. Art, Mac: should a critical necessity arise in connection with the crisis surrounding the Ninth Variant, I authorize you to act in accordance with the demands of the moment—even if that entails deviating from ARC protocols and procedures.

“That said,” he added calmly, “I expect you to make every effort to minimize such deviations.”

Art and I exchanged a glance, then looked back at Norton and nodded in silence.

Norton turned to Ellen. As if anticipating the cue, she addressed the room.

“On that note, I believe we can consider the afterparty concluded. Thank you all for a productive discussion.”

Everyone rose, retrieving their masks and clips from the armrest slots and putting them back on. I remembered what I had intended to do the moment I had my mask on again.

I turned to Art and quietly asked him to enable the Essence layer. He complied at once. I looked at Norton.

As expected.

Norton’s contour stood out clearly against the baseline Essence. Just as I had suspected, he was a strider. I glanced around the room. The only non-striders present were Mona and Manish.

At that moment Mona, taking Manish by the arm as they headed toward the exit, was saying, “Come to our wing—we’ll go over everything there. I think Karina will want to join us as well.”

Norton and Ellen were already moving toward the door.

I looked at Art.

“First stop—the Gate,” he said briskly. “I’m curious myself how the Ninth Variant will react to us.”

I nodded, a surge of anticipation rising in me.

And Art and I headed out as well.

Chapter 21. Settling In

We boarded Big Tom. The cabin had reverted to two seats again, both facing forward. The moment we settled in and the soft safety vests closed around us, Tom lifted smoothly off the platform and began gaining speed and altitude.

I hadn't yet visited these mountains—I mean, back there, in my world. So now, taking them in, I couldn't help but admire their majestic,—lavish, I would say—beauty. I found myself thinking that the First Ones—or whoever it was that had created the Gates—had not chosen these mountains by chance for the very first one.

Below us, the folds of the slopes drifted past, cloud shadows sliding across them. Thin lines of trails, barely visible from this height, formed intricate patterns. Off to one side, a river shimmered, splitting into sunlit branches. On the other, bands of forest climbed the slopes, and above them rose monumental, primordial cliffs.

The flight was swift yet soothingly smooth, without any noticeable maneuvers or shifts in speed. Tom wasn't flying so much as gliding, as if deliberately presenting the passing scenery on a vast panoramic screen that surrounded us on all sides.

In the distance, the ghostlike arch of the Gate emerged and began drawing closer with steady inevitability. Studying it, I thought that the Gate did not quite harmonize with the surrounding landscape—yet neither did it clash with it. It was like an avant-garde element introduced into a classical painting. And the painting still remained a masterpiece.

As we approached, Tom descended and settled gently onto a level stretch of ground nearby.

We stepped outside.

The air was cool and astonishingly clear. A light breeze carried the scent of grass and flowers not yet scorched by the sun, with a faint undertone of damp stone. I took a deep breath and realized that I was breathing differently here—slower, deeper, calmer.

The mountains surrounded us on all sides, yet they did not press in. On the contrary, they created a sense of space and stability, as if here, of all places, everything stood exactly where it belonged.

I glanced at Art.

"Well then," he said, "let's see how the Ninth Variant reacts to us—or rather, to you."

I nodded silently and stepped forward.

A designation appeared against the surface of the Gate, indicating the Variant beyond it. For now—V3.

I registered it automatically, the way one notes the number on a door one has no intention of opening. Art and I exchanged a look and began moving forward slowly, unhurriedly.

The image within the Gate was blurred, slightly out of focus. At one point it seemed to tremble—not sharply, but the way a vast bowl of water might quiver if lightly disturbed. Then the image grew murkier, and finally it seemed to drift, flowing into something else. Similar—and yet not the same.

The designation shifted.

V9.

In the same instant, it felt as though something shoved me in the face. Not struck—shoved. Abruptly and without warning. I stumbled back a step, and Art did the same. Almost immediately a wave rolled over us—dense, viscous, profoundly hostile.

It wasn't pain in the usual sense. It was something even worse.

I suddenly remembered with startling clarity the time I had once been gravely ill: high fever, mental fog, the sense that even existing required effort. Back then, I had thought it couldn't possibly get worse.

It could. Far worse. By an order of magnitude. Immeasurably worse.

With every second spent near the Gate, the sensation intensified—pressing from within, twisting thought, stripping away any sense of footing. The only thing that brought even the slightest relief was stepping back. One step away from the Gate, and the pressure eased. Another—and it became marginally more bearable.

We retreated almost at a run, as if fleeing an invisible wave crashing toward us. Or escaping a zone where space itself had turned against us. I barely understood where I was anymore; I simply followed the instinct to move—back, away, farther.

We practically stumbled into Big Tom. The hatch sealed, the vests closed—and at Art's silent command, Tom launched.

The pressure began to recede at once, even before we had gained altitude. After a few seconds it was merely awful. A few more—tolerable. And then there remained only heavy breathing and the sticky, lingering sense that we had approached something we had no business approaching.

Tom carried us rapidly away from the Gate.

And I was profoundly grateful to him for it.

He flew fast and steady, as though he too were eager to increase the distance between us and the Gate. Within minutes, to my astonishment, there was no trace left of that horror. No weakness, no clouded mind, no echo of the pressure—as if nothing had happened at all. Only the memory of it, far too vivid to dismiss as imagination.

I drew several slow breaths.

Everything seemed to be back in order.

Art turned toward me in his seat, studied me carefully, and nodded—more to himself than to me.

"Well," he said calmly, "that was to be expected. Judging by the reaction, the Ninth Variant affects you exactly the same way it affects everyone else. No worse. No better."

And in that moment I felt an unexpected sense of relief. Strange. Almost embarrassing. As if something inside me, clenched in anticipation, had finally let go.

I must have been afraid, I realized. Afraid that at some time I would find myself alone with the Ninth Variant. That it would turn out to be my problem—and mine alone. But that hadn't happened. The Ninth Variant remained a shared frontier, not a personal trial.

"I sent Manish a brief report," Art went on. "No details, just the essentials. That should be enough for him."

He fell silent for a couple of seconds, then gave a faint smile.

"That means we can consider this item closed. And therefore..." He looked at me. "We can finally take care of your arrangements."

I nodded.

"And to begin with," Art continued with slightly theatrical enthusiasm, "you need to pay Thomas a visit. He's our chief authority on all matters domestic."

Big Tom was already descending toward the Trillium parking platform.

When we stopped in front of a door that read:

Thomas

Head of Personnel Affairs

and below, in smaller print:

"It's always better to walk in than stand outside wondering."

—Thomas

Art paused and gave me a conspiratorial look.

"Listen, Mac, you don't need me for this meeting," he said. "Go in on your own. I'll be around. Let me know when you're done."

I was a little surprised, but I didn't ask questions. I nodded and stepped inside.

Behind a curved standing desk, focused on a monitor, stood a man about my age. He was extremely tall—well over two meters—and broad and thickset, yet the build suited his open, friendly face perfectly. He looked up at me, and his expression instantly lit up with unrestrained delight, accompanied by a radiant smile.

"Mac!" he exclaimed. "Finally! I've been waiting and waiting. I thought you weren't coming today!"

Instinctively, I glanced over my shoulder, half expecting to see another Mac—an old and dear friend of Thomas's—standing behind me. But there was no one there.

By then Thomas was already striding toward me, extending his hand and simultaneously gesturing with the other.

"Come on in, don't just stand there."

He shook my hand firmly, clapped me on the shoulder, and steered me back toward the desk.

"Where's Art?" he suddenly asked. "I thought he'd come in with you. You know he pulled a disgraceful stunt—started calling his glider 'Big Tom.' Imagine that. Tom is me, just so we're clear. And he tells everyone. I hope he didn't tell you?"

I averted my eyes and gave a noncommittal shrug.

"Aha," Thomas muttered to himself, "so he's persisting in this outrageous behavior. Then it's his good fortune he didn't come in. Because I would've thrown..." He scanned the desk. "...this clip at him. No—this terminal. You tell him that."

I looked into his eyes and saw the playful spark there. He was grinning broadly.

I understood the local conversational etiquette.

"That's exactly why he didn't come in," I said. "He's terrified of being hit in the forehead with a terminal. He's hiding out in the corridor right now. Behind a palm tree."

We both laughed.

We remained standing at the curved desk—more side by side than opposite each other—and Thomas, still smiling but noticeably more focused now, said:

"All right. Jokes aside, let's get to business. First—formalities. However you look at it, you're an arrival from another Variant, so naturalization is unavoidable."

He glanced over my shoulder.

"It's simple and quick. Don't worry."

I turned.

A matte-gray mech was approaching us. Its appearance contrasted sharply with the relaxed atmosphere of Thomas's office: severe lines, no decorative elements, movements precise and economical. On its front panel was an intricate emblem encircled by the inscription:

Continental Forum of Alpida

"Official representative of the Forum," Thomas explained. "You just need to answer three formal questions."

The mech stopped in front of me.

"The naturalization procedure is commencing," it said in an even, impersonal voice. "Please answer three questions. The answers must be unequivocal."

I nodded.

"Do you have the desire, intention, and interest to become a full legal resident of the Continent of Alpida?"

"Yes," I answered without hesitation.

"Is there anything that, in your opinion, prevents you from becoming a full legal resident of the Continent of Alpida?"

"No."

"Do you undertake to respect the rights and lawful interests of the residents of the Continent of Alpida—collectively and individually?"

"Yes."

The mech paused briefly.

"DNA scan in progress."

A thin blue holographic ring appeared in the air above me. It began to descend slowly, passing through my body as if carefully and unhurriedly examining me from every angle. I felt nothing—aside from a faint, almost ticklish awareness of its presence, which was probably nothing more than suggestion.

The ring reached the floor, stayed there for a second—and vanished.

"DNA scan complete," the mech announced. "From this moment forward, you are a full legal resident of the Continent of Alpida. Congratulations."

It turned and moved toward the exit just as silently as it had arrived.

"Well then, that takes care of the Forum," Thomas said, watching it go. "Now one more formality."

A document appeared in my mask, headed:

Agency for the Regulation of Quintessence

Employee Code

I read it carefully. I won't recount its contents—they're confidential—but I noted to myself that the Code struck me as logical and, in a way, reassuring. There were no grandiose declarations, no attempts to shift responsibility onto abstract phrasing. Everything was clear, precise, and to the point.

I signed it mentally. The document disappeared at once.

Thomas rubbed his hands together with visible enthusiasm.

"Excellent," he said. "All formalities complete. Now we can move on to the pleasant part."

His eyes darted behind the lenses of his mask as he worked with an interface invisible to me.

"All right. A bank account has been opened for you," he said in a casual tone, as if discussing something entirely routine. "I've transferred what we call the employee initial package: a setup allocation plus your first month's salary. Altogether—roughly the equivalent of six months' standard pay."

He looked at me questioningly, then waved a hand.

"It may not sound like much, but honestly, you're unlikely to need even that anytime soon. Housing, transportation, communications, everyday expenses—they're all included in the strider package and automatically covered. So you'll be more than fine." He gave me a wry smile. "Unless, of course, you're planning to buy a flying yacht."

"Not at the moment," I said, unable to suppress a smile.

"Good," he nodded—then, suddenly contradicting himself, added, "Though honestly, they're not as outrageously expensive as you'd think. I just bought a decent, reasonably priced model myself—installments, admittedly, but I'll have it paid off soon. If you ever decide to get a hover, consult me first. I'll help you choose something worthwhile. There are all sorts of nuances. Climate control, for example. I know people who flew theirs down to Antarctica on vacation and ended up sleeping in their clothes because some of the cabins were cold there. Can you imagine?"

I shook my head solemnly.

"Yes, yes," Thomas confirmed enthusiastically—then cut himself off. "But we're getting sidetracked."

He ran me through the remaining elements of the strider package: insurance—"for absolutely everything," as he put it—medical support, legal protection, and several other provisions. As he spoke, I felt a growing sense that the world around me had suddenly become far more stable, reliable, predictable. Not richer. Not more luxurious. Just... safer.

"Oh—and one more thing," Thomas remembered. "You've already been assigned a net ID. So if anyone needs to reach you, there won't be any issues."

I nodded—and immediately caught myself thinking of Zara.

"You'll have no trouble with the terminal," Thomas continued. "After the first download, you'll know and understand everything."

He lowered his gaze thoughtfully and fell silent for a moment, as if mentally reviewing whether he had forgotten anything. Then he looked up at me again, broke into a wide smile, and spread his hands.

"That should be everything. If you don't mind, I'll hand you over to the team handling your first download."

"Of course," I said. "I'm ready."

Thomas smiled, stepped out from behind the desk, and gestured invitingly toward the door.

Chapter 22. Download

When Thomas and I stepped into the corridor, a notification immediately appeared in my mask: two new messages.

The first was from Art.

From: Art

To: Mac

Subject: This evening

Mac, I figured you'll be wiped after the download tonight, so I won't bug you.

Message me in the morning when you wake up—I'll swing by. It's a seven-minute flight to your place.

And if anything changes, call.

Have a good download.

Say hi to Ian and his crew for me.

Below the text, along with an empty reply field, were three preset options:

Thanks, Confirmed, and simply OK.

I chose the last one. The message vanished.

The second opened immediately—this one from Manish.

From: Manish

To: Mac

Subject: Episodes for scanning

Hi Mac,

Just to clarify the episodes for the scan.

First—the appearance of the Gate. It technically began at 5:47, but let's start from the moment you woke up. From there, proceed as you see fit.

Second—the encounter with the Reds. Everything you can recall.

Third—anything connected to the Black Jellyfish.

Fourth—from the moment you felt the urge to head toward the location of the nugget until the moment you saw it.

According to protocol, the neurocoders must not know the content of the information they are scanning. At this stage, they only know there will be four episodes and will refer to them by number only.

Many thanks in advance.

And good luck with your first download.

I closed the message and only then realized that Thomas had been talking the entire time.

"Sorry," I said. "Got distracted by messages. Art and Manish."

I gave him a quick summary.

“Ah, no problem,” Thomas waved it off. “Honestly, I wasn’t saying anything important. And yes”—he grinned—“after the download, you probably won’t feel like talking to anyone. So Art planned that correctly.”

We were walking down the main corridor of the Trillium. It was as spacious and bright as ever: fountains murmured softly between islands of greenery, and along the walls enormous three-dimensional landscapes shifted one into another—mountains, forests, coastlines—like fragments of reality carefully inserted into the architecture.

Soon we turned into a side corridor. Above the entrance, a soft holographic sign glowed:

Neurocoding Center

We passed several doors labeled simply:

Section 1, Section 2,

and entered the one marked:

Section 3

Inside, the room was empty. It looked more like a research laboratory than a medical facility: subdued lighting, matte surfaces, equipment. The equipment, in particular, was impressive.

“The team will be here in a minute,” Thomas said. “Their schedule runs down to the minute.”

He turned to me and extended his hand.

“Good session, Mac. Don’t rush. Just follow their instructions. And...” He paused briefly. “Trust the process.”

I nodded.

Thomas left. The door closed softly behind him, and I found myself alone.

I looked around.

Near the far wall, almost at the center, stood a large, soft reclining chair surrounded by a ring of neurocoding equipment. It reminded me of MRI or CT machines back in my world—but this one looked far more... integrated. No sharp edges, no aggressive geometry—only smooth arcs and streamlined modules, as if the entire structure had been conceived not as a machine but as an extension of the human body. Matte metal blended with translucent elements through which layered internal structures could be glimpsed—but not individual components. The whole apparatus conveyed complexity, expense, and—unexpectedly—a sense of care.

Facing the main chair was a lighter, wheeled seat clearly intended for an operator.

Closer to the center of the room, embedded directly in the floor, were two circular platforms of frosted glass, each about two meters in diameter. For some reason they reminded me of small club stages—though here, instead of microphones, several holographic monitors hovered in the air near each circle, currently displaying abstract idle visuals.

Closer to the entrance, along the walls, stood three small desks with light chairs behind them, while nearer the center there was a round table with three compact seats. I modestly pulled one back and sat down, trying not to look like someone who had no idea where to put himself.

At that moment the door opened, and three people entered.

The first stepped in briskly—a middle-aged man who looked unusually young, or perhaps a young man who seemed older because of the assuredness of his movements. His bright orange hair, cut in a short bristle style, reinforced that deliberate youthfulness.

Behind him came a petite, pleasant-looking young woman with short hair, a graceful figure, and facial features hinting at East Asian heritage.

Bringing up the rear was a dark-skinned young man with short, dense black hair and an attentive, slightly thoughtful gaze.

All three were dressed in identical light-blue, medical-style suits. On the left side of each chest was what appeared to be an ID badge, though I didn't have time to make out the details.

"Ah, Mac—you're already here! Hi!" exclaimed the orange-haired guy. "I'm Ian. And this"—he gestured lightly—"is Polina and Kofi."

He gave me a quick glance, then looked at the chair I was sitting in and smirked.

"You picked the wrong seat. Yours is that one."

He pointed to the large chair surrounded by equipment.

We exchanged handshakes and smiles. Polina and Kofi, without unnecessary words, immediately took their places by the holographic monitors—Polina at one of the circular platforms, Kofi at the other.

Above the frosted glass circles, identical three-dimensional startup screens flared to life, bearing what was evidently the manufacturer's logo. The monitors suspended around each circle awakened as well—lines of numbers, indices, and brief strings of text began streaming across them. Polina and Kofi scrolled through them with practiced gestures, flicking data aside, collapsing windows into icons, expanding others.

I managed to catch only fragments—and occasionally the word "Testing..." appearing among the scrolling lines, followed almost immediately by a brief "OK."

Sections of the equipment around the main chair began glowing softly—blue, silver, pale green. The light moved from module to module as if the system were checking itself along a familiar route. Everything looked calm, calibrated, and reassuringly competent.

I crossed the room hesitantly and sat in the "main" chair. It proved unexpectedly comfortable—soft enough to support the body, but not so soft as to let it fully relax.

Ian rolled up in the light wheeled operator's chair and settled in front of me. Almost immediately, a light-blue mech in matching "uniform" colors appeared at his side, holding a small tray in one manipulator. On the tray stood a fairly large glass filled with something that looked like coffee with milk.

"To start with, please drink this," Ian said. "It's a recovery formula—an optimized nutrient blend designed for maximum absorption and focused on restoring brain tissue and the nervous system. Any e2n intervention puts serious strain on all that, and you'll need energy and nutrients to recover."

As he spoke about nutrients, I suddenly realized how hungry I'd become. I took the glass from the tray and tasted the drink. It was thick and pleasantly vanilla-flavored. I finished it and returned the empty glass to the mech, which withdrew at once. Watching it leave, I was surprised to feel my hunger evaporate almost instantly. I would even say it vanished—like someone had flipped a switch inside me.

Ian, who had been observing me closely, nodded with satisfaction. Then his face shifted into exaggerated melancholy.

"Well then," he said sadly, "on to the formalities. The official introduction."

Above the "stage" monitor to my right, a three-dimensional image of Ian flared into existence. He was seated in a chair, leaning elegantly on the armrest and smiling. He looked as though he were posing for an official portrait—just slightly overdoing it.

Above the second monitor, another display appeared. At the top was a complex emblem—I recognized the contours of the symbol I had seen on the drone in Thomas's office, but here it had been softened with

rounded elements and additional symbols clearly associated with healthcare. The logo managed to look both official and reassuring.

Below it appeared text:

Continental Forum of Alpida

Department of Health

Licensed Specialist Profile

Field: Neurocoding

Name: Ian

License Number: 697-439-125

License Status: Active

Neurocoding Clearances:

n2e — up to Level 12 inclusive

e2n — up to Level 12 inclusive

Years of Practice: 14

Current Workplace: Neurocoding Center, Agency for the Regulation of Quintessence

Sessions Conducted: 3,632

Of which:

— without remarks: 3,629

— with remarks: 3, of which critical: 0

I scanned the lines and looked back at Ian. He wore a caricatured expression of guilt.

“Mac, you mustn’t pay attention to the number ‘three,’” he said with theatrical resignation. “In the first case, for example, I got distracted and accidentally transmitted the entire World Forum library to a client. He became a genius.”

“Mac, that’s his standard joke. Don’t mind him,” Polina commented calmly without looking up from her monitor.

Ian shot her a mock-wary glance, turned back to me, and lowered his voice conspiratorially.

“In the second case, the client was a very attractive woman, and I accidentally—emphasis on accidentally—transmitted my net ID to her.”

“I believe I’ve heard that one before as well,” Polina murmured to herself, still working.

Ian leaned closer to me and continued in the same conspiratorial tone.

“And in the third case—quite the opposite. I... got slightly distracted by my own memories and transmitted information about a former girlfriend. Specifically... about her preferred positions.”

“Now that’s a new one,” Polina said, raising an eyebrow slightly—without taking her eyes off the screen.

“Right,” Ian concluded, straightening up and casting Polina one last quick glance, “that’s enough about me. Now—about them.”

Above the two other monitors, images of Polina and Kofi appeared, accompanied by their professional credentials. I noted that Polina had eight years of experience, Kofi seven. Like Ian, neither of them had a single session with critical remarks.

They gave me some time to review the profiles. Then the display changed.

A new line of text appeared:

Do you consent to undergoing a neurocoding session conducted by this team?

Yes No

Without hesitation, I selected “Yes.”

“Thank you for your trust, Mac,” Ian said with a smile. “We won’t let you down.”

Polina smiled and nodded at me. Even Kofi briefly surfaced from behind his monitors, gave a friendly wave, and immediately returned to work.

“Stage one—baseline scan,” Ian continued, now in a businesslike tone. “We need to determine the individual characteristics of your brain and nervous system—susceptibility, reactivity, and a few other nuances. Please, remove your mask and clip—they’ll interfere. You can place them here on the stand. Then just lean back and relax.”

I did exactly that.

The equipment around me seemed to come alive. Several glowing rings of different hues passed over my body—from head to toe and back again—followed by a constellation of thin, precise beams. They moved quickly and methodically, lingering around my head as if examining it in detail.

Suddenly, two images appeared on the volumetric displays before me. On the right—myself, nearly life-sized, with a delicate lattice of silver threads visible within me: my nervous system. On the left—a magnified, almost unsettlingly large image of a brain, which I understood to be my own. Different regions lit up in shifting colors, the illumination constantly changing as if reflecting various scan parameters and modes.

Polina and Kofi immediately focused. They touched specific areas of the images, pulling them closer; sections enlarged, revealing deeper layers of detail. They examined the projections carefully, occasionally annotating side monitors with swift gestures. Meanwhile, Ian leaned back slightly in his chair, observing their work. I realized they were conducting an intense discussion—wordlessly, through their interfaces.

As if overhearing my thoughts, Ian turned toward me with an apologetic smile.

“Sorry, Mac. I know you’re probably bored out of your mind, but we need just another couple of minutes to run through the pre-session checklist.”

I hurried to assure him that I wasn’t bored at all and that they should take whatever time they needed.

Ian gave me a thumbs-up and turned back to his team.

True to his word, only a few minutes passed before he nodded to Polina and Kofi and rotated his chair toward me.

“Overall, everything looks good. There are a few interesting individual traits, but nothing that should interfere with coding or cause complications. So—we’re moving on to the main phase. We’ll start with n2e. Manish asked us to scan your memories of four episodes. Don’t be alarmed—we’re going to fit you with a sort of ‘cap.’ It keeps the active modules as close to the brain as possible and optimizes the neural exchange.”

I felt soft panels extend from the headrest of the chair. They slid forward and gently enclosed my head, much like the safety vest in Big Tom's cabin—except this material pressed snugly into place, holding my head completely still.

Ian examined the fit from several angles and nodded, satisfied.

"Scanning episode one. Ready?"

I "nodded" with my eyes.

"Excellent. Begin."

I focused on recalling, in as much detail as possible, the morning I witnessed the appearance of the new Gate. The memories surfaced easily and vividly. I even noticed, in passing, that alongside the scan my brain seemed to be undergoing some kind of subtle, toning stimulation.

I carried the memory through to the moment I returned home, collapsed onto the bed, and fell asleep.

"Done," I said.

"Good," Ian replied encouragingly. "Readings look excellent. We're moving at a great pace. Episode two. Ready?"

I "nodded" again.

"Begin."

One by one, we moved through all four episodes Manish had specified. When the last one was complete, Ian said:

"That concludes the n2e phase. We're transitioning to e2n coding. To prevent discomfort, we'll place you under sleep. The entire session will take approximately an hour to an hour and a half. Any questions or objections?"

"No, all good. Let's begin," I said.

"Good," Ian said. "Beginning."

A wave of drowsiness swept over me almost instantly, and I dropped into sleep.

I woke, it seemed, only seconds later.

The chair in front of me was empty. Ian was standing beside Polina, working with her intently on the image of my brain. Kofi was studying the neural map, occasionally touching specific sections and lingering there, as if verifying something critical. Both the brain and the nervous system now looked almost alive: their fragments shimmered through shifting bands of color, flowing smoothly from one shade to another.

Almost as soon as I opened my eyes, Ian noticed. He returned to the chair in front of me. As if on cue, the "cap" around my head gently released and retracted back into the headrest.

"How are you feeling, Mac?"

I tried to answer—and couldn't.

The attempt to form even a single coherent thought collapsed before it began. My head felt utterly relaxed, hollow, drained. It was like nausea—but in thought. Or like trying to stretch a rubber band that had long since lost its elasticity and sagged uselessly. Concentration felt nearly impossible.

Still, I forced myself, with immense effort, to produce:

"All... good..."

The words came out clearly. My tongue wasn't thick. My body felt neither weak nor numb. Only my thoughts were fragile.

Ian nodded knowingly.

"Kofi will take you home now. I expect you'll be able to get out of the chair and lie down once you're there. After that, he'll put you back to sleep. A medical mech will monitor you overnight. And tomorrow—trust me—you'll feel fresh as a cucumber."

I couldn't gather enough focus to respond.

Ian smiled at me, then glanced toward Kofi. Kofi stepped away from the monitor and approached.

The chair beneath me rose smoothly into the air, unfolding at the same time into something resembling a recliner. It drifted toward the door as it opened and glided out into the corridor. Kofi walked slightly ahead and to the side, occasionally glancing back at me with a sharp, professional eye.

In this manner we exited the Trillium building and emerged onto the parking platform. A small glider with a wide side door already slid open approached us. The chair floated inside and settled gently onto the cabin floor.

Only then did I notice that the light-blue mech—the same one that had served me the recovery formula—had followed us. A Department of Health insignia was visible on its side. The mech glided into the cabin after my chair and lowered itself beside me. Kofi took the pilot's seat, facing me. The door closed, and the glider slipped smoothly forward.

Within minutes we landed outside my cottage, and the same quiet procession carried us into the bedroom. My condition was indeed improving gradually, though concentrating was still difficult.

I stood from the reclining chair and lay down on the bed—surprisingly soft, yet resilient.

The mech hovered beside it, as if taking up its watch.

"Thank you," I said to Kofi.

It came out clearly enough.

He smiled.

"You're welcome, Mac. Congratulations on your first download. Get some rest."

They were the first words I had heard him speak.

Kofi took a small device from the pocket of his medical jacket and briefly touched it to my forehead. Drowsiness rolled over me once more—

and I was asleep.

Chapter 23. Awakening

I opened my eyes, and the first thing I saw was the light-blue mech hovering directly above the bed.

It reacted instantly. A familiar holographic ring appeared in the air—this time milky white. The ring descended slowly from my head to my feet, as if carefully and unhurriedly assessing my condition. When the scan was complete, the mech, without saying a word, turned with professional efficiency and headed toward the door.

I “automatically” issued a mental command to open it.

The door opened, the mech glided out, and the door closed behind it.

Only then did I realize.

Wait.

I wasn’t wearing the clip.

Which meant I couldn’t possibly have opened the door with a mental command.

But... I had issued the command, hadn’t I? Yes, the command was there. It simply hadn’t executed—the mech had opened the door. Still, I had definitely formed the command.

I froze, sitting on the edge of the bed.

So... I can already do this?

And then I fully woke up.

Of course. Operating the mask, the clip, and all n2e interfaces—that was part of yesterday’s download.

I jumped to my feet and scanned the room for the mask and clip. They were lying neatly on the bedside table—of course Kofi had made sure I would see them immediately. I put them on.

For a brief moment, it felt as though they weren’t mine, but some other devices entirely. But no—they were the same mask and clip.

They hadn’t changed.

The world had.

The space around me seemed to come alive. The room filled with objects, sounds, variations of light, scents—and even... the emotions those scents and sounds evoked.

The room was no longer bright simply because daylight streamed through the transparent wall-window. It was just bright—like full day. The bedroom felt less like an enclosed space and more like a natural extension of the lawn outside.

Along the walls and in the corners appeared flowering shrubs—similar to those growing outdoors, yet subtly different. The blossoms were more numerous, larger, more lush, flawless, with shapes and shades that in nature might occur by chance—but never all at once.

The air filled with a delicate, remarkably pleasant fragrance. Not merely floral—it was a layered blend of blossoms, fresh leaves, a faint trace of cut grass, and something else, elusive. Overall, it felt like standing in a luxurious tropical garden or in a meadow at early spring dawn.

Soft, brisk morning music accompanied it perfectly. I’m no expert in classical music, but it sounded like a performance by some unmistakably renowned string quartet.

To confirm my theory, I removed the mask and clip.

The space immediately reverted to its ordinary state: the neatly made bed, the transparent wall-window, the lawn outside—exactly as they had been yesterday.

I put the mask and clip back on—and the new world returned. It felt as though I had awakened again, shifted to a higher level of wakefulness.

And with it came not a constructed explanation, but precise understanding. Not a chain of reasoning, but knowledge already present, simply activating at the appropriate moment. I instantly recognized the onset of the false memory that had been downloaded into me.

Art—or perhaps Kofi—had used the open remote access to my mask and clip to activate the transparent net Layer of the cottage.

Almost automatically, I switched my device permissions to “closed,” then quickly reviewed the available Layers. The cottage offered an entire suite of virtual interior augmentations—from minimalist to unapologetically decorative. I decided to return to that later, when I had time and inclination to experiment.

Holographic infographics and lines of text appeared before the wall-window: current weather, temperature, wind speed, and below, the day’s forecast. Above the headboard floated a report on my sleep. I noted the duration automatically—eleven hours and twenty-three minutes. All other metrics were in the green zone, comfortably above ninety percent.

Without quite realizing what I was doing, I swung open the bedroom window. Cool mountain air rushed in, this time carrying the unmistakably real scent of grass.

I opened the door to the living room and headed there, issuing commands almost reflexively: pour a glass of orange juice, brew a cup of black coffee, fill the bath, warm a towel. I had no appetite at all—Ian’s recovery formula was evidently still at work—or I might easily have ordered or prepared breakfast as well.

By the time I reached the kitchen, a chilled, condensation-beaded glass of juice was waiting in a niche of the refrigerator, and a rich aroma of freshly brewing coffee drifted from the machine. At the same time, the kitchen lighting softened, adjusting to morning mode, and a nearly invisible prompt appeared on the inner surface of the window, noting increased solar activity—the system recommended leaving the glass in filtration mode.

I noticed Estri “hiding” between the kitchen stove and the refrigerator.

Almost instantly I realized that I could now control the mech easily and silently. But I also noticed something else: Estri was behaving differently. He wasn’t taking initiative, wasn’t offering drinks or assistance. He was simply in standby mode.

I opened the mech control panel and saw the sliders labeled Initiative and Extraversion—both set almost to zero.

Looks like Art thought of that too, I reflected. So Estri wouldn’t overwhelm me with enthusiasm while I’m still adjusting.

For now, I decided to leave the settings as they were and try handling everyday matters myself.

As I finished my juice, savored my coffee, and went through my morning routine in the bathroom, I became fully convinced: managing everything around me felt easy, intuitive, and natural.

It wasn’t just information. My mind now carried memories of another life—a life lived here, in Variant 1. So nothing around me felt foreign or newly acquired. It felt familiar. Logical. As though I were returning rather than arriving.

I made myself a second cup of coffee and stepped outside with it.

Enjoying the view of the real—not virtual—lawns, flowerbeds, and shrubs, feeling the same fresh mountain breeze scented with wild grass, and slowly savoring my coffee, I decided to check my messages.

As expected, the terminal was in silent mode: incoming requests were disabled, and notifications suppressed. I enabled both and immediately saw the list.

Three messages—Ellen, Ian, and Art.

All were personal. No formal “From,” “To,” or “Subject.” Just small icons with photos and names.

Ellen wrote:

Hi, Mac!

Congratulations on your first download!

I already spoke with Ian—I know everything went well. He’ll give you the details himself, but overall he’s very pleased with the results. In his assessment, you’ll handle two false memories per evening without difficulty, which means we can complete the full download cycle in about three days. In that same timeframe, it’s realistic to complete at least one honing session per skill—except picking, of course. That one can only be honed in real fieldwork.

On the training grounds, it’s better if Art is with you at least the first time. I imagine he’ll suggest it himself. Just keep in mind: he only has today available for that. Our team is next in the picking rotation—most likely we deploy either tonight or tomorrow.

Don’t forget to register for the official course required to obtain your resonator license. It’s an external training program, and it’s best to book it at least a day in advance.

So yes, you’re sitting this picking out, of course—but we can already start planning the next one. Your internship will follow a special scenario, so I need confirmation that you’re ready at least a day before launch.

Art will help you with everything, but if you need me—message anytime.

I’m around.

Ian’s message read:

Hi, Mac.

Overall, everything went excellently—I’ve already confirmed that to Ellen. We can proceed with the standard accelerated schedule: two false memories per evening. I’d suggest holding sessions daily at 18:00. If that works for you, we’ll lock it in.

Today, please come in about half an hour earlier. I’d like to discuss something with you. Let me reassure you immediately: you’re perfectly fine. There’s just something interesting I noticed yesterday, and I decided not to overload you before your first download. Today we can talk about it calmly.

So I’ll see you at 17:30.

And of course, if anything at all feels off after yesterday’s session—come straight to me. Anytime. If I’m occupied, just ask for me; I’ll step out as soon as I can.

Art’s message:

Good morning, Mac.

I imagine you’re still getting used to everything. No rush—none of it’s going anywhere. When you feel more or less settled, call me. I’m around.

And one more thing. You've got your terminal and net ID now, so I'm fulfilling my promise. Zara's ID: L8U6-B832-09YS-78W9

You can try calling her, of course, but I already did—she's currently offline. Looks like she isn't in our Variant right now.

Art's message both pleased and unsettled me.

Pleased—because I was, in fact, only one step away from Zara.

Unsettled—because I couldn't take that step. Not yet.

As I thought about it, a faint anxiety crept in. Where was she now? Manish, I seemed to recall, had said that Zara spent most of her time in this Variant... no, that wasn't quite right. He had only mentioned that when she was here, she wasn't concerned about trouble from either the Forum or ARC. And what Zara had told Art was merely that she was rarely in her own, Fourth Variant. That didn't mean she was permanently in the First.

She could have business in other Variants. I didn't even know what she did professionally.

True, we had met her in the company of two Reds—one of whom, at the very least, raised questions. And she had been picking Essence alongside them.

But, I told myself, that didn't prove anything.

I had no desire to entertain unpleasant assumptions—especially not now, in my current buoyant mood.

I entered Zara's net ID into my terminal—and Art's as well.

In my previously empty contacts list, Art appeared at the very beginning, and Zara at the very end—the first and last letters of the alphabet.

The most important people in my world, I thought. As if they marked its boundaries.

For a while I considered whether to call her. If I did, the attempt would appear in her terminal—and I had no idea when she might call back. What if I were busy? Or in a download session? What if she thought I was simply choosing not to answer?

Maybe a message instead?

But what would I write?

After running through the same loop several times and failing to find a version that felt right, I decided—for now—not to do anything at all.

Then I called Art.

"Hey!" he answered immediately. "So? How does it feel?"

"Hey. I'm not even sure how to describe it..." I paused. "Maybe like switching from black-and-white to color. And three-dimensional. And in motion."

In message mode I couldn't see his reaction, but I was almost certain he laughed.

"Keep in mind," he said, "this is just the beginning."

"I hope so."

"Mac, back to business. I'll most likely be out on picking tomorrow, so while we've got time, let's get to the interesting part."

"The training grounds," I said, demonstrating my remarkable level of preparedness.

“Exactly. Which one do we start with?”

“The closed one.”

“Okay. I’ll be at your place in about five minutes. Come outside.”

“Deal.”

Chapter 24. The Closed Ground

The Closed Training Ground was a facility belonging exclusively to the Trillium and used solely for the preparation of striders and other agents—for honing.

Here, three skills were trained—separately or in any combination: dodging, resonator handling, and unarmed control—UC.

The ground itself was an enormous hangar. Or rather, a fragment of pristine mountainous terrain enclosed by walls and covered with a roof. Inside, the space was divided by irregular, fractured holographic partitions into separate “battle zones.”

Depending on size and configuration, each zone functioned either as a UC platform, a dodging route—with or without a resonator—or a hybrid of everything at once. What made them battle zones was the presence of simulated opponents: anthropomorphic mechs, either unarmed or equipped with pseudo-resonators. Each zone contained one or several such adversaries.

A strider’s objective was either to complete the route with minimal hits taken and maximum hits delivered, or to neutralize the opponent without a weapon—or to accomplish all of it simultaneously.

The layout and terrain of the zones changed daily so that conditions were always new. A dedicated team of mechs handled the reconfiguration. They moved massive boulders, installed simulated trees, barriers, and other objects. Some elements were holographic. The result was simple: there were no “familiar” battlefields. Every session took place in entirely new, unfamiliar terrain.

Art and I entered the hangar.

Near the entrance stood a reception console, behind which hovered an administrator mech. As we approached, it silently issued us two pseudo-resonators and a pair of backpacks. The packs resembled standard strider gear—but they, too, were simulations.

“It’s important to train with the pack on,” Art said. “As close as possible to real picking conditions.”

We stopped beside one of the smaller battle zones.

At the far end stood a mech nearly indistinguishable from a human—camouflage jacket and trousers, high boots. In its hand it held something very much like a resonator.

An orange number **1** appeared in my mask. The “res” in the mech’s hand lit up orange as well, and in my clip I heard the characteristic signal of an active device:

Beep... beep...

“We’ll start simple,” Art said. “Short, straight route. Ten meters. Minimal obstacles. Neutralization at the end.”

He added that he would demonstrate first.

“For clarity, we’ll switch on demo mode. You’ll see the mech’s pseudo-res the way I see it.”

I nodded.

Art stepped to the starting point. The mech opposite him slowly raised its resonator. The icon in my mask—and the device in its hand—flashed red. The signal in my clip shifted into a sharp, urgent warning:

Beep-beep-beep-beep-beep!

And in the next instant, Art moved.

It was... impressive.

A burst forward. A deflection. A roll. A sudden lateral shift, a leap, another roll. His movements were fast, economical—and astonishingly unpredictable. It was as if he wasn't moving through space so much as continually failing to be where he was supposed to be.

A couple of seconds later—the first shot.

Vzzzt!

A blue pulse erupted from the mech's resonator and slammed into a massive boulder—precisely where Art had been an instant earlier.

Almost immediately, Art fired.

His pulse struck the mech cleanly.

Another series of bursts and rolls. Another exchange of shots.

The mech—missed.

Art—hit again.

The mech didn't get a third shot.

Art was suddenly beside it. He slipped past the strike, intercepting the mech's arm and carrying its momentum forward. A sharp pull—and the mech went down hard. Art followed instantly, pinning it and twisting the arm into a lock.

A second later they were already standing.

The mech, not the least bit offended, retrieved its pseudo-res from the ground. Its icon had shifted back to orange—then vanished entirely. The mech froze in place.

Only then did I realize that Art's resonator was already on his belt. He had secured it to free his hands for unarmed control—and I hadn't even caught the moment he did it.

Session results appeared in my mask:

Dodges: 2

— successful: 2

Shots fired: 2

— justified: 2

— hits: 2

Neutralizations: 1

— justified: 1

— successful: 1

I was so impressed that I couldn't find words.

I simply spread my hands in silent acknowledgment of the obvious—Art's mastery was absolute.

Art walked over to me. He didn't look triumphant or smug—if anything, he seemed almost preemptively apologetic.

"Well, Mac. Your turn. The first attempt usually goes... not great. That's normal. Just do it however you can. We need something to build from."

I took that for simple politeness.

In my head, I had a very clear, confident understanding of what needed to be done. It seemed to me it would be just like this morning—controlling the devices. It would simply... happen.

I had overlooked one thing.

Your body is not a remote device.

It's your body.

And it knows how to hurt.

When the mech raised its resonator—now glowing red—and the sharp, pulsing warning filled my clip, I lunged forward.

For the first two seconds, everything seemed fine.

Then I attempted a roll.

I went down hard onto my side. Pain shot through my hip and shoulder at the same time. My head rang from the impact. And almost immediately I realized something else: rolling across rough ground with a backpack on is wildly inconvenient.

A split second later I heard the ugly:

Vzzzt!

I didn't feel impact or touch—but somehow I knew I'd been hit.

I threw myself forward, somersaulted—rolled again over the pack, scrambled to my feet—and my entire right side flared with the pain from that first fall.

And then I took a second hit.

I pushed through a few more desperate steps. Only a few meters now.

That sound again—and I saw the blue beam strike me.

Only then did I remember I had a resonator.

I snapped it up and fired, watching the mech jerk aside. The beam missed.

Instantly I understood I had a brief window. I surged forward, stepped, and leapt sideways.

Shot. Beam—yes! Missed.

Encouraged, I charged the mech, barely paying attention to the lens trained on me.

And, predictably, took another hit.

But I was close now.

The mech struck—short, compact, no wind-up—with its left.

And connected.

I ran straight into its fist with my stomach. The blow knocked the air from me. A nauseating wave surged through my head; everything dimmed for a second—

—and I hit the ground.

The mech immediately pinned me and twisted the arm holding the resonator behind my back.

The pain forced my fingers open. The resonator dropped to the ground.

The mech released me at once, rose, and went still.

With my body aching, my head heavy and fogged, and a burning, almost physical sense of humiliation pressing down on me, I had no desire to stand.

I wanted to stay down.

Or better—disappear.

Or sink straight into the ground.

“Mac, listen—that wasn’t bad!” Art’s voice came from above. “You reached him. And you dodged one shot. In my first session, after the fourth hit, I just stopped and decided to restart. You’ve clearly got potential.”

For a moment I thought he was mocking me.

But when I pushed myself up and looked him in the eye, I realized—he meant it completely.

“Thanks, Art,” I muttered bleakly. “But honestly, you’d be better off yelling at me. That was... humiliating.”

“Careful what you wish for,” Art snorted. “Kirsten, for example, never held back. And I can tell you—the experience isn’t exactly pleasant.”

Despite everything, I couldn’t help smiling.

Seeing that, Art clapped me on the shoulder and smiled properly this time—openly encouraging.

“Alright. What does the session report say? And check your skill bar while you’re at it.”

The report was already in my mask:

Session Results:

Dodges: 5

— successful: 1

Shots fired: 1

— justified: 1

— hits: 0

Neutralizations: 1

— justified: 1

—successful: 0

Then I opened my skill scale. I knew how. Picking up the training resonator from the ground, I summoned my profile in the mask and selected the appropriate panel. In the corner of the display hovered my small, official-looking 3D portrait. Beneath it:

Mac

Agent, First Rank

Essence Picker, First Class

Current Skill Levels:

- Picking: 1 (+0)

- Piloting: 0 (+0)

- Dodging: 5 (+5)

- Unarmed Control: 1 (+1)

- Resonator: 1 (+1)

Each skill was visualized as a beige bar—mine still very short. At the end of each bar glowed a small green segment: recent progress.

Art looked at me expectantly. I realized he couldn't see the data—by default, it was confidential. I quickly took a screenshot of the skill scale and sent it to him.

He studied it carefully, then nodded with satisfaction.

"That's what I thought. The NA gave you five points for that successful dodge. I'll repeat: that's an excellent result for a first attempt. The single points for picking, UC, and shooting just log participation. You made the right moves—just without results. Yet."

I still suspected he was exaggerating slightly about the "excellent result."

But my gratitude for his support was entirely genuine.

We returned to the starting point.

"Now let's isolate the skills. First—dodging. You can stash the res in your pack. The task is simple: run the route and touch the mech. Preferably without getting hit."

To be honest, I'd rather not describe the full extent of my subsequent humiliation, so I'll limit myself to the results.

We started with dodging. Over the next ten sessions, I managed to avoid being hit only twice more. I quickly realized that the first success had been largely luck. As if sensing this, the NA stopped being generous and awarded only one point per successful dodge instead of five.

Honing resonator shooting felt like a pistol duel between me and the mech. Either one of us—or both—would advance toward the other. The mech constantly altered its rhythm: fast movements shifting to slow, sharp motions blending into fluid ones. The objective sounded simple—draw, fire, and hit—but only if the opponent genuinely intended to shoot.

That was the real difficulty.

The mech regularly performed threatening but ultimately harmless gestures—sudden lunges forward or sideways, simulating attack. The moment I raised the res and pulled the trigger, it would instantly break into motion, dodging with inhuman agility—in both the literal and figurative sense.

I don't remember how many such "duels" we went through, but in the end my resonator proficiency bar did grow—by eight points.

And then came UC.

In other words: sparring.

Which also meant blows, falls, and painfully efficient holds. Or, to summarize—pain, pain, and... significant pain.

After about half an hour—when the NA, as it seemed to me, most reluctantly awarded me a third point in Unarmed Control—Art took pity and announced that he was hungry and it was time for a break.

"After lunch we can head to the open ground and work on piloting."

I exhaled with immense relief.

We left the hangar and entered the adjacent administrative and service wing of the training complex.

Some time later, standing in the sanitizer chamber of the spa section, rinsing dust, sweat, and the remnants of my illusions about my strider competence off my body, I fortunately remembered that all sports and fitness sanitizers include a healing mode—and immediately switched it on.

By the time I stepped out of the spa, I felt almost normal again. The scrapes, bruises, and swelling had nearly vanished.

Art and I stopped at one of several small cafés located in the same building. It turned out to specialize in Asian cuisine and offered “replica-class” food. So the noodles placed before me by the café’s sole attendant—a compact mech-waiter—looked like ordinary meat, vegetables, and herbs. In reality, everything had been synthetically produced.

As I quickly discovered, this had no negative effect on the taste—quite the opposite. Every component of the dish, and the dish as a whole, tasted exquisite. I might even call it benchmark-level.

Noticing my obvious satisfaction, Art explained that artificial ingredients make it far easier to achieve a perfect flavor profile than natural ones. He personally preferred replica-class food.

I decided on the spot to follow his example—and informed him accordingly.

Chapter 25. The Open Ground

After lunch we stepped outside and settled properly into the seats of Big Tom—piloting honing was next.

Big Tom immediately set a course for the nearby open ground, a vast training area designed for mastering various types of floaters and refining the associated skills.

This enormous range, high in the mountains, was not under the exclusive control of the three Agencies. It was used by local police units, pilots from other services, and even civilians who wanted to practice manual piloting—or simply enjoy themselves that way.

The boundaries of the ground were not marked in the physical world. They appeared only in the net Map Layer as a designated special-use zone. Access required authorization from the local Forum. We had it.

As we crossed the virtual boundary, Big Tom slowed smoothly and came to a stop, hovering about ten meters above the ground. Before us stretched raw mountain rock, carved by canyons and streaked in places with glaciers. Floaters streaked overhead at intervals—some climbing sharply, others diving into narrow gaps between the cliffs.

Art turned to me and made a broad, inviting gesture.

“Go ahead. For now, just fly. Get used to the controls.”

The cockpit space in front of me transformed instantly. Holographic scales and symbols appeared, displaying speed, altitude, orientation, and other parameters. Ahead of us, beyond the canopy, a cursor materialized—a stylized green arrow indicating direction of travel. I knew that as speed increased, the virtual cursor would drift farther ahead, marking the point we were about to occupy.

I “recalled” without effort the purpose of every other holographic element filling the cabin. Basic operation of non-commercial ground and aerial vehicles had been included in my first download. As I later confirmed in my profile, the Forum had automatically issued the corresponding piloting license afterward. As with everyone else, obtaining it required only the basic skill package and knowledge of the rules—and in any case, the NA would never allow a violation or the creation of real danger.

A message appeared above the instruments:

Manual Mode.

For some reason, my heart began to beat faster.

Carefully, I imagined us shifting forward, moving slowly ahead.

Big Tom responded with perfect obedience, gliding through the air. The cursor drifted forward almost imperceptibly.

After covering a few meters, I stopped the glider. Then I exhaled slowly and glanced at Art. Smiling, he gave me a thumbs-up. I looked forward again.

More confidently now, I accelerated. I gained a little speed and tried maneuvering: left, right, then a smooth drop, a rise, back to level flight. Big Tom executed every mental command with flawless precision— instantaneous, without the slightest lag.

It felt as if the machine around me were simply an extension of my body. I even had the impression that X-shaped wings had unfolded behind my back. This new, augmented version of me could fly. I was gliding, soaring, drifting through the air—unbound.

The sensation of free flight was dizzying, intoxicating, overwhelming. For reasons I couldn’t quite explain, it reminded me of spring—the sweetness of fresh air and a sunlit world quietly rejoicing in its own existence.

I leaned forward and, gaining speed, plunged toward the cliffs and the ice clinging to them. The cursor pulled far ahead of the cabin; the ground began rushing toward us at an alarming rate. I caught myself, reduced speed, leveled out. Then slowed further, came to a stop, and breathed.

I turned to Art, eyes wide with exhilaration.

“This is... incredible...” I exhaled.

Art nodded, watching me with a faint smile—and, I thought, a trace of envy. For him—someone who had been able to fly like this since childhood, even since birth—flight without wheels, pedals, or joysticks, guided by thought alone, had always been ordinary. The dizzying freedom, the boundless joy of it, must have long ago become routine.

Which made it all the more precious to me now—feeling it for the first time.

I surged forward again, keeping low over the terrain, tracing the contours of the land, weaving between smaller rock formations and diving into narrow gorges.

The arrow-cursor ahead not only indicated direction and speed; it also served as a risk indicator. If my chosen trajectory and velocity began to create danger of collision with ground or stone, the cursor shifted color—smoothly but rapidly—from green to yellow, then, as risk increased, through orange to red.

At the same time, the NA would quietly but decisively intervene, nudging control just enough to steer us out of the danger zone, selecting a trajectory as close as possible to my intended path while keeping it safe and within tolerable G-forces.

A couple of times I failed to correct in time and sent us straight toward a cliff. The arrow flared red instantly, and the glider snapped into a sharp turn, rolling almost belly-forward before veering hard aside. We were pressed unpleasantly into our seats.

For a while I simply couldn't tear myself away from piloting. I couldn't think about anything else.

It felt like finally drinking clean, cold water after a long, painfully long thirst—gulping it down greedily, almost choking on it, unable to get enough.

Art maintained a tactful silence the entire time and didn't interfere.

Gradually, I began to come back to myself and realize it was time to move on to actual honing. At last, making a deliberate effort, I brought the glider to a stop, nodded to Art, and said:

“All right. Let's begin.”

He nodded as if nothing unusual had happened.

“Excellent. We'll go through the training routes in order. In my experience, they're designed very well—the difficulty ramps up exactly as it should.”

He tilted his head slightly toward the windshield. Text flickered beneath it:

Layer connected: Maps

Filters: ARC / open ground / training / route #1

Among the rocks, several virtual objects lit up in golden light—concentric circles crossed by perpendicular lines, like three-dimensional targets. They formed an uneven, jagged line through the terrain.

“Simple enough,” Art said. “Your task is to clear all checkpoints in the shortest time possible. Start when you're ready.”

I immediately directed the glider toward the nearest checkpoint. I built up decent speed, though cautiously, making sure to pass precisely through the center of each circle. I flew cleanly through the first “target,” then the next, and the next. There were twelve in total.

At once, my mask displayed:

Training Route 1

Time: 1 minute 18 seconds

Accuracy: 100%

Performance rating: 37%

I opened my skill scale. Piloting now read 2 (+2).

I automatically sent the report to Art. As usual, he nodded with quiet approval.

“Not bad. We can move on.”

“Wait,” I said, confused. “Why so low? Why only thirty-seven percent? And just two points?”

But I was already beginning to guess. Art simply confirmed it.

“Speed, of course. In theory, that route can be flown much faster in this craft.”

“Almost three times faster?” I ventured.

“No,” Art shook his head. “Much faster. On Big Tom? Probably... ten seconds. With extreme G-forces, of course.”

He paused, then added:

“The rating is calculated from a combination of accuracy and speed. The weight of each factor shifts depending on the route’s configuration and complexity. You got full marks for accuracy. For speed... considerably less.”

I felt a brief flicker of embarrassment. It transformed almost instantly—and quite naturally—into competitive irritation.

“Fine,” I said. “Let’s try again.”

The second route earned me even less—twenty-four percent. I had accelerated, what felt like to the limit, but failed to center myself perfectly in eleven of the sixteen checkpoints.

The art of piloting turned out to be far more demanding than it had seemed at first.

We flew route after route. Their configurations grew more complex. The number and density of checkpoints increased. They appeared at varying altitudes, closer to the ground, and rocks began to intrude into the path more frequently. Navigating them became steadily more difficult.

After the twelfth route—for which I received eighteen percent—Art asked me to stop.

“We don’t have to keep increasing difficulty,” he said. “We could repeat some earlier routes.”

“No,” I replied stubbornly. “Let’s continue. Thirteen.”

Art smiled.

“All right. But I want to suggest a technique. I use it myself. And I’m not the only one.”

I looked at him intently.

“When you’re maneuvering around obstacles, try to keep the cursor in the red zone. Trust the NA—it will guide you along a far more optimal trajectory than you can select manually. But be prepared for the G-forces.”

I nodded eagerly.

“Thanks, Art.”

I tried to follow his advice.

In practice, it wasn’t so simple.

I would aim the glider straight at a rock—but only up to a certain point. When it began rushing toward me at a catastrophically increasing speed and the cursor shifted to orange, my survival instinct seized me by the collar and yanked me back. Without consciously deciding to, I would cut speed and bank away, clearing the obstacle the safe way.

The cursor would immediately return to green.

Still, I completed Route Thirteen with a fairly decent result—forty-two percent.

I flew several more routes. The results hovered around the same level—roughly forty percent. I found myself growing increasingly irritated. I forced myself not to veer away from dangerous lines, to ignore the cursor turning red. But I couldn’t do it. My survival instinct kept overriding me—and that only made me angrier.

Sensing my state, after the eighteenth route Art turned to me and said gently:

“Mac, I think you’re pushing too hard right now. In my experience, it’s better to conserve your nervous system. You’ll need it on real pickings.”

For the first couple of seconds, I wanted to argue. But after thinking about what he’d said, I exhaled slowly and let myself ease back.

“Yeah...” I admitted. “I think you’re right.”

“Besides,” Art continued, “I’d say you’ve already made solid progress. I’d put your piloting at around ten points by now.”

“Nine,” I replied after checking my profile. My mood lifted noticeably. “But I think I can round it up today.”

Art nodded encouragingly.

I drew a deep breath, trying to gather myself for the next route.

And at that exact moment, an alarm buzzer cut through the cockpit.

Red letters flashed before us:

Attention!

Call to picking.

Participants: team Ellen.

Starting point: Gate No. 2, Variant No. 7.

Storm began: 17... 18... 19... seconds ago.

Almost simultaneously—without waiting for any command—Big Tom snapped into motion, banking sharply to the right and accelerating hard.

I looked at Art uneasily. He appeared calm, though a trace of confusion crossed his face.

“That’s strange,” he said thoughtfully. “According to the analysts, this Storm wasn’t expected before tonight. Looks like the appearance of the new Gate shifted the Storm frequency.”

He paused briefly, then seemed to cut himself off.

“Mac, as you know, we can’t lose time in situations like this. I won’t be able to take you home. I can drop you somewhere on the way.”

“Of course,” I said quickly. “I didn’t mean that. I meant your things. Your pack...”

“Already packed,” Art smiled. “It’s back there.”

He hooked a thumb over his shoulder.

I nodded with genuine respect.

Without altering course, Big Tom began descending rapidly. I saw our trajectory intersect a mountain highway.

“I’ll be back in three or four days,” Art said evenly. “We covered the essentials. You’ll manage from here. And, of course—good luck with the downloads.”

“And good luck with the picking,” I replied, rising from my seat.

Art raised his hand. I slapped it with mine.

Then, bracing against the deceleration of the glider, I moved toward the rear of the cabin. Big Tom touched down smoothly. The ramp lowered—and I ran out.

The glider lifted off again immediately, retracting the ramp mid-motion.

I was left alone by the side of the road. Cars streamed past.

I thought about calling a taxi and, after a brief consideration, chose a regular ground vehicle rather than a glider.

I didn’t want to dilute the magnificent memory of today’s piloting with a routine autopilot ride.

Chapter 26. Waiting

Three days passed.

On Saturday morning, the first thing I did after waking was send Ellen the message she had asked for: I had completed all downloads and moved every one of my professional skill scales off zero. The previous evening had been my fourth and final download, preceded by the “licensing” training for resonator use.

The training turned out to be largely procedural. The content itself was nothing new—a set of fairly obvious principles about using a resonator only when necessary, observing safety protocols, and so on. What mattered was the format. The instructor mech didn’t simply recite the rules; it asked questions, ran short tests, formally confirming that I hadn’t just heard the information but had understood it.

The session normally concluded with a training freeze, but that requirement was waived in my case. The NA confirmed that freeze had already occurred in my life experience.

Far more important—and far more interesting—were the downloads themselves. Besides the first one, there had been three more, each containing two false memories. Which meant that now I possessed a complete—as complete as my situation allowed—knowledge and understanding of all Delta Variants except the Ninth, of course. My own Eighth Variant, naturally, required no downloading.

As expected, the new “memories” left behind an entire constellation of questions and threads of thought. But there was one idea in particular—one that first occurred to me after the second download, the one covering the Second and Third Variants—that I kept returning to.

The idea was simple, and now seemed entirely obvious: much of what in my world is considered fantasy or creative imagination—including the substance of many literary works—may in fact be knowledge of other Variants that somehow surfaced.

Take, for example, dragons or unicorns from Variant Two. Now that I “remember” them as part of my own lived experience, there is nothing mythical about them. They are simply animals—domesticated, familiar, working creatures. No more fantastic than horses or elephants are to us. They likely existed in other Variants as well, but for one reason or another did not survive or did not persist into our present.

Or consider—again from the same Variant—elves, dwarves, and orcs. They are not magical beings. They are peoples—ethnic groups—who preserved their distinct languages, cultures, and traditions, and with them certain differences in appearance, physique, and manner of speech from what I am accustomed to.

These examples—and many others—led me to what felt like an unavoidable conclusion: information somehow leaks from one Delta world into another.

And the moment I recognized that, I had a distinct intuition that Essence plays no small role in the process.

It was a subject worth discussing with Art. Worth thinking about more deeply in general.

Another notable event during those days was my conversation with Ian—on the very day Art left for picking.

Even though I arrived ahead of schedule, Ian was already waiting. This time he suggested I sit not in the monumental client chair but at a small round table. He positioned himself not directly opposite me, but slightly to the side—a placement that allowed him to avoid fixing me with a direct stare and instead glance at me occasionally, almost casually.

Looking at me in that way, Ian began:

“Mac, I need to tell you something. Yesterday wasn’t the first neurocoding session of your life.”

I widened my eyes, not yet understanding where he was heading. I assumed it was a turn of phrase, or perhaps the setup for one of his jokes.

It wasn't.

"I won't burden you with technical details," Ian continued. "In short: any e2n intervention leaves characteristic traces in the corresponding regions of the brain. We can see them."

He jerked his head toward the equipment looming behind him.

"And yesterday we saw such traces in your brain." He paused. "Before our download."

I understood almost immediately.

"Yes," I nodded. "That's right. I've been through a freeze. I was hit with a resonator."

Ian waved that off with a slight shake of his head.

"Freeze and resonators have nothing to do with it. I wouldn't even register those as noteworthy. In your case, it goes much... deeper. Your brain underwent a complex, large-scale intervention. Something fundamentally different from our procedures."

He paused, searching for a comparison.

"If I had to use an analogy... it would be like comparing a simple photograph to an abstract painting. And not just any painting—a masterpiece. Changes were introduced into your brain—not in the regions responsible for event memory, but in far deeper layers. Layers connected to reflexes, subconscious responses, unarticulated sensations. I'll be honest: modern neurocoding simply isn't capable of operating at that level yet."

As he spoke, my surprise rapidly deepened into something closer to shock.

"But... how is that even possible?" I blurted out.

And then something clicked in my mind. The thought was almost obvious.

"Tell me... can you determine when it happened?"

Ian glanced at me with an approving half-smile.

"Fortunately, yes. We've learned to determine the timing of e2n interventions. In your case, it occurred precisely during the period whose memories we scanned yesterday. Episode One."

He gave an ironic little smile.

"You guys can encrypt and compartmentalize all you like, but it doesn't take a genius to figure out which event we're talking about."

I sighed and gave a small shrug.

"I understand—secrecy, clearance levels, all that," Ian continued. "But this isn't only about your operational affairs. This may matter for the development of neurocoding as a whole. We might be standing on the threshold of a fundamentally new understanding of how to interact with the human brain. I'll obviously discuss it with Norton and with respected colleagues in my field. So it's entirely possible we'll ask for your assistance again."

"Of course," I said quickly. "If you need anything, I'm at your disposal."

Ian nodded, studying me with thoughtful focus. In that moment he bore no resemblance to the carefree, slightly reckless charmer I'd first taken him for. Sitting across from me—or, rather, beside me—was a scientist. A professional. One of the "respected colleagues" he had just mentioned.

As if reading my thoughts, Ian immediately restored his familiar, lightly mischievous expression.

“And yes, Mac... if you ever happen to meet whoever did this to you, please pass along my sincere and deepest professional respect to our colleague.”

Now, recalling that conversation, I found myself thinking again that it was something I ought to discuss with Art. I had begun to notice that talking through new developments, ideas, even stray thoughts with Art had become a habit—almost a need. Over the past few days, several such topics had accumulated. And today he was due back from picking.

Strangely enough, at that very moment an incoming call from Art appeared in my mask.

“Hey, Mac! How are things? I’m on approach. Can I drop by, or better later?”

“Oh—hi! I’m fine. You won’t believe it—I was just thinking about you. I think we need to talk about a few things. Of course, come over. Coffee?”

“Yes, please. Strong. I cleared the Gate around two-thirty in the morning, so I’ve barely slept. Go ahead and start it—I’ll be there in about two minutes.”

As I instructed the machine to prepare a double coffee, I decided that discussions about Essence and broader theoretical speculation could probably wait, given Art’s state. The conversation with Ian, on the other hand, was worth sharing.

Barely a minute later, through the open wall-door, I heard the familiar sound of Big Tom touching down.

When Art came in, we exchanged a firm handshake, and I asked immediately:

“So—how was the picking?”

“If I’m honest? Not great,” he replied, dropping into a chair out of habit and taking an appreciative first sip of coffee. “Not the picking itself—that went smoothly. No incidents. I mean what’s going on there in general. We were in the Seventh Variant. As you already know, most of their key technologies are built around nuclear energy. Which means the states—or rather, entire blocs—are locked in a brutal struggle for nuclear fuel. It’s reached the point where a global catastrophe nearly unfolded. The way it once did in the Fourth Variant.”

He paused, took another sip.

“Ellen says she’s planning a serious conversation with the ICDA people about it. We may have to intervene somehow.”

He fell silent for a moment, then seemed to shift back to me.

“But that’s later. What about you? Downloads, grounds, everything else?”

I gave him a concise summary of the past few days, including my conversation with Ian.

“And in my free time,” I concluded, “I’ve mostly been on the grounds. And dealing with various practical things.”

Art listened attentively. After a short pause, he said:

“Believe it or not, I suspected something like this,” he nodded, clearly referring to Ian’s findings. “And my intuition tells me this is far from the end. Quite the opposite—it’s just beginning. Or maybe it’s been developing for a long time already, and only now has it started affecting us—you, specifically.”

He paused briefly.

“In any case, it’s good you’ve completed your training and are ready for work. And speaking of that—I have news as well. I talked to Zara today. Called her right after I delivered the box to the vault.”

In response to my look—silent accusation and mild reproach combined—he only waved it off with a smile.

"I know, I know. I should have said it first. But there's nothing urgent there. And if I'd started with that, we wouldn't have been able to talk calmly about anything else."

His tone—that friendly, understanding irony—dissolved the brief tension at once. I found myself smiling despite myself, acknowledging that he was right.

"We had a good conversation," Art continued. "As it turns out, she only got back yesterday—to our Variant, I mean. Said she'd been away on work."

I frowned involuntarily, but Art didn't seem to notice.

"I asked where she lives. Turns out it's on the coast—less than half an hour from here in Big Tom. I suggested we meet today, the same group as we planned. She reacted completely normally. In fact, I even had the impression she was expecting something like that. I suggested dinner all together, did a quick search for somewhere near her place, preferably by the sea, and found one of the Eco Gallery restaurants—big chain, eco-cuisine. She agreed. Here's the address."

He sent me the map with the restaurant marked.

"Seven p.m."

As he spoke, I suddenly became acutely aware of my own pulse—fast, insistent. Realizing that, I grew genuinely irritated with myself. It was probably time to stop behaving like an adolescent and get a grip. Especially ahead of meeting Zara.

"Well, that's about it," Art concluded, rising from his chair and setting his cup down. "There's still time before evening, and I'd like to devote it to some well-earned rest. We can meet there, or—if you prefer—we'll pick you up."

I made a deliberate effort not to react to that perfectly natural "we."

"Yes, please swing by," I replied evenly, walking him to the door. "And, by the way... thanks for Estri. I've settled in. You can take him back."

"Excellent," Art smiled. "I've missed him. Estri!"

He nodded toward the doorway. Estri, who had been discreetly stationed somewhere in the kitchen, immediately glided toward the exit.

"We'll be here at six-thirty," Art said, turning back once more.

I gave him a thumbs-up. He nodded and followed Estri toward Big Tom's ramp.

...

Among the "practical things" I had casually mentioned to Art was, fortunately, the question of clothing.

As someone who genuinely dislikes shopping, I was relieved to discover that in this world such problems could be solved without endless store visits, fittings, hesitation, or the internal debate of "do I really need this?" One properly formulated task for the NA—and the issue simply dissolved.

A couple of days earlier, I had asked my NA—whom I had, for no particular reason, named Larry; the name had surfaced spontaneously and stuck—something along the lines of:

"Larry, please buy me several outfits suitable for all occasions."

If anyone were to point out that this was not the most precise instruction ever given, I would probably agree. And yet Larry executed it flawlessly. Within hours, my wardrobe was filled with clothes and shoes that I tried on one by one—and approved without exception. Nothing needed returning to the net stores. Sizes, cuts, tailoring—everything fit perfectly and suited me. I didn't even bother wondering how Larry had managed it.

I acquired a full set of grooming and fragrance products in much the same way.

So when, following Larry's suggestion, I chose for the evening a pistachio-colored shirt, beige trousers, something halfway between a blazer and a light jacket in an indeterminate but extremely flattering shade, and sport-style shoes—astonishingly comfortable—I studied myself in the mirror and felt entirely satisfied.

The time remaining until six-thirty I spent at the open ground, simply flying a rented glider between the cliffs, carving smooth arcs and thinking about nothing at all. As I had already discovered, it was the best way for me to rest and clear my head.

I returned home early so as not to keep Mona and Art waiting.

They arrived precisely on time. When I stepped into the cabin—the seats once again arranged in a circle—they both rose to greet me.

I looked at Mona and noted that she remained faithful to her style of perfectly calibrated carelessness. Art's outfit aligned more or less with mine, which pleased me—though I understood perfectly well that this was entirely Larry's doing. I thanked him silently.

The flight to the restaurant took just over twenty minutes. We spoke little, each of us absorbed in our own thoughts.

For my part, I found myself reflecting on the fact that every meeting with Zara so far had, in one way or another, been connected with food.

I wasn't sure whether that was a good sign or a bad one.

I never reached a conclusion—because we were already descending to land.

Chapter 27. A Friendly Dinner

The restaurant wasn't directly on the shore, but the moment I stepped out of the cabin, I could already smell the sea in the air. The water stretched not far away, reached by a gentle slope covered in dense coastal vegetation.

The interior was styled like an art gallery. The main hall was divided into private booths by holographic walls, every surface of which was covered with images of paintings in a wide range of styles. The artworks moved slowly—enlarging, shrinking, dissolving into one another. The effect was subtle, almost hypnotic, enhanced by low, lingering music that seemed to flow rather than play.

The mech who greeted us introduced himself as Cuel. We gave our names in return and followed him down a passage between booths, careful not to walk through the holographic walls so as not to disturb any guests who might be inside. Selecting one of the wall-paintings, Cuel drifted soundlessly through it, and we followed.

We entered a cozy space with a large round table at the center and four inviting semi-armchairs arranged around it. Above the table, suspended in the air before each seat, hovered a holographic menu.

We took our places and asked the waiter to return in five minutes. Art settled opposite me; Mona took the seat to my left. Almost unconsciously, I turned my head to the right and looked at the fourth chair—still empty.

At nearly the same moment, the abstract painting on the wall behind it seemed to part smoothly down the middle, letting Zara in.

Her appearance—as before—felt unexpected and faintly magical, as though she had materialized from thin air or stepped in from some neighboring reality.

No matter how much I had prepared myself, no matter how many times I had replayed this moment in my head, my breath caught, my pulse quickened, and for a second the room seemed to tilt.

It took several long moments of deliberate effort to steady myself. Art rescued me from an awkward pause by rising at once and extending his hand with an easy smile.

"Hi, Zara," he said calmly, warmly. "Good to see you. I'm not sure whether I like the setting of this meeting more than the last one. The mountains weren't bad either."

Zara smiled and shook his hand.

"Hi, Art. Yes, I liked that meeting too. Though this seems perfectly decent as well."

Collecting myself, I stood up too. She turned to me, extended her hand, and said:

"Hello, Mac."

It was simple and natural—warm, open, without the slightest hint of flirtation or irony. And in that moment, with the warmth of her hand in mine, all my nervousness seemed to dissolve at once.

"Hello," I replied quietly, meeting her eyes and no longer attempting to conceal how I felt.

"I'm not going to wait for one of you to remember to introduce me," Mona's voice came from behind me.

She walked around the table, offering her hand.

"Zara, hi. I'm Mona."

They shook hands, holding each other's gaze for a heartbeat longer than usual—and then suddenly laughed and embraced like old friends. It looked as if the same thought had occurred to both of them at once, and they had instantly recognized it in each other.

We took our seats again. As if sensing the moment, Cuel drifted silently back into our booth.

Not allowing the pause to stretch, Mona took the initiative.

“Cuel, could you please tell us, in general terms, about the concept behind your menu and what you might recommend tonight?”

“With pleasure, Mona,” the waiter replied in a well-modulated voice. “But first, may I offer beverages? A profile is sufficient, and I will select an optimal mix.”

“I’d like something mildly stimulating,” Mona said. “Ten to fifteen percent. A little alcohol is fine—around five degrees. No other effects. Not too sweet. Chilled, but no ice. And low-calorie, of course.”

Cuel gave what looked like an understanding nod and turned to Zara.

“I’ll have the same, but with no effects at all, please,” she said.

“Noted,” Cuel replied, shifting his gaze. “Art? Mac?”

“Something cool, unsweetened, and with no effects,” Art said.

“The same,” I added without much thought.

“Excellent,” the mech concluded. “Now, allow me to introduce our menu.”

He paused briefly, as if clearing his throat without sound, then continued:

“Eco Gallery is an official representative of the culinary houses Kagemori, Maison Cardo, and Casa Armelli. Naturally, their spring and summer menus are fully available. In addition, we offer a standing selection of classics and highlights from the past three seasons. And, of course, a number of our own creations, which have already earned a strong reputation.”

He stopped, clearly awaiting questions or comments.

I knew that eco-cuisine, being entirely synthetic and therefore almost unlimited in its ability to create flavors, aromas, forms, and textures, had long since developed its own branch of “haute” cuisine, where the culinary houses set the tone. But beyond that, I was admittedly out of my depth. Which, apparently, could not be said of Mona.

She drew out thoughtfully:

“Mmm... Then I’ll have something light from Kagemori. A salad... from the spring menu, perhaps.”

Several images appeared in a row on the holographic menu before her. They qualified as dishes only by virtue of resting on flat plates—in every other respect they resembled elaborate cakes, floral arrangements, or three-dimensional still lifes.

Mona began to “leaf” through the menu, sliding the images aside and occasionally touching one. Each selected dish expanded to fill the entire display and began rotating slowly.

At last she stopped.

“This one, please.”

“An excellent choice, Mona,” Cuel responded approvingly.

By that point, I noticed that Art and Zara were also studying their menus with focus. Somewhat uncertainly, I mentally pronounced one of the names Cuel had mentioned—Casa Armelli. Images immediately appeared before me, and I began scrolling through them.

Without looking up, Art murmured:

"I'm in the mood for something more substantial... From Maison Cardo's mains... Yes. This one looks promising."

He enlarged a dish that more closely resembled recognizable food—though still exotic in appearance. Its surface seemed to flicker with tongues of flame.

"Of course, Art," Cuel confirmed. "Flambéing, incidentally, is one of the defining trends of this summer season—particularly at Maison Cardo."

He turned to Zara, who had just completed her selection.

"This one for me, please."

"Forgive me, Zara," Cuel said with mild professional caution, clearly educated by past experience. "Do you have any caloric restrictions?"

"No, I'm fine. I enjoy eating well," Zara replied with a smile.

I registered, with quiet satisfaction, that the question occupying my thoughts on the way here had just received a thoroughly positive answer.

Momentarily distracted by that realization, I faltered when Cuel turned to me. Acting on impulse, I said:

"I'll have the same, please."

And immediately felt a faint flush of self-consciousness.

Cuel, however, was a consummate professional. He smoothed over the moment at once by slightly raising his voice and redirecting attention.

"Excellent. The dishes will be ready in seven to thirteen minutes. If your beverages"—he turned toward another mech who was gliding into the booth with a flat serving platform bearing four tall, exotically shaped glasses—"need to be refreshed or replaced, I remain at your service."

He waited while the mech arranged the glasses on the table, then departed soundlessly alongside it.

We raised our glasses.

"To the reunion, friends," Art said in a tone faintly ironic, as if apologizing for the conventional toast.

We tasted the drinks. Mine was light, delicately balanced, and pleasantly refreshing. I took another sip with genuine pleasure.

"This," Art said contentedly after several mouthfuls, eyeing his glass with approval, "is roughly what I was dreaming about yesterday on picking."

"And where were you yesterday?" Zara asked calmly, naturally. From her tone I understood she meant which Variant.

"The Seventh," Art replied just as calmly, taking another sip. "Drinks weren't exactly on the agenda there."

Zara nodded in understanding.

"You didn't happen to be returning from there yesterday, by any chance?" Art inquired casually.

"No, I was in the Fourth," Zara answered after the slightest pause—as though weighing how much to reveal.

"Hm." Art nodded sympathetically. "Visiting home?"

Zara hesitated again, briefly.

"Mostly work," she said at last. Then, catching his questioning look, she elaborated a little more readily. "I work in organic botany and naturopathy. Anything involving herbs and plant-based formulations. I have a

small studio—just me and two mechs. We create tea blends, aromatic capsules, oils, creams. All organic, of course.”

I remembered the tea she had served us in the mountains and thought that she had clearly achieved a considerable level of mastery in her craft.

“Some herbs don’t exist in this Variant,” Zara continued. “Or rather, they do—but they’re... different. So from time to time I have to go through the Gates.”

“Where can your products be found?” Mona asked with genuine interest. “I mean, if I wanted to buy something.”

“At La Vie d’une Fleur and Organic Spot,” Zara replied evenly.

Mona’s eyebrows shot up.

“I have an open procurement request with them,” Zara added casually.

This time Mona’s eyes widened fully, her lips parting in surprise. She turned to Art.

“Organic Spot—and especially La Vie d’une Fleur—are the most prestigious organic marketplaces. And everything there is extremely expensive.”

“And an open request,” Zara continued, “means they’re prepared to purchase anything I offer without additional approval. I set the prices myself.”

The last words carried unmistakable pride.

Then she looked at Mona.

“Mona, don’t worry—I’ll curate something for you personally. We’ll discuss it later.”

Mona nodded enthusiastically.

“Thank you, darling!”

She smiled radiantly and blew Zara an air kiss.

A mech assistant drifted into the booth carrying Mona’s salad-still-life balanced on its manipulator like a pedestal display. It lowered the dish onto the table without a sound and withdrew just as quietly.

“The people you were with back then—Fang and Ion,” Art asked. “Have you known them long? They didn’t strike me as being in your professional sphere.”

Zara seemed to have expected the question.

“We’ve known each other for a few months,” she said with a slight shrug. “We collaborate. I help them locate nuggets, and they... shield me from trouble. In certain Variants, as you know, that’s not unnecessary.”

Art nodded.

“And in this... shielding-from-trouble capacity—are they professionals? Or enthusiastic amateurs?”

Zara considered for a moment.

“It wouldn’t be fair to speak of them the same way. Fang and Ion are very different.”

Art inclined his head with polite interest.

“They don’t like to talk about it,” Zara continued, “but I believe Fang is security. Or rather... Ion’s bodyguard. I think he’s responsible for both their safety. And when we’re, as they put it, ‘harvesting’ together—mine as well. Though Ion can certainly take care of himself.”

Art nodded in understanding. Mona added:

“And Ion treats Fang with respect. He doesn’t restrict him. For example...” She hesitated briefly, then went on decisively. “They both tried to court me.”

I couldn’t prevent the sudden pounding in my temples. I lowered my gaze to the table, careful not to let my face betray anything.

“And?” Art asked with a faint smile.

“I don’t enjoy flirting,” Zara replied calmly, confidently. “So I told each of them directly that such behavior was pointless.”

An overwhelming wave of relief washed through me.

“I’m only mentioning this,” Zara continued, “to clarify something. When—let’s say—Fang began showing interest in me, Ion reacted entirely calmly. By that point, he and I had already... discussed matters.”

Another assistant mech entered, this time carrying two dishes—mine and Zara’s. They looked extraordinarily appetizing.

“Repeat my drink, please,” Art said to the mech.

“Of course,” it replied, departing at once.

Zara examined her dish with visible approval and, without further commentary, began eating with evident appetite. I decided it would be wise to follow her example.

The dish placed before me—or rather, the experience of tasting it—was entirely new. It consisted of carefully composed elements of varying forms, textures, and consistencies. Each carried its own distinct flavor, pleasant in its own way, but what astonished me most was the harmony between them. Together they produced the curious sensation of something deeply familiar yet elusive—as if you were tasting something exquisite that you had once known well but could no longer quite name.

At one point I was almost certain I detected the flavor of my famous shepherd’s stew. But no—it was something else entirely. And that “something else” was extraordinarily, exquisitely good.

Mona, I now noticed, had been giving her salad slow, deliberate attention the entire time, selecting individual components with care and occasionally sipping her drink.

“Well,” Art said thoughtfully, leaning back in his chair, “this is interesting. Forgive the questions—if you’d like, I can explain why I’m asking. But just one more: when was the last time you saw them?”

“Yesterday,” Zara replied matter-of-factly, continuing to do justice to her meal.

The three of us froze for a fraction of a second.

The silence was broken by the mech returning with Art’s dish in one manipulator and his drink in the other. It placed them on the table, removed his empty glass, then held a manipulator briefly above the plate. The dish burst into elegant flame—red with fine blue veins. After the fire subsided, the mech slipped back through the holographic wall.

Zara lifted her eyes from the extinguished flames and, noticing our expressions, added lightly:

“We ran into each other yesterday morning. At a... place. Completely by chance, I think. We talked briefly, and then I left—headed straight to the Gate.”

Art turned his knife and fork thoughtfully in his hands, then nodded to some private conclusion and took a bite. After another approving nod, he looked back at Zara.

“May I ask what you were talking about?”

Zara took a sip from her glass.

"The main news. The one all the koyo are buzzing about. The contours."

"Koyo?" I asked.

"Contours?" Art clarified at the same time.

Zara smiled and turned to me first.

"Koyo is what they call themselves—the ones you refer to as the Reds. It means something like 'brothers and sisters.'"

I nodded. She shifted her gaze to Art.

"The news is that, apparently, among those who slide, contour levels decrease over time. Which means that sooner or later, most of them will likely lose the ability to pass through the Gates without boosting."

"What—didn't they know that before?" Art asked, genuinely surprised, pausing mid-bite.

"Maybe they didn't want to know," Zara shrugged. "But when the new Gates appeared with higher threshold, everyone suddenly started checking their contour levels again. And someone noticed that theirs were significantly lower than they used to be."

She paused.

"So now everyone's agitated. And there's a rumor circulating that the Creatures are responsible for all of it. Which means many koyo have suddenly grown hostile toward them."

Zara set her plate aside, took another sip, and placed the glass down carefully.

"And what do Fang and Ion think about that?" Art asked, lifting his eyes from his dish.

"Ion—nothing in particular," Zara replied. "At least he doesn't say anything. As usual, he makes ironic, noncommittal remarks. But Fang..."

She paused.

"Fang says that if he can no longer walk through the Gates, there will be no point in living."

Zara exhaled softly, then looked at Art with steady focus.

"So why are you so interested in them?" she asked. "May I know?"

"Yes, of course," Art replied, pushing his plate aside as well. "After we met that day—later the same day—someone ambushed us. Mac was hit with a freeze. I dodged. Probably just luck."

Zara froze.

For several seconds she did not move at all. Then she slowly turned her gaze to me and looked directly into my eyes. There was unmistakable confusion in her expression. And something else—concern.

She shifted her attention back to Art and said slowly, thoughtfully:

"It couldn't have been Fang and Ion. We were together the entire day. And the following one."

"Is that so? Interesting..." Art answered evenly. "Then it seems I questioned you unnecessarily. My apologies. We're simply trying to take precautions. Perhaps we're worrying for nothing. Or perhaps we're just being overly careful."

Zara fell silent. A taut stillness settled over the table.

"No," she said quietly at last. "I don't think you're worrying for nothing."

She paused again, as if weighing each word.

"In my view, caution never hurts. And right now—especially."

Suddenly she rose.

"You know, I have to go. Thank you for the interesting conversation—and the pleasant company."

I was on my feet instantly. Art stood as well.

"Mona, we'll talk later. Bye," Zara said with a nod.

"Bye..." Mona replied, somewhat stunned.

"Please don't walk me out," Zara added as she moved away, and slipped through the holographic barrier.

I shot Art a panicked look, ready to follow her.

Art raised a hand in quiet warning.

"If she's decided to leave, she'll leave."

I exhaled helplessly, acknowledging the truth of it, and sank back into my chair. Art sat down as well.

For a while, none of us spoke.

Then Art drew a deep breath and said:

"I understand that, strictly speaking, our friendly dinner could be considered over at this point. Still, I'd ask you both to stay a little longer and, so to speak, respond—while everything is still fresh—to two purely practical questions that have arisen."

He looked at us. Mona and I remained silent. Art continued.

"I apologize in advance if my first practical question sounds cynical. Nevertheless—can we trust Zara?"

I snapped my gaze up at him, staring in stunned disbelief.

As if expecting that reaction, Art met my eyes calmly and gave a small, understanding nod.

"All right, Mac. You don't have to answer. I think your reaction is answer enough. Mona?"

Contrary to my expectation, Mona did not respond immediately. She lowered her gaze to the nearly empty glass she still held lightly between her fingertips and remained silent for several moments.

Then, still seemingly thinking it through, she said:

"Your question is clearly driven by the fact that Zara is hiding something."

She looked at Art. He returned her gaze with a slight nod and a satisfied half-smile. Mona nodded in return.

"Granted," she went on. "But at the same time, she is very willing to engage. She answers your questions openly."

"And more than that," Art added, "I have the distinct impression that Zara is eager to tell us as much as possible. More than I'm actually asking."

Mona nodded again.

"And you're suggesting that this might be part of some double—or even triple—game?"

Art spread his hands slightly, as if to say, I don't know what to think.

"No," Mona said firmly. It felt as though she had just arrived at a conclusion after weighing everything carefully. "And not simply because such a scheme would be unnecessarily complicated. It would also be irrational."

Art narrowed his eyes slightly and tilted his head, as if listening not only to her but to his own thoughts.

"A far more natural explanation," Mona continued with steady confidence, "is this: yes, she has something to hide. But whatever it is, it's not directly connected to Ion and Fang, the Reds, or the Tribe. Or perhaps it is connected—but indirectly, without implying that she herself is... culpable. In that case, it's perfectly logical that she would try to dispel any suspicions we might already have—or might develop. To me, that is the simplest and most probable explanation of her behavior."

At this point, Mona glanced at me and added:

"And yes, I liked her very much. So I would rather not discover that we're—let's put it this way—on opposite sides. But that preference has not influenced my analysis or my conclusions."

The last words were directed at Art.

He looked at her with undisguised admiration.

Only then, I think, did I truly understand how he regarded her.

He shifted his gaze to me, smiled broadly, and let out a relieved breath.

"Then we may consider the first question resolved unanimously. And I'm glad we've resolved it. I have a feeling we may need to rely on that decision in the future. Now—on to the second question."

Art took a sip from his glass. His mood seemed noticeably lighter.

"The second question," Art continued, "is whether, in light of the new information we've received from Zara, we should make any adjustments to our plans. Specifically, to Mac's upcoming picking internship. Ultimately, of course, it isn't our decision—but I think our opinion carries weight."

He looked at both of us.

"My view is no—we shouldn't change anything. There's a bit more uncertainty now, yes. But I don't believe it significantly increases the risk level. And in the current situation, what Mac mentioned at the afterparty—information and initiative—becomes even more valuable. What do you think?"

He leaned back in his chair, deliberately not addressing anyone in particular.

I glanced at Mona, preferring that she speak first.

"I agree," she said with a nod. "To me, it's fairly clear. Frankly, the more pressing practical question is how the Reds' shifting mood will affect developments around the Creatures and the Ninth Variant."

Art turned to me.

"I agree as well," I said briefly.

"Excellent," Art concluded. "In that case, I think we can finally call it a night."

Mona and I nodded at the same time.

We rose and headed toward the exit. Cuel appeared ahead of us almost immediately and, seemingly attuned to our mood, escorted us in silence to the door, offering a discreet wish for a pleasant evening only at the threshold. Hearing it, I couldn't suppress a faintly grim smile.

When we entered Tom's cabin, I noticed that the seats were no longer arranged in a circle but all faced forward. The third seat was set behind the other two, like a second row. I understood at once that Art,

sensing my mood, had arranged for a measure of privacy. I thanked him silently and took the rear seat. Art and Mona settled in front.

We did not exchange a single word during the flight back.

Only as the glider began its descent did Art turn toward me.

“Mac, forgive me if this sounds intrusive, but I want to say one thing. I know what you’re thinking—and what you’re planning to do. If you want my opinion, then no—don’t call her right now. And this has nothing to do with pride, dignity, or any of that inflated nonsense. It’s simply that, from what I’ve learned about Zara, she’s the kind of person who decides for herself. Your call—or anything else—won’t influence her decisions.”

At that moment Tom touched down, and the edges of my safety vest slid apart. I stood and looked at Art.

There was no patronizing superiority in his eyes. Only quiet concern.

I smiled.

“Thanks, Art. I’ll think about it.”

He nodded.

“Good night.”

Mona turned toward me as well.

“Good night, Mac.”

I nodded to both of them, stepped down the ramp, and headed toward the house.

...

Half an hour later, I heard the sound of a glider approaching.

I looked out the window and saw a small two-seat cab descending onto the pad in front of my house.

I ran to the door and flung it open.

Zara stood on the threshold.

Holding my gaze steadily, she stepped forward.

Instinctively, I moved back, letting her in.

Zara turned and closed the door behind her.

Chapter 28. False Memory 2: Dragon Wrangler

The flock belonging to our family is, of course, not the largest in the world. Indeed, even within our own principality there are at least two flocks greater than ours, and in neighboring lands there are some whose numbers exceed ours by more than half again.

But we take pride not in quantity, but in the lineage and purity of our dragons. In that regard, our farm has no equal.

The reason is simple: our gorge is wide and generous, with many mesas—"table mountains," as some call them—rock formations crowned with flat plateaus. And most of them are sheltered from the winds. We have caves in abundance as well. Such places—secluded, windless mesas and deep caverns—are precisely where dragons prefer to build their nests. And when dragons are comfortable, their offspring are plentiful and true of blood. That has long been observed.

The same holds for the valley below. It is vast enough to sustain immense herds of livestock. Our sheep and cattle far exceed the needs of the flock, and in the forests that cloak the foothills there is game enough for dragons to hunt their fill.

That is why, in good years, more than a dozen gray dragons hatch under our care—and among them there are always at least two blues of the purest strain. Every two or three years, moreover, a golden beauty appears.

Many tales are told about dragons, most of them nonsense. Among common folk—and even among certain nobles—there persists the belief that when angered, dragons exhale a stream of flame capable of burning to ash anyone in their path.

Such stories arise because rumor has confused two very different things: the dragon's cry and the dragon's spit—and then embroidered the rest, as rumor always does. Both are used only in the hunt. Ordinary people have nothing to fear—unless, God forbid, someone should attempt to harm a dragon. In that case, as the saying goes, he has only himself to blame.

Now then—about the cry and the spit.

All dragons, even the grays, can emit a cry that does not spread in all directions but travels straight ahead—like a beam of light, though invisible. It can deafen, yes—but it can also rob even a great stag of consciousness, which is how dragons bring down their prey. As for a man—well.

And in the hunt a dragon may also release its burning spit. Dragons are, after all, serpents—only with legs and wings. Some serpents spit venom; everyone knows this and finds nothing remarkable in it. A dragon's saliva is not venomous, but caustic—like acid. It burns.

It also glows in the dark. That serves a purpose: by night, a dragon marks its prey and may then pursue it at leisure, without distraction. Someone must once have seen that luminous spray in the darkness and, not understanding what he witnessed, invented the fable of fire.

As for flying a dragon—truly flying, that is, in a saddle fastened at the base of the neck, where one may guide it, rather than merely sitting beneath a canopy between its wings—that privilege belongs only to the one who has saddled it.

And saddling does not mean placing the saddle upon its back. No. First one must leap upon the dragon, seize its neck, and hold fast while it tries with all its might to throw you. If you endure—then it is yours. It will know you for the rest of its life and heed you as well.

Unlike a horse, which any man may break and which will then obey any rider, a dragon obeys only the one who mastered it. And only we—the wranglers—are permitted to attempt such mastery.

Not everyone may become a wrangler. Many who try to saddle a dragon fail the first time—and are thrown. Then a man either dies upon the rocks or is left maimed for life. That is why we are respected. And paid well.

The pay matters less to me than to most of our lads. I was born into a prosperous family: my father owns the dragon farm, as well as the gorge and valley that surround it. Yet little of that wealth is destined for me. I am my father's fifth son—and the youngest. I have three sisters as well, all older than I.

When our dragons reach maturity, we sell them at the fairs. Not all, of course—some of the finest we may keep. Any wrangler has the right to keep the dragon that he chooses—that is our custom. And there is no companion more faithful than a dragon. I do not believe that even two men may share a bond stronger than that between a dragon and its rider.

And it is easy to befriend a dragon. For dragons understand every human word.

Perhaps not only words.

Perhaps they sense the thoughts left unspoken.

For my part, I believe they do. I have seen proof of it more than once.

Now then—about the fairs where we sell our dragons.

They are held in the nearest city, twice a year—once in spring and once in autumn. The fairs are, without question, the most exciting thing in a wrangler's life—save for the dragons themselves, of course. They are our chance to show ourselves, to learn something of the wider world, and to celebrate properly. That is why we—lads and lasses alike, for there are women among the wranglers, though not many—await each fair as one awaits a festival.

We also make our purchases there. One can always find the finest goods at the fair. From the dwarves—for that is what the master craftsmen of the high mountains call themselves—we buy all our dragon gear: saddles, canopies, harness. They live high among the peaks, mine the ores, and in matters of craft they have no equals. From them we purchase what our dragons require—and for ourselves as well: tools, mostly, and hunting weapons.

From the elves—the tribes who dwell in the forests at the foot of our mountains—we obtain remedies and elixirs, both for our own use and for the dragons'.

As I have said, when we travel to the city for the fair, we learn much of the distant world. Merchants who gather there from many lands are fond of telling tales in the evenings, in the taverns, over a cup of wine or a mug of ale—stories of the places where their trade has taken them.

And then there are the warlocks. Who else?

Warlocks travel often—mostly to visit one another, to exchange their arts, though they wander for other reasons as well. Yet their knowledge of far-off lands does not come merely from their journeys. It comes from their enchanted amulets—the Emerald Eyes, for instance.

I have seen one of those with my own eyes. It appeared to be nothing more than a clear sphere, about the size of a large apple—or perhaps a small pumpkin. At its very center was set a great emerald.

A dwarf I once knew—who had been caught in an avalanche and whom I happened, by fortune, to pull free with my dragon—told me later, in confidence, that it is the dwarves who craft these Emerald Eyes for the warlocks. They shape them from a special mountain crystal, and within it, he said, is fused not only a true emerald but countless filaments of some rare metal—dearer, he claimed, even than gold.

Such a sphere can show a warlock distant places.

And what they see, they sometimes share with us.

I once heard a warlock speak of far-off valley lands—great open steppes—where nomadic tribes dwell. Orcs, they are called. They herd horses and other livestock, and they raid neighboring peoples as well.

One detail of that tale has stayed with me. The warlock said that just as we fly upon dragons—or ride horses and unicorns—so the orcs ride great wolves.

They call them khan-wolves—“kings of wolves.”

They are the size of a calf and known for their strength, speed, and ferocity. At a master’s command, such a wolf can tear a man apart, and none can stand against them. And as with dragons, a khan-wolf has but one master—the one who tamed it as a cub and raised it in a particular way.

Some say these are only stories.

Yet I find I believe them.

I trust the warlocks. One can see in their eyes that they know things beyond the reach of ordinary men.

When one of the Gyres appeared not far from our gorge, and the Undead began to emerge from it, and Blizzards started breaking out around it, we did not yet know that ours was not the only such place in the world—that there were seven more besides. It was the warlocks who later explained all this to us. It was they who gave them their names—the Gyres, the Undead, the Blizzards.

The warlocks told the people that all of it was born of otherworldly witchcraft, and that only they possessed the power to contend with it. That is why they forbid folk from approaching the Gyres.

But not everyone listens.

There are always those—among the nobility and the merchant houses alike—who wish to see a Gyre with their own eyes, to pass through it and return. They say it strengthens the body. Restores vigor.

That, at least, I do not believe.

I have passed through the Gyre myself more than once. It left me no stronger than before. As for my health—I suppose that, too, remained much the same.

Still, neither I nor any of ours trouble ourselves with correcting such beliefs. For the Gyre has brought us profit.

It lies high in the mountains, and the path to it on foot is long and wearisome. Worse still, a man may be caught in a Blizzard out in the open—and I know of nothing more dreadful than that.

On dragonback, however, one can reach the Gyre from our farm in less than an hour. And should a Blizzard rise, a dragon can gain the cliffs in moments and find shelter among the rocks.

So it came to pass that we began, for a generous fee, to carry nobles and wealthy folk to the Gyre upon our dragons.

One of us rides in the saddle and guides the beast, while the passenger sits beneath the canopy between its wings. We strap them in well with leather belts, so they do not fall mid-flight and dash themselves against the cliffs. The coin from this trade now rivals what we earn from the sale of dragons themselves.

And another source of income came to our farm, also because of the Gyre.

Some three years after its appearance, my father acquired a partner. The man, one might say, bought a share in the farm. In truth, he paid a great sum for the right to use our dragons—for himself and his companions, whoever they may be—to fly the gorge and search for... something.

By agreement with my father, he always has ten gray dragons and two blues at his disposal. From time to time—usually after a Blizzard—he flies to the Gyre for two or three days and meets his people there.

How they get to the Gyre, and what they do there—we do not know.

Nor is it our concern.

Those who live upon farms do not care to thrust their noses into other men's affairs.

And so this is how we live now: we breed dragons, saddle them, and take them to the fairs. And we carry the curious to the Gyre.

And as for me—if a man may choose his lot in this world, then to be a wrangler of dragons is life enough.

Epilogue

Art and I were sitting on the grass, leaning back against our packs, resting after the crossing. Not far from us, the other striders from Ellen's team had settled in much the same way.

In the distance, among the rocks, I spotted a flock of dragons emerging and heading in our direction.

We had just passed through the Seventh Gates into the Second Variant, where my first picking was about to take place—my first as a full-fledged strider, an ARC agent. At the same time, this operation was also, in a sense, a layered ambush designed by Ellen and Norton, aimed at actively countering the Pride's escalating aggression.

The journey to the Seventh Gates had taken almost the entire night, which gave Ellen time to conduct the snap in virtual format during the flight. There she walked us through the operational plan. To me, the plan felt less like an ambush and more like a form of fishing—or perhaps hunting large predators—where a harmless fish, bird, or small animal is placed in plain sight in hopes of attracting something eager to devour it.

In this case, that living bait was yours truly.

Strangely enough, that fact did not trouble me. On the contrary—something very much like this was exactly what I needed in my current state of mind.

That mood had been shaped by what happened yesterday.

When I woke—well past noon—Zara was no longer beside me. I jumped out of bed and ran into the living room. She wasn't there. Her tiny cab was gone from the landing pad.

I rushed to my mask and clip.

In my inbox I found a single message, sent at 05:17—apparently shortly after I had drifted off beside her, noticing through the window-wall of my bedroom the first pale hints of dawn. Nearly eight hours before this moment.

The message was brief:

"I'll return."

I immediately called her ID and received the response I had already expected:

"The user with this ID is currently not connected to the Net."

Art called some time later. From certain cues—ones I couldn't even define—he seemed to understand what had likely happened and what was still happening. He didn't press himself on me. He simply asked me not to remove my mask or clip so I wouldn't miss the picking call, and then he disconnected.

The next hours I spent either lying on the bed staring at the ceiling or wandering aimlessly from room to room. I replayed our conversation at the restaurant again and again, along with everything that had followed. Of course, I wanted to dwell only on what came after her midnight arrival—but I forced myself to focus on what actually mattered.

I tried to understand what had happened. Where Zara had gone. Why she had chosen to leave the way she did.

And, inevitably, I worried about her.

So when the picking call came at 01:37, I felt relief more than excitement.

Art picked me up seven minutes later, and Big Tom set a course for the opposite side of the Earth—to the Seventh Gates.

Now, remembering all of it again, I took a deep breath and made an effort to shift my attention to something more immediate.

I thought about how the second crossing had felt. This time it had been much easier. Apparently my body already knew what to expect and had prepared itself on some subconscious level. I was recovering faster now. I felt almost fully steady again.

Art turned toward me.

“Well, Mac—even if this picking is formally still your internship, I think everyone—including me—considers you a real strider now. One of us. So—congratulations.”

“Thank you, Art,” I said sincerely. “If it weren’t for you, none of this would have happened to me.”

He grew thoughtful.

“You know,” he said slowly, watching the dragons drawing nearer, “sometimes I have the feeling that everything that’s happened since the day the new Gates appeared—it’s like a performance unfolding on a stage under the direction of some unseen producer. And you and I—we’re just characters in the show.”

He paused for a moment, then shifted into a lighter tone.

“But that’s poetry. Right now we’ve got work to do. And we might as well try to do it well.”

We rose to our feet and moved forward.

In the clearing before us, proud and graceful, magnificent dragons were landing.